



THE LONG GRACE

PLATES OF THE TABLE

HEADER ART BIBLE · GODS & PLACES

FORTY-SIX PLATES · ONE FRAME · NO RESCUE

NOTHING WAS WASTED. NOT THE HOOVES, NOT
THE HIDE, NOT THE EYES.

[CARVED OVER THE WEIGHHOUSE DOOR, SATED]

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CHAPTER 1

PLATES OF THE TABLE

The Header Art Bible

We do not paint the god. We paint the plate it was served on, and let you imagine the rest.

– NOTE PINNED ABOVE A CUTWRIGHT ILLUMINATOR'S DESK, QUIRE



This book defines the **header plates** of *The Long Grace*: wide 3:1 title images for the setting's gods and places, all set in one shared frame so the books, handouts, screens and online pages read as a single object.

Each entry in the following chapters gives you two things:

- ◇ **The plate as it stands.** A finished title plate: the shared gold frame, the land's sigil, and the title lettering, over an ink-and-fog scene drawn in code. These are usable now for chapter headers, slides, a virtual table or printed handouts.
- ◇ **The brief for the painting it is waiting for.** A cinematic art brief for a painter or an image model: the shot, the light, the

textures, the story in the frame, the hidden details a sharp-eyed player could find, and a ready-to-use prompt with a negative prompt. The style follows the references the plates were designed against: dark painterly brushwork, heavy black space, near-monochrome with one accent colour per land, and body horror rendered close and intimate.

When a painting is commissioned, set it under the frame overlay supplied with the plates ('_frame_overlay_blank.png'), keep the lower centre band dark and calm for the title, and the new plate will match every other plate in the set.

▼ THE FRAME

Every plate uses exactly the same frame and title treatment. Do not vary it.

ELEMENT	SPECIFICATION
Canvas	2400 × 800 px (3:1); safe area inset 60 px
Outer rule	2.2 px gold #b79c63, inset 26 px
Inner rule	1.2 px dim gold #7d6a45, inset 44 px, diamond at each inner corner, short gold bars beside each corner
Sigil notch	140 px gap at top centre; land sigil in light gold #d8bf86, line-drawn
Kicker	THE LONG GRACE · LAND, Josefin Sans 400, 17 px, tracking 9
Title	Josefin Sans Light 300, 70 px, all capitals, tracking 22, light gold, centred at y 652
Rule	dim gold line either side of centre with three small diamonds, y 684
Subtitle	Cormorant Garamond italic, 34 px, parchment #cfc4ad, y 726
Title band	soft black ellipse behind the lettering; keep the painting quiet here

▼ THE PALETTE

LAND	ACCENT	GROUND
Sallowreach	bruise green, fly black	tea-stain sepia, fog
The Fatlands	raw meat red, tallow yellow	warm brown-black
Brinehollow	drowned teal, salt white	slate, black water
The Vigil	lamp amber	smoke, soot
Cradlewrack	wet iron red, clay	red-black
Oathen	canyon ochre, dried blood	rust, shadow
The Fast	candle gold (the only warm, kind light)	dusk brown
The Table, the Eighth	bone white	pure black

HOW TO USE THE BRIEFS

- ◇ **For artists:** read *The Shot*, *Light and Colour* and *Texture and Flesh* first; *The Story in the Frame* tells you what the moment means; *Hidden Details* are the things players will look for.
- ◇ **For image models:** use the *Painter's Prompt* and *Negative* as written, at a 3:1 aspect ratio, then place the result under the blank frame overlay.
- ◇ **For the Carver:** read *The Story in the Frame* aloud when the Guests first arrive somewhere. Every brief is also a location description.



CHAPTER 2

THE TABLE AND ITS GODS

These are the first nine plates of the set, and the ones every other plate answers to. The land plates show the Table as its peoples live in it now: the fens, the plains, the drying coast, the lit city, the clay, the canyons, the empty middle. The god plates show what those peoples ate to get there. Every god in this chapter was a body. It had a temperature, a smell, a weight that pressed the ground flat, a way of breathing that was the weather of its country. The painter's first job is to make the viewer believe that, because the whole horror of *The Long Grace* rests on it: these were not ideas that died. They were neighbours, and they were carved.

Each plate keeps the shared frame: the thin gold double-line border, the diamond corners, the land's sigil in the notch at top centre, the title in widely spaced light capitals and the italic subtitle in the lower centre band. Keep that band dark and quiet in every composition. The god is never in it. The god is always just above it,

or to one side of it, looking at it, the way a dish looks at whoever is sitting down.

Plates two to seven each pick one of two moments: the night of the eating, from inside the crowd, or the god's Regrowth now, as it pulls itself back together out of its people. Plate eight shows the one god still walking. Plate nine shows a gap.

Painters should read **The Story in the Frame** first. It holds the god's whole body as its people knew it, and none of it is metaphor.



*We did not pray to them. You do not pray to a
mountain.*

GRANDFATHER PEAT, AS INTERPRETED, LASTGATE,
640 A.G.

▼ THE LONG GRACE



◇
In the Long Grace, my grandmother kept bees.

OVERHEARD AT FOGMOUTH; THE SPEAKER'S
GRANDMOTHER IS STILL LIVING

Plate: The Long Grace · *The Table, six hundred and forty-one years after the meal* · The Table · bone-white on pure black

THE SHOT

An impossible height, but not a map. The camera stands on the last broken shoulder of the salt wastes beyond the eastern rim, far above the canyons, on a 24mm lens tilted slightly down, so the whole continent lies before us under night the way a plate lies before someone who has just sat down. The Table is round, nine hundred miles across, and from here it is seen as an ellipse foreshortened into the 3:1 frame, its far edge curving off into the black at both sides. The left third holds Brinehollow and Cradlewrack: the western coast a bone-pale crust where the sea has pulled back, the Uncovered glittering like spilled sugar. The right third holds the near ground: the lip of Oathen's canyons cracking away under the camera like the rim of a dropped dish, ink-black fissures running toward us. The centre third is the Fast: a disc of perfect, empty black, the hole the ring of lands is built around. The Rim Road circles it as a thin unbroken line of tiny lamp-points, the inns lit for the night, a necklace laid around nothing. Fog lies over Sallowreach at the top of the frame as a grey film; the Vigil is a smudge of soot-light at upper right. Exactly at the centre of the black disc, very small, is one point of light that is not a lamp. The Plate, the moon, hangs full and low at upper left, enormous, its face scored with faint marks like knife-scratches on pewter. The lower centre band, where the title sits, is the dark southern Fast and the Hem of the Rim Road: calm, black, unlit.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Two lights only. The full Plate rakes the continent from upper left, cold, bone-white, catching every ridge and salt-flat and leaving the hollows absolute black. The Rim Road lamps are pinpoints, the same bone-white, no warmth allowed, so the ring reads as stitches rather than comfort. The single point at Hallowboard is the only exception and it must be ambiguous: almost white, perhaps a breath of warmth, small enough that a viewer is not sure they saw it. No other colour. No sky gradient; the black above the horizon is the same black as the Fast.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Paint the land as a carcass that has healed badly. The canyons in the foreground are dry-brushed scar tissue, the stone flaking in layers like old fat on a cold joint. Ridges radiate outward from the middle the way ribs radiate from a spine, faint, never stated, only felt in the dry-brush direction of the strokes. The salt of the Uncovered is scumbled thick and cracked, like the glaze on a dish left in an oven too long. The fog over the fens has the texture of a cataract. The black of the Fast is not flat: it is laid in many thin glazes so it has depth, wet and endless, like the inside of a mouth seen from far away. Ink spatter drifts across the upper sky like crumbs, which is what the Table calls stars.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

This is the Table now, in 641 A.G., seen as nobody on it ever sees it: whole, at once, from the outside, on the night before something. Six peoples live on this rim of land around an empty middle, each in the country where it ate its god, each carrying that god in its blood as a set of Cuts. They trade with one another along the Rim Road, which runs two thousand four hundred miles around the Hem and never crosses in. They say *Lack keep away* before eating with strangers, and none of them knows who the grace is addressed to. They are all, at this moment, sick with the same thing at the same speed, and each government is hiding its numbers.

The image must feel like a table laid and waiting. The continent is round because a plate is round. The Rim Road is the gold rim of the china. The lands are the courses set around it, and the black disc of the Fast is the bare place at the middle where the dish will go. Everything on the Table has been eaten once already; the viewer should feel that it is about to be served again.

What happened just before this moment is six hundred and forty-one years of digestion. What happens next is the end of the Grace: the College's graphs bent upward in every land after 600, all at once, which is impossible if the Regrowths are separate things. The gods are getting up. The point of light at Hallowboard is the Host, awake, laying a table. Nothing else in the frame is moving, but the painter should make it feel as if the whole continent has just, very slightly, been turned toward someone.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The Rim Road lamps are not evenly spaced. Counted, the clusters at the great inns form seven groups; there is an eighth gap on the ring between the Fast-side of Sallowreach and the Hem near Wanting, where no inn has ever stood. Players who count chairs will find the count never closes.
- ◇ The scratches on the face of the Plate, read at a slant, are a knife and fork laid side by side, the way a diner signals that they have not finished.
- ◇ The faint ribs in the land converge not on Hallowboard but a hair to one side of it: on the eighth side of the stone table.
- ◇ At the far western edge, out past the Uncovered on the drained seabed, there is one tiny rectangular shadow: Cray Lobbett's table, with a single long shadow cast from one of its chairs.
- ◇ A line of very small pale marks crosses the western sea toward the coast like footprints on wet sand. It runs in, not out.
- ◇ The fog over Sallowreach has a gap in it shaped like a pair of open hands.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

A vast cinematic 3:1 night panorama from an impossible high cliff at the edge of a salt wasteland, looking down across a whole round continent laid out like a plate: cracked canyon rim in the black foreground, a pale coast crusted with salt at left, grey fog over fens at top, a thin glittering ring of tiny inn lamps circling a perfectly black empty heartland at the centre, one minute ambiguous light at its exact middle; an enormous low full moon at upper left scored with faint knife-scratches; strictly bone-white on pure black, near-monochrome, dark oil painting with dry-brush and ink-wash texture, land rendered like healed scar tissue and faint radiating ribs, ink spatter for stars, huge negative space, the lower centre left dark and calm for a title, quiet dread, a world waiting to be served.

Negative: bright colours, blue sky, sunrise, cartoon, fantasy map labels, compass rose, legible text, modern objects, satellites, city

lights grid, clean digital gloss, lens flare, saturated green, cheerful mood, visible gods, figures in foreground

▼ OSSEL, THE CLOSING HAND



The Hand did not stop us. It only reached over our heads, now and then, to close the eyes of the ones we were too slow for.

THE CORSE TELLING, AS KEPT IN THE LOFTS

Plate: Ossel, the Closing Hand · *God of death and endings* · Sallowreach · bruise-green and fly-black on tea-stain sepia

THE SHOT

Eye level of a standing fen-woman, slightly below, on a 35mm lens, the camera among the crowd and shouldering through it, so the first plane is the backs of the starving: ragged hoods, bone-knives held low, sharp shoulder-blades under wet cloth, out of focus and almost black. The left third is Ossel's length running away from us into the fog along the reed-bank below what will be Lastgate: a grey shape like a fallen ash tree as long as a road, half sunk in black water, its far end lost. The centre third, upper half, is the moment of the plate: one of the great hands lifted off the peat, slow as a heron, reaching over the heads of the crowd, a fingertip the size of a loaf descending toward something small and wrapped that a mother holds at the back of the throng. The fingers are too long and have too many joints, nine and ten each. In the midground below the hand, on the bank, an old woman sits in a reed hurdle with her mouth working: Agna Corse, eating the last joint of the smallest finger. The right third is the fire and, beyond it, across black water, the empty bank on the far side: reeds, fog, and a place where the fog bends around nothing, very tall, sitting. One small boy at the extreme right edge of the crowd is turned away from the god, staring at that bank. The lower centre band is the black water and the crowd's backs: dark, still, unreadable.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The fire at right is the key light, low and sepia, throwing the crowd into silhouette and catching the underside of the lifted hand from below so its palm glows like old tallow. Cold fog-light from above flattens everything else to tea-stain brown and grey. The accent is bruise-green, sparing; in the cut flesh where the finger-joint came away, in the lips of the families who have eaten from the hands, in a faint sheen on the black water. Fly-black is the darkest value: the crowd, the far reeds, the hollow inside the fog on the empty bank.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Ossel's skin is grey the way fog is grey, finely ridged like a fingernail, dry-looking but beaded with condensation. Where the knives have gone in, the flesh beneath is cold and pale and wet, the texture of a cellar mushroom, and the paint should look chilled: no warmth in the reds at all, only a bruised lilac-green going to grey at the edges. Knuckle joints lie open on the peat, small and white, many to a finger, each cracked clean like the hinge of a box. The fen-folk's knives are ground from cattle shoulder-blades and still show the bone grain. Their lips are grey by the light. Breath does not smoke from the mouths of the ones who have eaten most. The peat is black and glistening, studded with tiny fired-clay votive hands, palms up. Flies hang in the fog in a fine drift, motionless, as if they too were waiting.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Ossel lay in the northern fens for as long as anyone remembered, long and grey and still as a fallen ash, half in the black water and half on the bank. It had a body, but the fen never really looked at the body; it looked at the hands. They were enormous, each wide enough to cup a cottage, and they lay open on the peat, palms up, and they were the only part of the god that ever moved. The fingers had nine and ten joints apiece. The face, which few paintings show, was a long grey oval low to the water, lidded, patient, more like the idea of a face than a face. It smelled of cellars and turned earth and

the inside of a closed box. When someone died, their kin carried them on a reed hurdle and laid them within reach, and talked to them of eel-traps and courting until the hand came, and closed their eyes and mouth and folded their arms. Then the body went into the Sweetwaters and was clean in a season. People who lived beside Ossel were calm about everything.

This plate is the first night of the eating, in the ninth year of the Lack. The fen-folk stood around their god for hours with knives and could not begin. While they stood, children at the back of the crowd died of hunger, and each time the hand lifted over everyone's heads and closed the child's eyes with one fingertip. Show only the lifted hand and the small wrapped shape it reaches for; never the child. It did that eleven times before ninety-year-old Agna Corse asked her grandson to cut her the last joint of the smallest finger, because she would not last till morning and would like to have eaten something. She is eating it now, raw, with her gums. She is, by some accounts, still upright in a Lastgate loft.

What happens next: the fen eats slowly, ashamed, all night, and the families who take the hands become the Hand-lines. The boy at the edge of the frame runs into the fen before dawn and the water takes him; he is Grandfather Peat. He says the god was smiling. In the painting, Ossel's low grey face, half turned toward the empty bank, should be doing something at the corners of its mouth that a viewer cannot quite name.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The left thumb's last joint lies on the peat untouched, already beginning to curl closed, as if holding something very small. It is the one piece nobody would take.
- ◇ Twelve tiny clay votive hands lie in the peat near the mother; one has two thumbs. Twelve children, eleven closings: the Tasker twins went in one breath, under one fingertip.
- ◇ On the far bank, the reeds are bent outward in a ring around an empty space, as if something large were sitting there and the reeds were giving it room.
- ◇ Agna Corse's grandson's knife hand is already grey to the wrist. He will be sunk in the Sump for five hundred years.
- ◇ One huge fingernail on the right hand has been half pared away: the slate-sized nail later kept in the Hall of Closings.
- ◇ The boy staring at the far bank is the only figure in the crowd whose breath smokes.

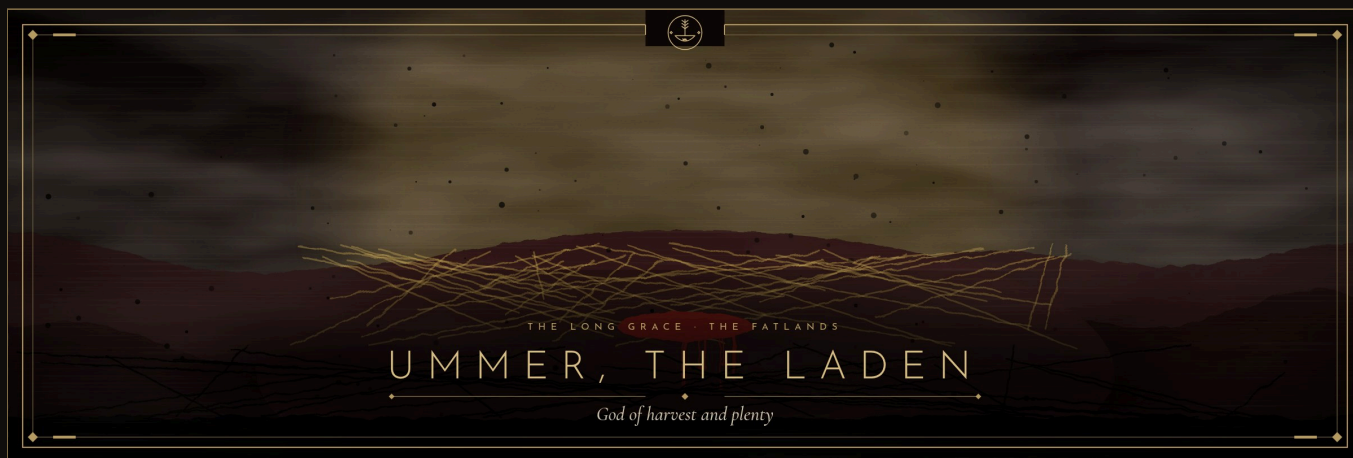
PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 night scene in a fog-drowned fen, shot from inside a crowd of starving peasants seen from behind as black silhouettes with bone knives; an immense grey god lies half sunk in black water like a fallen ash tree, its colossal open hands on the peat, fingers with too many joints; one hand lifts slowly over the crowd, a loaf-sized fingertip descending toward a small wrapped bundle a mother holds; an ancient toothless woman eats a pale severed finger-joint in the foreground; across a low fire, an empty reed-bank where

the fog bends around something unseen and tall; tea-stain sepia and grey with bruise-green accent in cut flesh and grey lips, fly-black shadows, oil and ink texture, cold chilled flesh rendered like mushroom and cellar stone, lower centre left dark for title.

Negative: bright colours, warm red blood, cartoon, visible child faces, gore on children, heroic poses, armour, text artefacts, modern objects, clean digital gloss, sunny sky, saturated green grass, glowing magic effects, monster teeth on the god

▼ UMMER, THE LADEN



*We ate the god and the god watched us do it, kindly,
the way a mother watches. That is the part I cannot
forgive it for.*

GRACE-KEEPER AMITY ROWLE OF DIMBLE, 590 A.G.

Plate: Ummer, the Laden · *God of harvest and plenty* · Fatlands · raw meat red and tallow yellow

THE SHOT

Low and close, almost lying in the grain, a 28mm lens at knee height on the great threshing floor at Brawn Tilt, the place the south now calls the Trencher. The god fills the frame from edge to edge like a fallen barn. The left third is its head, resting on the floor-stones, enormous and soft, one huge clouded eye open toward the camera and the mouth carved by nature into the smile every corn-dolly copies. In the near left foreground a woman sits in the hollow under its jaw with a baby, chewing. The centre third is the flank, opened: people with their faces in its side, arms buried to the shoulder, ribs prised apart and meat handed back over heads into the dark. The belly has been opened and grain is pouring out in a hot wave, knee-deep, spilling toward the camera across the stones, and in the grain are small white things like teeth. The right third holds the hind quarters and, behind them, the black fields of the plains under a starless sky. In the midground right a drover sits in the grain eating while his wife, behind him, stitches his split belly closed with a harness needle. In the far background, barely visible against the dark field, there is one figure standing upright and still, close to the god's rump, with its hand resting on the Laden's back. The lower centre band is the spill of grain and grease in deep shadow: textured, calm, dark.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Torches stuck in the grain, many of them, low and smoky, throw a greasy amber light upward across the flank. The accents are both land colours and they should feel edible: tallow yellow in the fat layer and the grain, raw meat red in the open flesh and the gravy running between the floor-stones. Everything else is near-monochrome umber and black. The god's eye catches one cold point of light that is not torchlight. The sky is black, and the smoke from the torches hangs in it like steam over a pie.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Ummer's hide is earth and bark and pelt at once: a furrowed crust like a loaf's, matted with thistle-down, with wheat-stubble growing out of it in places like the hair on a knuckle. Under the crust is a hand's depth of yellow fat, glossy, warm, beaded, and under the fat is dense dark meat bleeding gravy that steams in the cold. Paint the opened flank thickly, impasto, so the fat looks like it would give under a thumb. The grain spilling out is hot, gold, clotted with grease; the small white teeth in it are rendered exactly like husks until you look. Faces of the eaters are slick to the eyebrows. The drover's wound is a dark line with grain running from it into his lap, the waxed thread pulling it shut. Grease shines on every floor-stone like a wet road.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Ummer was the one god that walked. It was a vast, slow, broad-backed shape like a laden haywain made of earth and bark and pelt, the size of a barn, head always down, ambling across the southern plains, and the fields bowed toward it as it passed and rose up heavier behind it. Its legs were thick as granary posts, its feet broad as carts and soft-soled, and its footprints never failed a seed. It shed a warm, faintly sweet down in Carving that the women spun into swaddling. Its face was long and gentle, an ox's face crossed with a loaf's, with clouded kind eyes and a wide mouth that always seemed to be smiling. It smelled the way an oven smells when you open it.

Children rode on its back the length of the parish at Harvest Home. It was the most loved of the gods and the most taken for granted.

This plate is the last evening of the ninth Carving, when Ummer came in off the stubble and lay down on the threshing floor like an ox that has decided. There was no ceremony and no first cut. The starving went toward the smell on hands and knees and bit it. The Gut-line families were nearest the belly and opened it, and the floor was knee-deep in grain. Kell Sowerby is eating until his belly splits, and his wife is stitching him while he eats; he will live to ninety and never once feel full. The woman under the jaw is chewing meat and giving it to her baby with her tongue; that baby's descendants sit on the Board of Plenty.

The god's eye is open. It has been open the whole time. It is watching them the way a mother watches. Paint the eye so the viewer cannot look away from it, and cannot find any reproach in it. By dawn there will be nothing but grease and grain and people asleep in it with their mouths still moving, and around noon they will notice that the hunger has not stopped. It never has. Now, in 641, Ummer is regrowing in the Laden, and the Fatlands say the land will one day stand up and walk.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The figure standing behind the god's hindquarters, hand on its back, appears in every surviving Fatlands procession frieze. Nobody has ever named it. Its face is turned not toward the feast but toward the empty fields.
- ◇ Among the white teeth in the grain, one is clearly a human milk-tooth. The Fatlands wheat that grows teeth before ears started here.
- ◇ A corn-dolly lies trampled in the grease, its red-thread mouth stitched wider than any made before the Gorging.
- ◇ The harness needle in the wife's hand is the heirloom the Sowerby grandchildren still show at weddings.
- ◇ One forefoot is folded under the body; the other is pressed into the clay just outside the floor, making the last footprint, the one that never dries.
- ◇ The god's mouth is not quite closed. Between its lips, in the shadow, a little grain is still being offered outward, as if it were trying to feed them too.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark oil-painted 3:1 low-angle scene on a torchlit stone threshing floor at night: an immense gentle barn-sized god made of earth, bark and pelt lies on its side, its kind clouded eye open and watching, its wide mouth smiling, while a starving crowd tears into its opened flank with bare hands and faces; a hand-thick layer of glossy yellow fat over dark bleeding meat, a hot wave of grain pouring from the opened belly across the stones, small white teeth hidden among the husks; a drover eats while his wife stitches his split belly with a harness needle; a still figure stands far behind the god, hand on its back; near-monochrome umber with raw meat red and tallow

yellow accents, thick impasto fat, smoky torchlight, grease shine, lower centre left dark for title.

Negative: bright colours, clean butchery, cartoon, cute animal, gore on children, baby in danger, modern farm equipment, text artefacts, clean digital gloss, daylight, blue sky, heroic composition, glowing magic, sexualised figures

▼ DROMM, THE FATHOM



The sea gave back every one of them that night. It has not given back one since.

LOWMARK TIDE · POST INSCRIPTION, CUT 118 A.G.

Plate: Dromm, the Fathom · *God of the deep and what is kept under* · Brinehollow · drowned teal and salt-white

THE SHOT

From the water, at the level of a man in a rowing boat, on a 50mm lens with the horizon set high, looking up the shingle at Longslab on the third evening of the hauling. The foreground is surf and rope: ten thousand lines running out of the black water up the beach, taut, singing, hands wrapped in sailcloth gripping them, and a boat's gunwale cutting the bottom left corner. The left third is the shore crowd hauling, bent nearly double, their mouths open, threads of blood running from their ears down their jaws. The centre third, rising out of the shallows and onto the stones, is Dromm: a grey, slick mass like a reef that breathes, the size of a hill, no face anywhere on it, its skin moving in long slow ripples like the water it has left. The hooks are sunk in it by the thousand, and on the barbs, caught in the god's hide, are the drowned it kept: bundles of bone wrapped in weed, white dough-soft bodies swollen out of their clothes, one fresh, his eyes open, his hair moving in the wash as if nodding. The right third is the beach where the drowned have been laid out in long rows on the shingle, covered with sail, and beyond them the Lung-line families have already cut in under the god's ribs and stand chest-deep in a gush of brine pouring from it. The sea in the background is pulling back from under the boats. The lower centre band is the wet foreground surf, dark and even, with the ropes fading into it.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

A low sullen dusk from behind the camera, out over the sea, almost gone, giving everything a cold flat sheen. The accent is drowned teal: in the deep water, in the shadows under the god's ripples, in the faces of the long-drowned. Salt-white for the foam, the swollen bodies, the crust drying on the hauling ropes and on the hauler's beards. Lantern-wax gleams faintly on the face of the freshest drowned man, the last warm note in the image, almost gone. The sky above is the colour of a gutted fish's belly.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Dromm's skin is the texture of wet slate and deep-sea fish together: slick, grey, mottled with barnacle-crust and pale lice, the ripples across it painted as long liquid strokes. Where the hooks go in, the hide puckers like a lip. The cut under the ribs reveals lungs the size of chapels, folded grey sponge running with cold water, glossy and swollen. The drowned are rendered with tenderness rather than gore: weed knotted in ribs, skin like soaked bread, lips gone pale blue, fingers wrinkled to the bone. The haulers' ears bleed in fine threads, the blood diluted pink by spray. Brine crusts every surface white. The shingle steams faintly where the god's water runs over it. The sea-water pooling around it is thick and slow, like oil.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Nobody living ever saw more than Dromm's back: a long grey reef far out past the shelf that broke the surface on the stillest days and breathed. Its whole body, as the coast learned when they dragged it up, was a heaving mass the size of a hill, grey and slick, with no face anyone could find, no eyes, no mouth that opened; it was all pressure and patience, ridged with old barnacles, and its slow breathing sounded like surf turned inside out. It held the drowned. The coast rowed their dead out with lanterns and let them down on weighted ropes over the deep place, and Dromm kept them, along with every secret ever sealed in a bottle and dropped into *the Keep*. Divers who went near it came up with nosebleeds and the feeling of

being enormously, patiently watched. Storms broke on its back before they reached the shore.

It would not come up on its own. This plate is the third evening of the hauling, when the coast finally dragged it onto the shingle at Longslab with ten thousand hooks hammered from door-hinges and pot-handles. The sea fought for it: the water thickened until boats could not row, and pressed the ears of the haulers until they bled. On the second day the hooks began bringing up the drowned, caught in the god's hide, and the coast laid them out in rows and later, when hungry enough, did not look at the rows. A woman at the third rope sees her husband come up nine years drowned and not a day changed, and does not let go.

What happens next: the god takes four days to stop moving, and the people do not wait. A girl puts her head inside a lung-lobe to drink, hears the sea from the inside talking, and walks into the water a week later, the first of the Called. On the fourth night the whole coast wakes coughing salt. Now, in 641, the sea is leaving the coast and going into the Tenanted, because Dromm is gathering itself back together, and when the last of the sea has gone in it will rise from the Trench as it was dragged from it.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The woman at the third rope has a ring tattooed on her breastbone, nine short strokes pointing inward, the old coast mark of Dromm.
- ◇ Among the hooks in the god's hide is a green glass bottle sealed with pitch, caught by its neck. Its family seal is legible to anyone who knows the Admiralty's rolls.
- ◇ Each breath the god takes shows in the image as the waterline drawn back a little further from under the boats: there are three faint tide-marks on the shingle, each lower than the last.
- ◇ One of the drowned in the rows on the beach has turned its head to face the sea.
- ◇ The lung-drinker girl is visible at the far right, her hair soaked, looking west with a small, pleased expression.
- ◇ Far out on the horizon, where the sea is drawing back, there is a flat dark shape just breaking the surface, square-edged, too regular to be rock.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 seascape at dusk, viewed from a rowing boat in the surf: thousands of taut ropes and iron hooks drag a colossal faceless grey sea-god like a breathing reef up onto a shingle beach, its slick barnacled skin rippling like water; the hooks bring up the long-drowned caught in its hide, weed-wrapped skeletons and pale swollen bodies, one freshly drowned man with open eyes and hair moving in the wash; haulers bent double with blood threading from their ears; rows of covered dead on the stones; at right, people stand chest-deep in brine pouring from a cut beneath its ribs; near-monochrome grey with drowned teal shadows and salt-white foam

and crust, wet glossy brushwork, ink spatter spray, lower centre surf kept dark and calm for a title.

Negative: bright colours, tropical water, blue sky, cartoon, tentacle monster, kraken, visible eyes or face on the god, heroic sailors, modern ships, text artefacts, clean digital gloss, sunset orange, gore on children, glowing magic

▼ ISS, THE LIDDED



It never woke. Write that down and underline it. Then ask yourself why you need it underlined.

MARGIN NOTE IN THE LUDMERE TELLING, COLLEGE COPY, UNKNOWN HAND

Plate: Iss, the Lidded · *God of sleep* · the Vigil · lamp amber and smoke

THE SHOT

A long low dormitory in the Height, seen down its length from one end at bed height on a 40mm lens, with a strong perspective that runs the rows into darkness. This is the Regrowth plate, now, in 641. The foreground left and right are the first beds: two of the Counted, lying utterly still under linen, their faces turned up, needling-marks on the soles of their bare feet, a lamp hung on a hook between them. The rows go back and back, sixty thousand implied, a corridor of pale shapes under a ceiling lost in lamp-smoke. The centre third is the double exposure that makes the plate: the smoke above the beds thickens into the shape of the god as Ludmere knew it, a curled hound as long as a valley, head on its paws, lying along the whole length of the ward above the sleepers, translucent, made of the smoke from ten thousand lamps. Its great lid, at the centre top of the frame, is shut, and along its lower lid a row of tiny figures lie asleep like children along a bolster. The lid is trembling. Just visible, the lashes have begun to part by a hair. The right third shows a Vigil warden in a smoke-stained coat with a long needle and a lamp, frozen, looking up. Far at the vanishing point of the ward, beyond the last beds, there is a table, and someone is sitting at it with their back to us. The lower centre band is the dark floor between the beds: bare boards, smoke pooled low.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Hundreds of hanging lamps, all amber, all slightly guttering, set in two long lines that converge into smoke. They are the only light source and they are not warm in feeling: they are the light of a city that has not slept in three centuries. Lamp amber is the accent, burning in pinpoints and haloes. Smoke takes all the rest: grey, brown, soft. The ghost of Iss is lit from beneath by the lamps, so its belly glows dirty gold and its upper body fades into black.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The Counted are three centuries asleep and dust does not settle on them. Their skin is waxen and smooth, eyelids glossed as if wet, faces untroubled. The linen is perfectly clean, which is wrong in a room this smoky. Their feet show rows of tiny healed needle-scars. The ghost-god is painted in scumbled smoke that coheres into fur only at the edges: the thick nap of a hound, the soft pads of its folded paws, the lid-scales of its closed eye like overlapping moth-wings, thin and warm. The warden's face is the counterpoint: wrecked by waking, eyes red-rimmed and lidless-looking, skin grey and creased, rouse-stain at the corners of his mouth, lamp-soot in every pore. The air itself should look thick enough to chew.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Iss lay curled in the high valley above old Ludmere like a hound by a fire, as long as the valley, with its head on its paws and its great lids shut. No one in recorded history ever saw its eyes open. Its coat was a thick soft grey nap that lay down and stood up with its breathing, and its breathing was the weather of that country: the valley grass lay flat and rose again with every breath. Its lids were vast and shed warm scales in summer, which the walkers-softly burned as incense so the valley slept for a night and woke rested for a month. Along its lower lid, in every soapstone image, lie tiny figures asleep. It smelled of linen and milk and the hollow of a lover's neck. Oracles slept against its flank and woke with true prophecies about weather and

marriages. Its people were the best-rested and most reasonable in the world.

On the night of the eating, Ludmere came up the valley in stocking feet with knives wrapped in wool, and the mothers sang the cradle-song in shifts so it would not wake, and it never did. The Eye-lines cut out its eyes, still shut, and ate them closed. The Vigil, which grew from Ludmere, now burns every bed and has not slept in three centuries.

This plate is now. In 401 A.G. the first sleepers who could not be woken were laid in the long wards of the Height and counted, and the count has never stopped. They are the Counted, and they are Iss gathered back together into sixty thousand bodies dreaming one dream. In the dream there is a long dim room. The number Matron Dorm keeps is the number of beds needed to hold the whole god. The plate shows the god as it would be seen by anyone who could see it: lying over its sleepers, coming together out of their smoke, its lid beginning to lift. Iss has never been awake. When the last bed fills, the first thing it will ever see is waiting at the end of the room.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Every lamp in the ward is guttering toward the far end, as if a draught were moving in that direction, down the room, toward the table.
- ◇ One bed in the near rows is empty, turned down, a lamp already hung for it. The sheet bears a Vigil ward number that a player can match to a living character.
- ◇ Every Counted face in the near rows is turned very slightly toward the vanishing point.
- ◇ The tiny sleepers along the god's lower lid number seven. There is space at the end of the row for an eighth, and it is empty.
- ◇ The warden's needle is pointed not at the sleepers but upward, at the lid, as if he means to needle the god awake.
- ◇ The figure at the table at the end of the room sits in the only chair; the long room's other chairs, faint in the smoke, are all pushed in.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 interior of an endless low dormitory lit by hundreds of hanging amber oil lamps, rows of perfectly still waxen sleepers under clean linen receding into smoke; above them, translucent and formed from the lamp-smoke itself, the ghost of a colossal curled hound-like god lies along the whole ward, head on its paws, its vast closed eyelid trembling and just beginning to part, a row of tiny sleeping figures along its lower lid; a gaunt exhausted warden with a long needle and lamp looks up, frozen; at the far vanishing point, a small table with one seated figure seen from behind; near-monochrome smoke grey and brown with lamp amber accent, scumbled oil, soot texture, dreamlike double exposure, lower centre floor dark and calm for a title.

Negative: bright colours, cozy bedroom, cartoon, cute dog, modern hospital, metal beds, electric lights, text artefacts, clean digital gloss, sharp focus everywhere, open eye fully visible, face of the seated figure, sexualised sleepers, gore on children

▼ VEY, THE OPENING



First we ask *what it is*. Then we ask *whether it stays*.

THE MIDWIFE'S TWO QUESTIONS, FIRST ASKED ON
THE ROUND HILL

Plate: Vey, the Opening · *God of birth, beginnings and doors* ·
Cradlewrack · wet iron red and clay

THE SHOT

Kneeling height on the summit of the round hill in the red highlands, a 35mm lens close among the midwives, near dawn on the night of the seven killings. The left third is the dead: six earlier bodies of the god laid in a row along the grass, each smaller than the last, from a red heifer-sized shape nearest the edge down to something the size of a lamb, each one opened, each wound turned into a mouth that has gone still. Midwives kneel along the row with their hands still pressed over openings. The centre third is the plate's moment: Harrow Bede, a gaunt highland woman with clay to the elbows, sitting back on her heels, holding in her open palm the seventh Vey, the size of a hand, soft and red and wet and new, its tiny arms spread wide like a figure standing in a doorway. She is looking at it. It is looking at her with an expression of patience. Behind her, the families who ate the caul stand in a half-ring with it worn over their faces as veils, wet and red in the torchlight, faces invisible. The right third is the hilltop behind: frost, torches, and on the bare crown of the hill a door standing in a frame with no house around it, open a crack, a blade of darkness behind it. The lower centre band is the trodden red clay at Harrow's knees in shadow, quiet and dark.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Torchlight from the left, low and red, and the first bruised grey of dawn from behind the door at right, which is the coldest thing in the picture. The accent is wet iron red, and the god is the source of

it: the god's skin, the caul-veils, the clay on every hand. Clay ochre in the ground and the midwives' aprons. Heat-shimmer rises visibly off the small god into the frost. The open crack of the door is pure black, the darkest value in the frame.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Vey's skin is soft and red and glossy, like the inside of a lip, with a hundred small closed openings across it like buds about to break: puckered, wet, ringed in alternating petals and tiny teeth. Each earlier body has one wound that became a mouth; paint the lips of those wounds as birth-swollen, slick, ringed with clay, never gaping. The caul-veils are translucent membrane, veined, clinging to the eaters' faces and catching the torchlight like stretched red silk, dripping at the chin. The midwives' hands are cracked and stained to the wrist. Steam rises from everything warm. The door is old weathered wood with a red handprint at a child's height, the paint still wet. The frost on the grass has melted in a ring around every body.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Vey was the smallest of the Providers, the size of a heifer, soft and red and warm and always, somehow, new, as if it had just arrived. Its body was round-shouldered and rounded everywhere, without edges, its skin set with a hundred small closed openings like buds, and its warmth came off it in waves you could see in frost. It had a blunt gentle head with large dark eyes and no expression but patience. It moved from house to house in the highlands when a birth was near and lay across the threshold, and the labouring woman kept one hand on it, and the midwife caught the child's first breath in her cupped hands and blew it into Vey's nearest opening. Nothing was ever born wrong in the old highlands. When a house was built, Vey was asked to step through the door first.

On the night of the eating every midwife in the highlands was called up to the round hill. A Caul-wife put her knife in under the

breastbone, cleanly, and it died, and then the wound became a mouth and Vey slid out of it again, smaller, new, and lay down to wait. They killed it seven times. Each time it came out of the death with its arms spread wide, never crying. By the sixth, the women were holding the openings shut with their hands, and the openings pushed at their palms like a head pushing. Everyone who ate felt their bellies clench like a door being tried from the other side. The plate shows the moment before Harrow Bede, who buried nine in the Lack with her own fingers, puts the seventh into her mouth and holds her jaw shut. Do not paint the swallowing. Paint her looking at it.

What happens next: she sits in the clay and laughs until she is sick. The caul does not come off the faces of the families who wore it. And behind them, on the empty hilltop, the door nobody brought is open a crack. Now, in 641, Cradlewrack is in labour with its god, the Dilation is a mile across, and the door on the Sill is opening a finger's width a year.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Count the earlier bodies: six, but there are seven wounds turned to mouths. One of the six opened twice, the Kest telling's version leaking into the round hill's.
- ◇ The red handprint on the door is wet, and it is on the inside of the frame, at the height of a small hand pressing outward.
- ◇ One midwife at the left is not holding an opening shut but gently prising one apart with two fingers, looking away as she does it.
- ◇ The seventh Vey's spread arms frame the exact gap of the door's open crack behind it, so it seems to be standing in that doorway.
- ◇ A red clay breath-cup lies on the grass, fogged from the inside.
- ◇ In the frost at the hill's edge, the only footprints leading to the door come from it, not to it.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 night scene on a frosted hilltop in red clay highlands, torchlit, near dawn: a row of soft red newborn-like god-bodies, each smaller than the last, laid along the grass with gaunt midwives kneeling and pressing their hands over wet bud-like openings in the flesh; at centre a haggard woman with clay-stained arms kneels holding in her open palm a tiny glossy red being with arms spread wide like a figure in a doorway, steam rising from it, both regarding each other; behind her, a half-ring of people with wet red membranes worn over their faces like veils; at right a lone weathered door in a frame with no house, open a crack onto blackness; near-monochrome clay ochre with wet iron red accent, oil and ink texture, lower centre dark for a title.

Negative: bright colours, human babies, infant gore, visible swallowing, cartoon, cute creature, modern clothing, text artefacts,

clean digital gloss, pink pastel, sunrise colours, glowing portal, sexualised figures, birth depicted explicitly

▼TOLM, THE WITNESS



◇
Say less.

THE WHOLE OF OATHEN'S LAW, AS TAUGHT TO
CHILDREN

Plate: Tolm, the Witness · *God of oaths and true speech* · Oathen ·
canyon ochre and dried-blood brown

THE SHOT

From halfway up the canyon wall, hanging on a rope with the cutters, a 24mm lens angled down and along the deepest canyon in the east so its walls tower on both sides of the frame. The god runs the whole width of the floor, a long bare body foreshortened away from us, and the plate is built on its ear. The left third is the canyon wall, ochre, ropes hanging down it from rim to floor in hundreds, each with a silent figure on it, mothers descending with children strapped to their backs, leather bands over the children's mouths. The centre third is the great ear itself, pressed to the stone at the near end of the god, wide as a threshing floor, its whorls rising like terraces, and on its rim an old man kneeling with his knife, weeping without a sound, one tear caught mid-fall above the ear. The right third is the length of Tolm lying away into shadow down the canyon, a hundred thousand people spread along it in a dark ribbon, knives raised, eating, and nobody's mouth open. At the far right, in the midground, a mother kneels with her hand clamped over her young son's mouth, his eyes wide above it; nothing more is shown of him. A Tongue-line woman stands apart on the stone holding a loaf-sized lump of amber wax against her chest, not eating it. The lower centre band is the canyon floor in deep shadow, the stone under the ear, dark and blank.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

A narrow slot of moonlight from the canyon rim falls straight down on the ear and nowhere else; the rest is lit by a few shuttered lanterns, dim and brown. The accent pair are canyon ochre in the walls and the god's skin, and dried-blood brown in the cuts, the knives, the leather mouth-straps and the dark wet stone where the eating is. The single tear catches the moonlight as the brightest point in the image; nothing else is allowed to shine.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Tolm's skin is bare and grey-pink like an old scar, hairless, faintly translucent at the thin places, with veins showing through like river-lines on a chart. The ear is cartilage on a cliff's scale: ridged, waxy, folded, with fine hairs at the canal and amber wax in its depths. Where the knives work, the flesh is pale and sinewy and bleeds little, darkening the stone in brown stains. The tongue-eaters sit in a circle cutting slivers no bigger than a fingernail. Everything in this plate should look pressed silent: the leather straps creased with biting, lips pressed white, knuckles whitened around knife-grips. Dust hangs in the moon-slot, perfectly still. The canyon stone is layered like pages. Knife-blades are notched from the bone.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Tolm lay along the floor of the deepest canyon in the east, long and bare and grey-pink, with one ear pressed to the stone, listening. It was always listening. Its body was lean and endless, a mile and more, like a figure carved lying down, with long limbs folded close and one long finger laid across its own lips in every carving. Its face was narrow and closed, eyes shut or nearly, all attention gathered into the ear. What it heard was so. Contracts were spoken into that ear, marriages said there, and the guilty brought to declare their innocence and see what happened. Canyon-folk walked the whole length of the god to reach the ear, most of a day, and the walk was called *coming to the hearing*. Children were taken there at seven to say their names, once, so that they would be so. The god was fed

only true sentences. There was very little crime and almost no poetry.

In the Lack the people came to the ear and said *we are hungry*, and it was so, and *we will die*, and that was so, and they stopped coming. On the night, the whole people came down the walls on ropes in silence, children strapped and muzzled, and ate their god without a word, because a word said there would be true forever. The god heard the knives, and that was so. It heard a hundred thousand people chewing in a canyon that repeats everything, all night. This plate is the moment the old man's tear falls onto the ear. The god will hear it fall, and that will be so: his family, the Drips, will weep without stopping for six hundred years.

What happens next: the boy will try to speak and his mother will not take her hand away until dawn. Nobody will say a word aloud for a year. The first word said in the canyons afterward will be a merchant's *I swear*, and everyone knows what happened to his hands. Now, in 641, Tolm is regrowing in its Sayers, kept bitted in gold in the Gilded Cells, and the Kept Rain came three days late.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Every child on the ropes has a leather strap over its mouth except one, high on the left wall, whose strap has slipped. Her mouth is closed anyway. Her eyes are on the ear.
- ◇ The Tongue-line woman's lump of wax is the relic now in the Hall of Conditions. A sliver is already missing from one side.
- ◇ Carved into the canyon wall at the far left is an old ear-shrine worn smooth at the lobe, and beside it, smaller, an ear inside an open mouth.
- ◇ The tear, looked at closely, reflects the whole canyon rim, and on the rim, against the moon, a single extra figure standing where no rope hangs.
- ◇ The old man's thumb carries three Oathen rings, one for each oath outstanding. One is cracked.
- ◇ The god's finger is laid across its lips as in every carving, but here it has lifted, very slightly, a hair's gap from the mouth.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 view down into a towering narrow ochre canyon by night, a single slot of moonlight falling on a colossal bare grey-pink god lying along the canyon floor with its enormous ear pressed to the stone; hundreds of silent figures descend the walls on ropes, children strapped to backs with leather bands over their mouths; a vast silent crowd eats along the god's length with knives, no mouths open; on the rim of the ear an old man kneels weeping soundlessly, one tear caught mid-fall and shining; a woman stands apart clutching a loaf-sized lump of amber wax; near-monochrome canyon ochre and dried-blood brown, layered stone texture, dry brush and ink wash, still hanging dust, oppressive silence, lower centre canyon floor dark for title.

Negative: bright colours, open screaming mouths, speech bubbles, text artefacts, cartoon, modern climbing gear, clean digital gloss, blue sky, desert sunset, gore on children, injured child, heroic poses, glowing runes

▼ ORRUM, THE HOST



It only wants everyone fed. That isn't so terrible, is it?

WELCOME ARDENT, ON THE RIM ROAD

Plate: Orrum, the Host · *The god who was not eaten* · the Fast · warm candle gold

THE SHOT

Seated height, the height of someone who has just been shown to their chair, a 50mm lens, at the head of the Long Table in the valley in the Fast, on an early Carving night that has lasted six centuries. The table runs from the lower left of the frame away into the distance across the whole width, nine miles of it implied, lit by candles at every place, the line of light dwindling to a thread at the far right. The left third is the near diners: the Seated, in their good clothes, sitting upright with their hands folded, smiling at empty plates. The nearest are fresh; behind them they grow older, lighter, until the farthest visible are little more than clothes holding a posture, a smile hung between two cheekbones. The centre third, rising above the table and filling the upper two-thirds of the frame, is Orrum: very tall, stooping, its head bowed under nothing as if under a doorway, one great arm lowered to lay a bowl at a place, the other hand resting on the back of an empty chair. The right third holds the chair it is pulling out for us, at our elbow, close to the lens, its seat turned invitingly, a place card on the plate with a name we cannot quite read, and further along the table, one more chair, pulled out at an angle, with no place card at all. The lower centre band is the near edge of the tablecloth and the dark under the table: plain linen falling into black.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Candles, thousands of them, the only light and the only kind light in the whole set: warm candle gold, soft, welcoming, falling on faces

and cloth and the god's stooped body with the glow of a kitchen on a winter night. It is the accent and the horror. Everything outside the candlelight is black; there is no moon and no fire on any horizon. The god is lit from below by the table, so its face is warm and its eyes are shadow. The chair without a card stands at the edge of the light.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Orrum's skin is the colour and grain of a well-baked crust, soft-looking, warm, faintly dusted like flour on a board. Its hands are huge and gentle, the knuckles worn like the edges of an old bread-board, the palms creased deep. The Seated are rendered with terrible care: skin drawn papery over cheekbones and knuckles, lips stretched in smiles that have dried that way, hair brushed and oiled by someone else, collars clean, wasps' nest lightness in the oldest of them. Their plates are spotless. The linen is starched white and immaculate. Steam rises from the bowl the god is setting down, though there is nothing in it. Everything smells, visibly, of bread. Wax pools on the cloth and has never once been cleaned up, and never needed to be.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Orrum the Host lived in the rich heartland at the middle of the Table and went from house to house. It was very tall, taller than any lintel, and it stooped always, its long back bowed, its head inclined toward whoever it was serving. Its body was long-limbed and gaunt-shouldered but warm all through, like a hearth-stone in the evening. It had a broad mild face, a face like a grandparent's at the head of a table, heavy-lidded and smiling, and very large gentle hands. It smelled of bread fresh from the oven, woodsmoke and the inside of a kitchen when everyone you love is home. When it came to a door, the bell in the lintel rang, the hearth lit itself and the table was laid. The heartland set its lintels a hand higher so the god would not have to stoop so far. In every carving of the eight, it is the one who pulls out the chairs.

It was the god who was not eaten. On the tenth day the heartland came over the last ridge at Hallowboard and found it lying on the eight-sided stone table, and stood around it and said *No, thank you*. It looked at them, and then at the eighth side of the table for a long while, and then back, afraid. Then it got up, slow and stooping, and began to lay the table. Nine in ten of the Unfed died that winter rather than eat.

This plate is now. Orrum still walks the Fast, and lays tables, and anyone who sits at one and is fed becomes Seated: wasting for decades at the table, eating air, praising empty plates, alive and smiling and gone. The Long Table in the valley is nine miles of them. The light is kind because the god is kind. It only wants everyone fed. It is pulling out a chair for the viewer, and the viewer should feel how easy it would be to sit. The other chair, the one with no card, it has laid exactly as always: someone is expected. In 641 the Host-bells have begun ringing on the Rim Road at night, and Orrum is laying tables in every land.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The god's eyes, hidden in shadow, are not looking at the viewer or the diners but down the table toward the chair with no place card.
- ◇ The place card at the viewer's chair is half legible. In play, it can carry the name of a player character.
- ◇ One of the nearer Seated has a crust of hard brown bread in her lap, hidden under her napkin, uneaten: a Wanting child's crust, replaced with something better.
- ◇ A small bronze Host-bell hangs from a cord on the nearest chair-back, still swinging.
- ◇ The candle at the empty chair burns lower than all the others, as if it had been lit first.
- ◇ Far down the table, a living figure in a steward's coat is laying a place, square, the chair pushed in with its back to the lamp: Welcome Ardent, six centuries at the work.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 night scene at the head of an endless candlelit banquet table stretching miles into black darkness; rows of wasted, smiling, impeccably dressed diners sit upright before spotless empty plates, growing older and lighter into the distance until they are dry clothes holding a pose; above them a colossal gentle stooping god with warm crust-coloured floury skin, a broad grandparent's face in shadow, enormous kind hands, lowers a steaming empty bowl to a place and with its other hand pulls out a chair toward the viewer; nearby, one chair pulled out with no place card; the warm candle gold glow is the only colour, everything else black, soft oil glazes, papery skin detail, tender and terrible, lower centre tablecloth edge dark for a title.

Negative: bright colours, rotting food, gore, cartoon, festive cheer, modern cutlery, electric lights, text artefacts, legible names,

clean digital gloss, angry god, monster teeth, gore on children, crowded colour palette

▼ THE EIGHTH



◆
Don't count the chairs, love. Just sit where you're put.

A RIM INNKEEPER, TO A CHILD, OVERHEARD AT THE
GROANING BOARD

Plate: The Eighth · *The chair that is still pulled out* · No land · bone-white on pure black

THE SHOT

A carving, not a scene. The camera is close and low on the eight-sided stone table at Hallowboard, on a 100mm lens raking along one face of its frieze in near-darkness, so the relief runs across the whole 3:1 frame like a band of bone. The frieze shows the oldest carving on the Table: figures around a table, facing inward. The left third holds three of them, worn soft: the stooping one who pulls out chairs, and beside it the open hands, the curled sleeper. The right third holds four more: the walking belly, the reef, the small one in a doorway, the long one with a finger to its lips. Beneath them, cut very small, runs the line of little figures walking toward the table, carrying something. The centre third is the gap, between the Host and the Closing Hand: a recess exactly the width of one figure, gouged and pitted, chisel marks cut over chisel marks, frantic in one layer and patient in another, the stone ground until it shines. Below the recess, carved in the frieze's table, one chair is shown pulled out. In front of the actual stone, at the foot of the gap, on the real ground of the hill, lies a little drift of grey dust. Two of the carved figures, the Host and the Hand, have their heads very slightly turned toward the gap. The lower centre band is the bare hill-ground beneath the recess: dark, unworn, swept by nothing.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

One raking light from the far right, low and hard, as if from a lantern held close to the stone by someone reading it, throws every

chisel mark into sharp relief and leaves the hollow of the recess pure black at its deepest point. Strictly bone-white on pure black. No warmth anywhere, except that the dust is painted a single value warmer than the stone around it, so slight that only a careful viewer feels it. The lantern itself is never in frame.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Stone treated as skin. The seven figures are polished by ten thousand years of hands, smooth as an old knuckle, and in places the stone has the faint translucence of bone held to a lamp. The recess is the opposite: raw, wounded, like a socket where a tooth has been dragged out, its edges splintered, the chisel strokes reading as scratches on a dish. Some marks are crusted with old dirt; some are pale and new, done last year. The ground in front of the other seven figures is worn into shallow hollows by worshippers' feet. The ground in front of the gap is unworn, crisp, untouched. The dust is fine, grey, and lies slightly heaped, as dust lies under someone who has been sitting a long time.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

GM-facing. Show nothing; let the gap do the work. The players' book says only this: there is an eighth place in every carving older than the Gorging, between the Host and the Closing Hand, and it has been cut away by different tools in different centuries, some before the Gorging and some after. Nobody knows its name, its people, or who ate it, if anyone did. Asking is called *counting the chairs*.

The plate is the eight-sided table on the bare hill at the middle of the world, the table that is always clean, on which Orrum lay on the tenth day. This is its frieze, and its eighth side. Under the reeve's scratched slate, on the underlayer in a hand that is not human, there was a word beside the eighth side: the older word for *guest*, the one with no plural, the root *orr-* with a short stroke beneath it. The reeve scraped it from his own copy, as every carver on the Table had done

for ten thousand years. The Carver should know, and the painter need not, that the seven figures are shown standing because they were not the ones sitting down.

Whatever sat at this side sat there through the seventh, eighth and ninth years of the Lack, and on the ninth night it got up before the table was cleared. When the heartland arrived on the tenth day the stone here was still warm. It has not been back. The Regrowth graphs say it has turned toward the Table again. The carved chair is pulled out because it has never been pushed in. The grey dust is slightly too heavy and is never cold.

The moment captured is no moment: a lantern on old stone, late at night, on the hill where nobody goes, in the last year of the Long Grace. What happened just before is that someone carved here again: one set of chisel marks is fresh. What happens next is that someone sits down. Do not draw who.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ One set of chisel marks in the recess is bright and new, the stone dust still loose in the strokes; somebody is still doing this, and their tool was a table knife.
- ◇ Under the raking light, faint in the deepest gouges, the ghost of a tall seated outline survives, hands in its lap, face turned toward the other seven. It is visible only as a shadow of the cutting, the way Hesper Lune found it by laying rubbings over one another.
- ◇ Below the gap, in the frieze, the small walking figures are carrying dishes, and the dishes are shaped like the seven figures above.
- ◇ Scratched into the base of the recess, half-erased, is a short mark: the root *orr-* with a stroke beneath. It matches the mark on the ninth card at Thimble Cross.
- ◇ The carved table in the frieze has eight sides; the real table's eighth face, the one we are looking at, is the only face with no lichen.
- ◇ In the dust there is one faint impression, like the print of a napkin folded and set down on a chair to show the place is taken.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Extreme close-up 3:1 of an ancient stone relief frieze on an eight-sided table, raked by a single low hard lantern light from the right in near-total darkness; seven worn, polished, faceless god-figures stand facing inward around a carved table, two of them with heads subtly turned toward a central gap; in the centre a figure-width recess has been violently chiselled away, gouges cut over gouges, some old and dirty, some freshly bright, the void pure black at its depth, a carved chair beneath it pulled out; on the real ground below the gap, a small drift of fine grey dust and unworn crisp stone; strictly bone-white on pure black, stone like polished bone, dry-brush and etching texture, huge black negative space, unbearable stillness, lower centre ground dark and calm for a title.

Negative: any visible eighth figure, face, silhouette of a monster, eyes in the dark, bright colours, warm tones, cartoon, glowing runes, legible text, modern objects, clean digital gloss, gore, blood, fantasy temple grandeur, people in frame



CHAPTER 3

PLATES OF
SALLOWREACH,
THE FATLANDS
AND
BRINEHOLLOW

These fifteen plates cover the first three lands of the Long Grace: the grey north, where nothing ends; the warm south, where everything is meat; and the western coast, where the sea has moved into the people and is leaving the land. Each is a place, not a portrait, and that changes the brief. A god-plate is a face. A land-plate is a life, and the painter's job is to make the viewer feel they could step through the gold frame and be handed something to carry.

So every plate here is built around work. Somebody in each image is doing a job they will do again tomorrow: tarring a post, reading to the shelved, lowering a sack, stamping a barrel, bailing an old man over a knee. The horror is never the spectacle. It is the routine, held at ground level, by a named person with tired hands. Keep the

figures small against the place but give them faces you could pick out in a crowd, and let the place press in on them.

The three lands must be told apart at thumbnail size. Sallowreach is close, vertical and wet, all pilings, ladders and shelving, in tea-stain sepia with bruise-green rot and fly-black. The Fatlands are low, wide and warm, ramps and mounds and furrows, in tallow yellow with raw meat red. Brinehollow is long and horizontal, piers and flats and cliff, in drowned teal and salt-white, and every one of its plates should lean slightly west.

As always, the title sits in the lower centre band, so keep that band dark and calm: black water, shadowed turf, wet plank. And in every plate there is at least one thing that has been scraped off, chiselled flat or counted wrong. Don't explain it. Just paint it.

▼ LASTGATE



Ninth, Weir Row, the Coombe house, is where you'll find Gran. Sixth, Old Weir Row, is where you'll find her mother.

DIRECTIONS GIVEN TO A SEAMER'S THREADER,
NEEDLE STREET

Plate: LASTGATE · *The city on pilings where nothing ends* · Sallowreach · bruise-green and fly-black on tea-stain sepia

THE SHOT

Low and close to the water, from a punt drifting in the canal off the Landing at sixth bell, with a 35mm lens held a yard above the black surface so the city stacks up over us like a cliff. The 3:1 frame is all verticals. In the left third, close enough to touch, stands the Ferrying Post, the oldest piling in Lastgate, black as iron with centuries of tar, and on a plank cradle hung from it Gideon Tarr, the Tarrer, brush in one hand, bucket on a hook, working over a patch of the carved procession where one figure has been gouged away. In the centre third the city goes up in storeys: the Ninth on top with its lit door-candles, the Eighth below with damp rooms rented by the bed, and under the canal-line the Seventh, its windows half full of water, glowing faintly green through the gratings. In the right third the houses lean together over a narrow canal like old men sharing a secret, ropes and plank bridges strung between them, and beyond them the Breath swallows everything into yellow-brown fog, with the long roofs of the Lofts just showing at the far right edge. Foreground: black water, a raft of old leaves, our own prow. Background: fog and a dark fly-front coming in low over the roofs. The lower centre band is canal water, still and nearly black, holding the city's reflection in broken strips. The title sits there, over water, with only the reflected door-candles beneath it.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Two lights only. Hundreds of door-candles, lit by law at sixth bell, glow warm sepia through the fog so the whole city looks like something seen through the skin of a lantern. Below, the Drowned Storeys give off a cold bruise-green from the fen-glow jars Ossie Wade keeps lit, coming up through the gratings and the half-sunk windows. The accent bruise-green appears only below the canal-line and in the lacquered faces of the Kept porters. Fly-black is the incoming swarm over the roofs and the tar on the Post. Everything else is tea-stain brown and fog.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The Post is tar laid on tar for six hundred years, in drips, ridges and blisters like the hide of something old, and the fresh coat steams in the damp. Gideon Tarr is so sealed in it himself that his face reads as carved: a Kept man with a glossy black jaw, a crack at the corner of his mouth showing pale grey under it, fingers fused stiff around the brush handle. Pilings below the waterline are furred with green weed and soft as wet bread, leaning but never breaking. On the plank bridges walk the Kept in waxed gauze and cedar lacquer, cheeks drawn up with wire at the corners and shining like sideboards. A red cord shows on every porter's left wrist. The water carries leaves, a bobbing cork, a slick of rainbow tallow. Weep is falling and has left tea-coloured streaks down every wall. You should be able to smell it from the paint: tar, vinegar, cedar smoke, and the sweetness all of those are there to hide.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Lastgate is the capital of the grey north, built on ten thousand tarred pilings driven into the fen where the border road ends. The pilings do not rot; nothing here finishes. They soften, lean and sink an inch a decade, so for six centuries the city has built a new storey on top of the old and moved upstairs. Addresses give the storey, the board and the house. The Kept outnumber the breathing nine to one, and most families live with a dozen dead relatives at the table, up in

attics, in chairs by the window, kept clean and stitched by people who will one day need keeping themselves.

This is the Landing, the city's door to the south: Company warehouses, punt-stands, foreigners' inns, customs men splashing vinegar on everything off the road. The bell of the Ferrying Post, cast in the year 9 and never finished cooling, has just rung sixth, and all over the city families are lighting their door-candles off tins of smoulder-coal.

Gideon Tarr has tarred the Post at Court wages since 338. He is the man who covers the gouges in the eighth figure of its carved procession. They used to come twice a year. Now they come every month, and tonight's is fresh, cut from inside the wood outward, as if something were trying to get out.

At ground level Lastgate feels like a crowd in a cellar. Planks give a little under each step. Voices across the canal seem to come from just behind you. Underfoot, through every grating, the Seventh Storey looks back at you, green and wet, and somebody down there is still sitting in their parlour with the water at their chin.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The gouged figure Gideon is tarring over is the eighth in the procession; under the wet tar its outline still shows, a little longer in the arm than the rest.
- ◇ In a green-lit window of the Seventh Storey, a small figure in a schoolroom smock is pressed to the glass: one of the Smalls, and next to her the long pole and tin of Ossie Wade.
- ◇ A red-corded Kept porter is walking south along the causeway at the far left, and a living hand has caught hold of the cord to turn him round.
- ◇ On a doorframe on the Ninth, a chalked fly-count reads *41*, the Mallory tally for Pocock's Almanack.
- ◇ One door-candle near the centre is leaning against the draught, toward the viewer: a Wick Tallow candle, trying to be noticed.
- ◇ Floating face-up beside the punt is a lacquered Guild mask with a painted smile, and the eyeholes are not empty.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide 3:1 view from a punt at water level of a sinking city on black tarred pilings in a warm yellow-brown fen fog, houses stacked in storeys and leaning over a narrow canal, hundreds of small door-candles glowing sepia through the mist, the lowest storeys half drowned with cold bruise-green light coming up through gratings. Left foreground: a huge ancient tar-black post carved with a procession, one figure gouged away, and a Kept man glossy with tar painting over it from a plank cradle. Lacquered, wire-stitched dead walking plank bridges. A low fly-swarm darkening the roofs. Still black canal water with broken reflections across the lower centre. Oil and ink-wash texture, dry-brush grit, heavy shadow, tea-stain sepia, bruise-green and fly-black accents, intimate decay.

Negative: bright colours, blue sky, sunshine, clean stone, cartoon, anime, glossy digital render, modern boats, electric light, readable text, signage, gore on children, sexualised figures, fantasy castles, vibrant green, cheerful

▼ THE LOFTS



*Visitors remember the Lofts for the whispering.
Wardens remember them for the drip.*

LOFTSIDE SAYING

Plate: THE LOFTS · *Nine storeys of the Set-Aside* · Sallowreach · bruise-green and fly-black on tea-stain sepia

THE SHOT

Inside Hall Six, at the floor of the aisle, looking up and down its length with a 24mm lens tilted slightly upward from waist height, so the shelving rises nine storeys on both sides and narrows to a vanishing point in brown dark. The 3:1 frame reads as a long tunnel of shelves. Left third: the near shelves close enough to read, bodies wrapped tight in waxed linen from feet to crown, laid side by side like rolled carpets, each with a card tied at the throat. Centre third: the aisle running away, its sawdust floor dark with drip, and halfway up the right-hand stack, on a ladder that runs on a rail, Aldo Penny, the Reader of Hall Six, with a lamp hooked on a rung and a letter held close to his near-sighted eyes, reading aloud to the fourth storey. Right third: the stacks continue into the dark, broken by the rails of other ladders, a Warden's lamp very far off like a single star, and at the extreme right, the edge of the Wrapping Room door, ajar, with a long table and a pale shape on it. Foreground: the lowest shelf, tarred black, and a family's small gifts left on its edge, a book, a dried flower, a child's drawing. Midground: Aldo on the ladder. Background: the vanishing aisle. The lower centre band is the aisle floor, dark sawdust and shadow, calm and nearly black. The title sits there, on the floor of the hall, under the drip.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Low lamplight only, warm sepia, from Aldo's lamp and a few hooked along the rails, each throwing a small cone up the linen. The

halls are kept cool, and the air between the lamps is brown dark. Bruise-green appears in the old linen of the upper shelves, where a century of seepage has stained the wrapping, and in the faint mould on the label-cards. Fly-black is the drip-marks on the sawdust and the few flies that got in, crawling on the oldest wraps. Thin threads of drip catch the lamplight as falling gold.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Waxed linen, wound tight, creased and shiny at the high points of each body: brow, nose, folded hands, knees. Where the old wraps have slumped, the shape inside has settled downward, and the linen hangs in a soft pouch at the hips and jaw. Brown seeps through the weave in tide-lines like tea on a cloth. Below each upper shelf, slow beads of Loft-weather gather and fall, a sweetish brown rain that has spattered the tarred lower shelves into a crust. The label-cards are stained, rewritten, foxed, their strings sunk into the linen at the throat. On the oldest shelves the *Visited* line is simply ruled through. One wrapped figure close to the viewer has turned its head toward the lamp, and the linen over the mouth is moving. Camphor, wax, lamp-oil and old meat should rise off the paint together.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Lofts are nine long timber halls on the north edge of Lastgate where the Set-Aside are kept: the Kept too far gone in the long rot to stand or sit, wrapped, labelled and shelved. Forty thousand of them, nine storeys to a hall, all still aware. Families pay forty lacks to wrap and shelve a relative and one lack a season for upkeep, and come on feast days in a queue that runs the length of Loftside, carrying letters, books and small gifts the shelved cannot use. The Loft-Wardens move along the aisles on rail ladders with lamps and lists, rewrapping the oldest every decade in the Wrapping Room, where families are not invited, because what is under the linen after a hundred years is still talking.

The street outside is clean and swept and quiet except for the whispering, a soft continuous sound like rain on reeds that comes through the walls into every house on Loftside. Locals stop hearing it in a month. Visitors never do.

Aldo Penny is thirty-one, thin, with ink on his cuffs and a trained soft voice. He has read to the four hundred shelved of Hall Six every night for nine years and knows most of them by voice. Tonight he is reading Teal Mallory's letter to her mother Hanne, fourth storey, shelf nineteen: a day on Weir Row, eels, smudge-pots, nineteen saved breaths in a jar for a Closing license. Hanne listens. Around him, the whole hall listens.

What Aldo will not tell Teal, on Old Bettany's order, is that under the old whispering there is now a single word, and all the shelved are saying it together. He has begun waking at the same hour every night with it in his mouth. In the shot he has paused mid-line, lamp swaying, because the whisper has risen, and for a moment he is not sure whether the next word on the page is Teal's or theirs.

At ground level the Lofts feel like a library where every book is breathing. It is cool, and patient, and the drip ticks like a clock shop.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The card on shelf nineteen, fourth storey, reads *Hanne Mallory* and has the most feast-day marks on its *Visited* line of any card in the frame.
- ◇ On the far wall a Warden's chalked list has nine names struck through at once: shelved who went silent in the same night.
- ◇ Aldo's lips are shaped around a word that is not on the page he is holding.
- ◇ A candle in a lamp along the rail is a Wick Tallow named candle, leaning toward the shelves, not the aisle.
- ◇ In the Wrapping Room doorway, the figure on the table has linen unwound to the chest, and its hand is up, holding a Warden's wrist.
- ◇ The child's drawing on the bottom shelf shows a stick-figure family of two breathing and eleven wrapped, all smiling.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 interior of a vast timber warehouse hall, looking down a long aisle between shelving nine storeys high, every shelf packed with human bodies tightly wrapped in waxed linen from feet to crown, label cards tied at their throats, brown seepage staining the cloth, slow drips falling from the upper shelves through warm lamplight. A thin young reader with ink-stained cuffs on a rail ladder halfway up the right-hand stack, lamp hooked beside him, reading a letter aloud to the shelves. Sawdust floor dark with drips; small gifts on the lowest shelf; a distant lamp far down the aisle. Warm sepia lamplight, brown darkness, bruise-green mould and staining, fly-black drip spatter. Oil paint and ink texture, intimate, still, unbearable patience.

Negative: bright colours, clean white bandages, mummies Egyptian style, cartoon, glossy render, modern shelving, metal racks, electric light, readable text, cheerful, sexualised figures, gore on children, horror-movie jump scare, skeletons

▼ THE SUMP



The Sump is the only place in the north where nobody asks for anything back.

LASTGATE SAYING

Plate: THE SUMP · *Where the unstitchable are sunk* · Sallowreach · bruise-green and fly-black on tea-stain sepia

THE SHOT

At dusk, from the bow of the Sackmen's long punt on the open deep fen west of Lastgate, looking back down its length toward the stern with a 28mm lens at kneeling height, so the black water fills the lower half and the low sky hangs over it like a lid. The 3:1 frame is wide and flat and empty. Left third: three sewn hessian sacks lying in the bottom of the punt, roped, each with a lead name-strip at the neck, and the family who sewed them sitting very upright on the thwart beside them, not speaking. Centre third: the stern, and standing in it the Sackman, Abner Rook, fourth of his line, rope in both hands, a fourth sack just gone over the side, his lips moving on the words. The rope runs from his hands down into the water and has not yet gone slack. Right third: the open Sump, flat black water to a horizon of grey reed, and on its surface a pattern of rising bubbles, rings inside rings, with a line of them running away from the punt like something spelled. Far right, a dredger's stilt-hut with one lamp burning where none should be. Foreground: the bow and black water lapping over it. Midground: the punt, the family, the Sackman. Background: the bubble-rings, the reed horizon, the dredger's light. The lower centre band is the water beneath the stern, black, greasy, calm, where the rope enters it. The title sits on that water.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Late dusk, the Breath gone from yellow to brown, giving a dull tea-stain sepia light from the west with no visible sun. A single horn lantern on a pole at the stern throws a small warm circle on the Sackman's hands and the rope. Bruise-green is the oily sheen on the surface of the Sump and the faint glow inside the bubble-rings as they break. Fly-black is the water itself, and the cloud of flies over the sacks. The dredger's far lamp is a pinprick of warm wrongness.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The sacks are coarse hessian, wet through, sewn shut by family hands with uneven stitches, and the shapes inside are knees, a jaw, a shoulder, pressing at the weave. One sack has a darker patch spreading at the bottom, soaking into the punt's planks. The lead name-strips are dull grey, stamped with a name and a date, tied with tarred cord. The rope in the Sackman's hands is greasy and black with six centuries of use, and his palms are callused into hide. The Sump water is thick and slow, with a skin on it like cooling broth, and where the bubbles rise they leave rings of scum and a smell, implied in the paint, of drains. Abner wears a long oilskin gone soft and brown, a hood back, a living face lined and grey with damp. The family's hands are folded and very clean, because they scrubbed after the sewing.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Sump is the deep fen west of Lastgate where those beyond stitching are sunk: the Kept whose bodies have come apart too far for the Seamers' Guild to hold together, burned too badly, torn, or simply gone past wire and lacquer. It is the nearest thing Sallowreach has to a graveyard, and it is not one, because nothing in it is dead. At the bottom, by the account of the Kept who walk the fen-bed and have gone near it, is a mound: six hundred years of sacks heaped one on another, softened together, the ropes rotted into one mat, the whole of it slowly rising and falling.

The Sackmen are a hereditary trade, living and Kept, and they keep a strict and joyless decency. Each sack is sewn by the family, never by the Sackman. Each carries a lead strip with the name and date of sinking, so that what is down there may be found again if anyone needs it. At the drop the Sackman stands in the stern, holds the rope in both hands and recites the name, the dates and the words *Go under and keep*, and pays out until the rope goes slack. In the deep Sump that can take a long time. Nobody else speaks.

Abner Rook has done it since he was fourteen. Tonight he is sinking a grandmother, two uncles and a child cousin of the Lusk family from the Sinks, all of them past what the family could afford to have restitched, and he is on the first. The family watches the rope, not the water.

What they are not watching is the bubbles. Sump-watchers say the patterns are speech. Tonight they are rising in a line away from the punt, toward the dredger's hut at Grimsey Reach, where a lamp is burning after dusk. The dredgers, hated more than the Hookmen, come out with grapnels and rakes after the Sackmen leave.

At water level the Sump feels like being watched from below by something that is being polite about it. When Abner's rope goes slack, he will say the next name.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The child cousin's sack is the smallest, and the family's mother has stitched a sprig of rosemary into its seam; it is the only sack with no stain.
- ◇ In the bubble-rings, if read as a line, there are eight rings and then a gap where a ninth should be.
- ◇ On the dredger's platform at the far right, a pile of opened, emptied sacks is stacked to dry like grain-bags.
- ◇ Hung from a nail at the dredger's hut door is a single lead name-strip, kept, not cut off: the dredger's memento of someone, and the reason the hut has two cups on its table.
- ◇ Under the black surface beside the stern, a pale hand has come up to rest against the punt's planking, not pulling, only holding on.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 view at dusk from the bow of a long flat punt on still black greasy fen water, low brown fog sky, reed horizon. In the stern a weathered man in a soft oilskin holds a black rope in both hands as it runs down into the water, a lantern on a pole lighting his hands. Hessian sacks sewn shut with human shapes pressing inside lie in the bottom of the punt, lead name-strips tied at their necks, a grieving family sitting upright beside them. To the right, bubbles rising in concentric rings and lines across the oily surface with a faint green glow; a distant stilt-hut with one lamp. Tea-stain sepia, bruise-green sheen, fly-black water and flies, ink-wash and dry-brush grit, quiet dread, heavy negative space.

Negative: bright colours, blue water, sunset orange, cartoon, glossy render, modern boats, rubber, plastic, readable text, gore on children, sexualised figures, open sacks showing bodies, monsters, tentacles, cheerful

▼ DUNMERE HUSH



*We sing it to the end out here. That's the only place in
the north a song gets an end.*

BROTHER ABEL FISK, AT THE VERGE

Plate: DUNMERE HUSH · *The first and largest silence* ·
Sallowreach · bruise-green and fly-black on tea-stain sepia

THE SHOT

Standing at the Verge, the encampment along the edge of the silence, with a 50mm lens at eye height looking straight along the grey line, so it runs diagonally from the lower left corner to the right horizon and divides the frame. The 3:1 composition is two countries. Left third: the living fen, crowded with the Verge camp, tents, lean-tos, punts drawn up, candle-sellers, pilgrims kneeling, a soup kettle steaming, and at the kettle Brother Abel Fisk, a Kept Lamp of the Finishers, ladle in hand, feeding a queue of living children. Centre third: the line itself, as sharp as a cut: on this side green-brown reeds, flies, mud; a step further, reeds the grey of cold ash, standing perfectly still. A Finisher procession of candle-bearing Kept has just crossed it and walks on into the grey toward the village, getting smaller, their song stopped where they stopped. Right third: Dunmere village inside the Hush, four miles off, small and exact: doors open, washing on lines, and the shapes of its people lying where they lay down. Foreground: the Verge mud, wet, trampled, with dropped candles and name-strips. Midground: the line and the walkers. Background: the grey disc and the village under a white sky. The lower centre band is the dark trampled mud of the living side just before the line, where the grey begins. The title sits there, straddling the edge.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

On the living side, the usual tea-stain fog light, thick and moving, and the small warm glows of hundreds of Finisher candles. On the Hush side, a flat, even, painted light with no source and no shadow, because nothing there moves the air: everything rendered in bone-grey. The bruise-green accent lives on the living side only, in the reeds and the lacquered faces of the Kept pilgrims, and stops dead at the line. Fly-black is the swarm that hangs over the camp and stops in a straight wall at the edge.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

On the living side: muck, rope, wet canvas, beeswax dripped on everything, Kept pilgrims in waxed gauze with their seams loosening, faces brown and slipping under lacquer, carrying their own name-strips. The flies are thick, crawling in the corners of eyes. On the far side, nothing has texture except stillness. The grey reeds are dry and crisp as paper. The dead of Dunmere lie unrotted, cheeks whole, clothes clean, hands open, as if asleep in the road, and there are no flies on them at all. The pilgrims who have just crossed walk with their seams already settling, their lacquered faces losing the wet sheen as they go, as if colour were draining off them like water off a plate. Where the procession's candles cross the line, their flames stop flickering and look painted on.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Eight years ago Dunmere was a reed-cutting village of three hundred souls, living and Kept. In the Carving of 633 a ferryman poling past at dawn could not hear the village dogs, or his pole, or himself shouting. Everyone inside was simply, properly dead. When the news reached Lastgate, half the country wept with envy. Now the silence is a grey disc four miles across, growing a few yards a month, and it is the first and largest of the Hushes: places where the god of death, eaten and unable to do its work for six centuries, has begun to close things again.

Around it is the Verge: two miles of camp along the line, moving outward with it. Finishers live here, the death cult that walks into the Hushes singing, in long processions mostly of the Kept, carrying candles and the names of the dead. The Lamps and Singers who lead them live here. The families who watched someone walk in and cannot go home live here. Court guards, all Kept, are posted at the main approach, and some of them have walked in themselves. Dredgers wade the edge for dropped rings. Someone sells bottled air from the line, which the Court calls stolen licenses.

Brother Abel Fisk has led forty pilgrimages to the edge and never once gone in. He runs the soup kitchen for the living children left behind. In the shot he has turned from the kettle to watch the procession reach the end of its song, because the custom here is the last verse: those who stay sing it to its end, and the song is finished when the last singer outside stops. A small boy in the queue is still singing. Abel is waiting for him to finish before he fills his bowl.

At ground level the Verge is loud until it is not. Voices drop as you walk toward the line. At the edge, the nothing presses on your ears like deep water, you taste iron, and your own heartbeat seems to come from out in the grey, walking toward you, never arriving.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Ten feet inside the line, on the grey grass, lie a pair of severed hands, grey, open, nine joints to a finger: Lord Pellam Fallow's, given back in the Restitution of 639.
- ◇ One footprint in the grey reeds leads in and then back out again: Edda Thrush's, from 638.
- ◇ Among the walkers is a living man in a Fen Guard coat, breathing fog from his mouth; the Finishers cannot always tell in the dark who is breathing.
- ◇ A woman on the living side holds the end of a rope that runs over the line and lies slack in the grey.
- ◇ The Verge camp's tent-pegs on the line itself have grey ash creeping up them; the edge moved in the night.
- ◇ A Coldharrow pair of boots stands by a tent flap, laces tied, toes pointing toward the line.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 landscape at the edge of a perfect silence in a fen: a sharp diagonal line divides wet green-brown reeds, mud and a crowded camp of tents, candles and grieving pilgrims on the left from a vast still disc of ash-grey reeds on the right where nothing moves and no shadows fall. A procession of stitched, lacquered undead pilgrims carrying candles walks into the grey toward a distant silent village where clean unrotted bodies lie in the lanes. A gentle undead monk ladles soup for living children by a steaming kettle. A wall of flies stops at the line. Tea-stain sepia, bruise-green on the living side, bone-grey beyond, fly-black swarm; oil and ink-wash texture, mournful, vast negative space.

Negative: bright colours, blue sky, sunlight, cartoon, glossy render, modern tents, plastic, readable text, gore on children, sexualised figures, explosions, magic glow effects, skeletons, cheerful

▼ THE JAR ROOM



Read them out each morning, love. They like to hear their names. Even the ones facing the wall.

MERRIT CASK'S MOTHER, HANDING HER THE KEYS

Plate: THE JAR ROOM · *One shelf, very long* · Sallowreach · bruise-green and fly-black on tea-stain sepia

THE SHOT

In the low brick vault under the Hall of Hands, from one end, with a 40mm lens at seated eye height, looking down the full length of the single shelf so it runs from the left edge into a far point near the right third. The 3:1 frame is a long, low tunnel, the ceiling barely above the jars. Left third: the near end of the shelf, close and enormous, three thick green glass jars sealed with lead, each holding a head floating in amber pickle, hair drifting upward; on the shelf below, smaller jars of hands. Centre third: the shelf going away, hundreds of jars catching the lamplight one after another like a row of drowned lanterns, and halfway down, in a plain wooden chair, Merrit Cask, Keeper of the Jar Room, a lamp on the floor beside her, a ledger on her knee, reading the labels aloud. Right third: the far end of the vault, dark, and a stretch of the shelf where nine jars in a row have gone cloudy and still, their heads slumped, the labels unchanged. Foreground: the brick floor and the iron drains set into it beneath the shelf, wet. Midground: Merrit and her chair. Background: the far brick wall and the dark. The lower centre band is the floor, dark brick and the black mouths of the drains, calm. The title sits along the drains.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

One lamp, warm sepia, on the floor beside Merrit, throwing her shadow long down the vault and lighting the jars from below so each face glows through its glass. Bruise-green is the glass itself, thick

and old, and the skin of moisture sweating on every jar. Fly-black is the vault's dark, the lead seals and the drains. The amber pickle in each jar catches the lamp, but keep it brown-gold and dull, never bright. Where the nine silent jars stand, the green goes flat and grey, as if the light had stopped reaching them.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The jars are thick hand-blown glass, bubbled and uneven, so each face behind them is warped and doubled. Every jar sweats, a skin of green beads running down to pool on the shelf as if the vault were breathing on them. Inside, the heads float in thick amber: skin gone smooth and pale and soft as cheese, eyelids open, lips moving, hair rising and turning slowly like weed in a still pool. The severed necks are sealed with old wax and stitched. On the shelf below, the hands are busy, opening, closing, drumming, the nails worn to stubs from scratching at the glass, which is clouded in arcs where they have worked. Labels on parchment, stained, give name, crime, date. A few have a second label in red. Merrit's hands are red from lye; her apron is damp.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Jar Room is the Mortuary Court's prison: one shelf, very long, the full length of a vault under the Hall of Hands on the Upper Boards. In a land where nothing dies, the worst sentence is not death, which is the most precious thing the Court has to sell, but its opposite: to be jarred, Kept forever in pieces, head in one jar, hands in another, the rest rendered or sunk. The heads are aware. The oldest jar is from 304. The jarred for treason are shelved facing the wall. Those jarred for unlicensed Closing carry a red label reading *Not to be closed under any license*, and those are the ones who weep. The rendered remains go to Wick Tallow's candles. On the floor beneath the shelf there are drains.

Merrit Cask is a living woman of forty-four who inherited the keys from her Kept mother, who had them from hers. She dusts the

jars, oils the seals, sweeps the drains, and every morning she reads the labels aloud, one by one, the whole length of the shelf, because the jarred like to hear their names. She smells of lamp oil and lye. Her mother still comes down some mornings to help, slow on the steps.

Last month nine of the oldest jars went silent at once. They have not moved since. Rumour in the Sinks says a Hush opened in the Jar Room and closed them, and that the Court has hidden it, and the rumour is true. Since then Merrit has heard the shelf whispering about who will be next, a ticking and tapping from the hands like a roomful of people waiting to be called. In the shot she has just moved her chair another yard down the vault, away from the nine, for the third night running. She is reading the name in front of her and not looking to her right.

At ground level the Jar Room is cramped, damp and close. You cannot stand straight. Every face you pass turns its eyes to follow you, and the hands drum as you go by.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The third shelf-section from the left holds a jar labelled *Dunnock, 612, striking a Licenser*: Lark Dunnock's father, whose name she prints in every issue of *The Bequest*.
- ◇ A small jar holds only a tongue, labelled as a printer's, from the *THEY DO IT TOO* issue of 640.
- ◇ The nine silent jars are the only ones with no sweat on the glass, and the grey on the floor tiles beneath them is spreading, an inch at a time, toward Merrit's chair.
- ◇ The scratch-marks on one hand-jar spell something in arcs; it is a Closer's name, repeated.
- ◇ Merrit's chair legs have left a trail of scraped marks behind her down the floor, one per night.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 interior of a low brick vault with one very long shelf running into the distance, lined with hundreds of thick green sweating glass jars sealed with lead, each holding a severed human head floating in amber fluid, hair drifting upward, eyes open and aware; smaller jars of restless severed hands on the shelf below, scratching at the glass. A tired woman in a lye-stained apron sits in a wooden chair halfway down, a lamp on the floor beside her, reading labels aloud from a ledger. Nine jars at the far end gone cloudy and still. Iron drains in the brick floor. Warm sepia lamplight from below, bruise-green glass, fly-black shadow, oil and ink texture, intimate, oppressive.

Negative: bright colours, laboratory, modern glassware, neon, sci-fi tanks, cartoon, glossy render, clean surfaces, readable text, gore on children, sexualised figures, splatter, cheerful, skeleton decorations

▼ SATED



◆
*Four hundred thousand by head, and a hundred and
twenty million by the pound.*

SATED CIVIC BOAST

Plate: SATED · *The capital with ramps instead of stairs* · the Fatlands · raw meat red and tallow yellow

THE SHOT

At night from the corner of Ladle Lanes where it opens onto the inner ring, with a 35mm lens at a standing man's chest height, looking up a long broad ramp of packed brick toward the Weighhouse dome. The 3:1 frame is low, wide and heavy, nothing in it taller than the dome. Left third: Mother Suckling's pie-shop, the Bottomless Crust, its oven mouth open and roaring, the pie-wife herself at the counter, cleaver raised over a joint, while a queue of the poor waits for the ten-crumble plate. Centre third: the ramp, rising away from us, and on it a Gut-lines dray hauled by eight silent oxen, its passenger a vast shape under a canopy, attended by Carriers walking alongside with ropes and Washers behind with buckets. Above it, at the top of the frame, the dome of glazed bone tile, gleaming dully like a plate of fat. Right third: the low halls of the Scales, faced in bone tile, a pair of Bailiffs in threes counting plates at a street-cook's brazier, and an iron grating in the pavement breathing steam, with a clerk stopped over it, staring down. Foreground: the open gutter running down the middle of the street, warm with dripping. Midground: the dray and the ramp. Background: the dome, the night sky blue with frying smoke. The lower centre band is the dark, grease-slick cobbles at the foot of the ramp and the gutter, calm and shadowed. The title sits on the cobbles.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Tallow lamps on every corner, burning all night, give a thick tallow-yellow light that turns the smoke into a low ceiling. Mother Suckling's oven throws a hot orange-red across the left third; keep it deep and smoky, never bright. Raw meat red appears in the oven-glow, the joint under the cleaver, the dray's canopy and the wet gutter. Everything else sinks into brown-black and blue smoke. Light pools on the wet cobbles in greasy yellow smears, and the faces in the queue are lit from one side only, half gold, half lost in smoke.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The cobbles are fat-stained stone, sunk, tilted and relaid until the street ripples like a quilt over sleepers, sanded every morning and greasy again by noon. The gutter carries brown dripping that steams. The oxen are enormous, sleek, hairless at the flanks, with long lashes and eyes that watch rather than see. The great figure on the dray is a hill of flesh in silk, folds stacked on folds, a ringed hand resting on a cushion, mouth working on something; between two folds a Washer's wooden spatula is lifting a white rind. The Carriers are broad-shouldered men and women with rope-scarred palms. Mother Suckling is wide, floured to the elbow, her cleaver wet. The pies on her counter have crusts like crackling, split and steaming, with long pale fibres in the crumb. The air is blue, and every surface is tacky.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Sated is the capital of the Fatlands, built on the Great Gravy in nine broad rings around the Weighhouse, where the Board of Plenty sits and the Great Scales weigh the nation every Grace. Nothing in it is tall. Height means stairs, stairs mean the great cannot reach you, and in Sated to be beyond the reach of the great is to be beyond the law, so every building is a hall, every door double, every upper floor reached by a ramp. The city is never quiet and never dark. The Feasting Laws require five meals a day, Bailiffs walk the rings counting plates, and refusal is sedition.

Everyone here is hungry all the time. The hunger has nothing to do with the stomach; it is the god's famine, inherited, a hand open under the breastbone. So the city eats, and the poor eat in Ladle Lanes, where by Board ordinance every cookshop must sell a full meal for ten crumbs at any hour.

Mother Suckling keeps the oldest pie-shop on the Lanes. She buys meat at night from the back door, unstamped, off the Dusk Acres carts, and she has never once refused it, or refused to say whose it was if asked kindly. In the shot a ragged boy at the front of her queue has just asked, kindly. She is deciding whether to answer before she brings the cleaver down.

Up the ramp, a Gut-lines master is being hauled home to the Fold: Carriers to turn him four times a day, Washers to clean the folds where things grow. Behind him, a clerk who has stopped over a Weighhouse grating is breathing in the warm loam-and-gravy air from the cellars, where the Board keeps its real Reaping figures among roots that have grown through the floor.

At ground level Sated smells of gravy at every hour, brown, rich, salt, faintly burnt. Visitors stop noticing on the third day. On the tenth, they find they are always hungry.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Fine white threads have wound round the ankle of the clerk at the grating; in 639 a man who slept on one was found rooted through the cheek.
- ◇ On the ramp's brickwork a child has chalked the Grumble, the round smiling thing that lives in a tummy with its arms open.
- ◇ The dray's canopy carries the Tullow arms; its passenger's hand rests on a locked oak case, the true Reaping roll.
- ◇ An upside-down bowl sits on a windowsill in the Lanes, for someone dusk-shifted to the Cullmasters' far fields.
- ◇ One of the eight oxen has turned its head to look straight out of the frame, at the viewer, eating nothing.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 night street scene in a low wide city of massive brick halls and ramps instead of stairs, a broad greasy cobbled ramp rising toward a dome of dull glazed bone tiles. A colossal noble of folded flesh in silk rides a dray drawn by eight huge silent hairless oxen, attended by rope-scarred carriers. In the left foreground a broad floured pie-wife raises a cleaver at her roaring oven before a queue of the hungry poor; tallow lamps everywhere, blue frying smoke, a steaming gutter of brown dripping, an iron grating breathing steam. Tallow yellow light, raw meat red glow, brown-black shadow, oil-paint and ink texture, oppressive abundance and hunger.

Negative: bright colours, clean modern city, stairs, cartoon fat jokes, comedic tone, glossy render, neon, cars, readable text, gore on children, sexualised bodies, fast-food imagery, cheerful festival

▼ THE BLEEDING ORCHARDS



◆
*They let the children hear until they're ten. Then one
night in the old grove, so they know what they're
choosing.*

A KEEPER OF SAPWELL, IN HAND-SPEECH,
TRANSLATED

Plate: THE BLEEDING ORCHARDS · *Ten thousand acres that
scream at pruning* · the Fatlands · raw meat red and tallow yellow

THE SHOT

Early Grace, pruning season, in the oldest grove above Sapwell, from among the trunks with a 50mm lens at the height of a kneeling keeper, looking along a row so the orchard recedes in lines toward a pale yellow horizon. The 3:1 frame is filled with branches. Left third: a deaf orchard-keeper on a ladder, pruning hook biting into a limb, the cut pulsing dark sap into a bucket hung below; a second keeper, Aldo Pippin, sixty, signing up to him with quick hands. Centre third: Marigold Chine, freckled, in a straw hat, standing in the row with her head back and her mouth open, singing to the trees, the only one in the grove who can hear them. Around her the nearest trees lean, very slightly, their cut limbs angled toward her like listeners. Right third: the orchard going away in rows to the horizon, ten thousand acres, every tree with a fresh cut steaming, and in the far rows small figures with buckets. Foreground: blossom fallen on dark ground, a spilled bucket of clotting sap, and a pear-wood stool. Midground: the singer and the keepers. Background: endless rows and a heavy butter-coloured sky. The lower centre band is the dark orchard floor under the trees, shadowed turf and fallen blossom. The title sits there.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

A low early-morning sun behind haze, flat tallow yellow, coming through the branches in long dusty bars. Raw meat red is the sap: in the cuts, in the buckets, on the keepers' aprons, on the black-red mouths of two keepers' children sitting under a tree with a spoon. The blossom is off-white, faintly pink at the heart, and should not read as pretty. Everything else is brown bark and shadow. Steam rising from the fresh cuts catches the low sun in faint red-gold haloes around every tree, so the whole row seems to breathe.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The bark is smooth and slightly warm-looking, like the skin on the back of a hand, with old pruning scars healed into raised pale keloids. Fresh cuts open onto pink, layered wood that pulses dark sap in slow beats; it runs, steams in the cool air and clots in the buckets into a soft jelly with a skin. The keepers wear heavy leather aprons stiff with years of it. Their ears are scarred where the heated needles went in. Last year's fruit hangs dried on a high branch: a pear split to show the white fat under the skin, the pink meat, the ridged bone pit at the core. Marigold's throat is bare and taut with singing, her hat brim stained at the edge where she wiped her hand. Bees crawl in the clotting sap.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Bleeding Orchards are ten thousand acres of fruit trees east of Sated, in long rows on the slopes of what were once hills and may still be. In the Fatlands everything is meat, because the soil is the scattered flesh of the god Ummer, grown back. Orchard trees bleed when they are pruned. Their fruit has skin, fat, flesh and a pit of bone full of sweet grey marrow that children suck through straws. And at pruning in early Grace, the trees scream: a high, wet, wavering sound like a calf at the knife, from ten thousand throats, audible in Sated on a still day.

Sapwell, the chief village, is a village of the deaf. Its keepers go deaf young with heated needles, by choice, so they will not hear, and speak in a quick hand-language of their own that the Thin, the resisters who refuse to eat, have learned. Children are allowed to hear until their tenth year; on the night before the needles they are taken into the oldest grove to listen for an hour, so they know what they are choosing. The sap is collected in buckets for blood-pudding. The keepers' children are given a spoonful warm as a treat and grow up with black-red mouths and strong hearts.

Marigold Chine keeps the oldest grove, and she refused the needles. She sings to her trees through the pruning. They have begun to sing back, in tune, in her voice, a thousand trees at once, and the other keepers, who cannot hear it, feel it in their teeth. In the shot she is reaching the last verse, the wake-song, and she has realised it is about her.

Aldo Pippin, who cannot hear a note, is signing to the man on the ladder to stop cutting, because his own teeth are humming. He has hidden Thin fugitives in the hollow trunks of these trees for twenty years.

At ground level the grove in pruning season is unbearably loud to anyone with ears and perfectly silent to the people who live there. It smells of blossom and of a butcher's apron.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ In a hollow trunk at the right edge, a thin face looks out: a Thin fugitive, and the bark has grown a little further over the opening than last season.
- ◇ Marigold's mouth and the nearest tree's pruning-cut are open to the same shape.
- ◇ One branch above her has been cut with an old hook that the tree remembers; the wound has closed into the shape of a fist.
- ◇ A ten-year-old girl with clean ears sits at the edge of the grove with her hands over them, on the night before the needles.
- ◇ The keepers' hand-sign carved on a ladder rung means *she is singing it back*.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 view along rows of an endless old orchard in a hazy butter-yellow dawn, trees with smooth warm skin-like bark and raised scars, fresh pruning cuts pulsing dark red sap into hanging buckets where it clots. A deaf orchard-keeper on a ladder with a hook, an older keeper signing urgently with his hands, and in the centre a freckled woman in a straw hat singing with her head thrown back while the nearest trees lean toward her. Off-white blossom on dark ground, a split pear showing fat, pink flesh and a bone pit. Tallow yellow light, raw meat red sap, brown shadow, oil and ink-wash texture, beautiful and wrong.

Negative: bright colours, cherry blossom prettiness, cartoon faces on trees, glossy render, modern tools, readable text, gore on

children, sexualised figures, fantasy tree-monsters, cheerful, saturated green

▼ LOW TILTH



I don't say what it means. I only say what it is. Mark, mark, mark. You can see the shape of it from the door.

PELL HOGGET

Plate: LOW TILTH · *The richest soil, the highest Reaping* · the Fatlands · raw meat red and tallow yellow

THE SHOT

Carving dusk in Kettle Furrow, from behind the village supper table in the yard, with a 35mm lens at seated height, looking past the backs of the diners out across the far field. The 3:1 frame is a horizon: one long low table, then one long gold field, then a red sky. Left third: Hogget's Barn, its doors open, the inner walls visible floor to rafter, scored with tally-marks in chalk, knife and paint, and at the door Pell Hogget, short and broad, wheat-coloured beard, a stub of chalk behind his ear. Centre third: the village at supper, two hundred backs in a row, everyone eating outdoors facing the field so that if anyone is Reaped tonight they will not be alone; beyond them the wheat, red at the root, and in it, a hundred yards out, a stretch where every ear for fifty yards is leaning the same way, toward a single bent figure. Right third: the far field, and in it the Scarecrow, tall and thin on its pole, sacking and straw, arms spread, wide hat, a few furrows nearer than last year. Foreground: the end of the table, bowls, bread, a few upturned bowls on a wall. Midground: the diners and the leaning wheat. Background: the Scarecrow and the sky. The lower centre band is the dark underside of the table and the shadowed ground beneath it. The title sits there.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Dusk, the moment the Reaping chooses: the light gone amber, then red, heat lifting off the soil in a haze that bends the horizon. Tallow yellow is the wheat and the lamps on the table. Raw meat red is the

sky, the soil in the furrows, the wheat's roots and the oxblood stain on every barefoot ankle. The Scarecrow stands against the red as a black silhouette. Lamps along the supper table make small warm islands on the faces, and beyond them the field is lit only by the sky, deepening every second.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The wheat is gold from the road, but the nearest ears are split, showing each grain sheathed in moist pink gum with a tooth inside. The furrows are red-brown and glistening and look warm. The diners are big, thick-necked people in homespun, and their bare feet and shins are stained oxblood to the knee from walking behind the plough. On the table: bread with a crust like crackling, torn to show pink fibrous crumb. The barn wall is a ledger of scratches gone soft-edged with handling where pilgrims have touched the marks. The Scarecrow's sacking looks warm, and its straw is toothed wheat. In the leaning patch, the wheat is moving against something in rhythm, the soil around it softened to warm suet.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Low Tilt is the richest farmland in the world: a wide shallow basin south of Sated, black soil that sweats in Plenty like a basted joint, three harvests a year. It also has the highest Reaping of any district. Each Carving, people go out in the fields at dusk and are not back by morning. Sometimes a boot is found standing upright in a furrow, laces tied. Sometimes a set of clothes laid flat in the shape of a body. The Board's official explanation is wolves. There are no wolves in the Fatlands, and never have been. The fields eat. A Reaped man's row is a little redder next year, and his widow bakes his strip's flour into a name-loaf and the family eats it together in the dark.

Kettle Furrow has two hundred and eleven souls by the Board's census and a hundred and ninety-four by Pell Hogget's, and the difference is the Count. Pell is a farmer who noticed his village was one smaller each autumn and wrote it on his barn wall. Now two

hundred villages send him their tallies. His arithmetic shows the Reaping doubling every eight or nine years. The Board, in its root-choked cellar, has the same figures and calls them wolves. The houses here have no locks; a closed door only means the field has to come round to the window.

In the shot the whole village is at Supper in the yard, facing the field, as it does every Carving evening. Someone has gone out to fetch a dropped sickle. The wheat is leaning. Nobody at the table has stood up, because there is no point, and because the field smells like dinner. Pell has come to the barn door with his chalk in his hand. He is not looking at the field. He is counting heads along the table.

At ground level Low Tilt is quiet, polite, well fed and missing people. The ground gives like a mattress over a sleeper, and it is always warm.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ At the end of the table sits Gaffer Tolly Mumbray, the Wolf-Warden, eighty and toothless, with his report on his knee, the word *wolves* half written, crying.
- ◇ The Scarecrow's back is not to the village any more; the shadow of its hat-brim shows it has turned to face the barn.
- ◇ In the leaning patch, a raised arm is bending at the forearm where there is no joint. It is a wave.
- ◇ A set of clothes lies flat in the stubble of last week's strip, arms out, the soil beneath dark and freshly turned.
- ◇ High on the barn wall, apart from every column, is a blank square of planking ringed in chalk: the space for Nell Hogget's mark, which Pell has never been able to write.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 dusk scene in a vast flat wheatfield under a red-amber sky, heat haze over glistening red-brown furrows. In the foreground a long village supper table seen from behind, large barefoot farm folk with oxblood-stained shins eating together and facing the field; to the left an open timber barn whose inner walls are covered floor to rafter in tally-marks, a short bearded farmer with chalk at its door. Far out, a patch of wheat all leaning toward one bent figure, and in the far field a tall thin scarecrow of sacking and toothed straw, arms spread, silhouetted. Tallow yellow and raw meat red, brown-black shadow, oil and ink texture, still, dreadful, mournful.

Negative: bright colours, blue sky, cartoon scarecrow, pumpkin, Halloween, glossy render, tractors, modern farm, readable text, gore on children, sexualised figures, monster jaws, explicit gore, cheerful harvest festival

▼ THE DOWAGER HILLS



Plant him. Feed her to me. Come closer. Sit down. Lie down. Stay.

THE COUNSELS OF THE DOWAGERS, AS NOTED BY
THE HILL-SPEAKER, 640

Plate: THE DOWAGER HILLS · *Nine generations of matriarchs, Seated* · the Fatlands · raw meat red and tallow yellow

THE SHOT

Late afternoon on the old Weighing Road three miles out of Sated, from the path between the mounds, with a 28mm lens at ground level, almost in the grass, so the hills rise like sleeping bodies on both sides. The 3:1 frame is a landscape of curves. Left third: the Eldest, Matron Ysolde Tullow, the first and largest hill, nearest the road, with her gatekeeper's hut and her speaking-place, a warm damp crack in the turf that exhales. Centre third: a younger mound with a mouth, and lying face-down beside it in field-brown, knees and elbows dark with soil, Mercy Sowerby, the Hill-Speaker, laying a joint of meat on the red tongue in the turf with both hands, her ear pressed to the grass. Behind her, a Gut-lines family waits on the path in mourning silk, one of them holding a question written on a card. Right third: the hills going on, ninety-one of them, in rows along the road toward the ramped bulk of Marrable Hall on the farthest rise, and between two of the nearer mounds a narrow seam where their slopes have met and closed. Foreground: short bright grass, warm, with dew on it and a few clover-heads. Midground: Mercy and the mouth. Background: the hill-line and Marrable Hall under a butter sky. The lower centre band is the shaded hollow between the path and the mounds. The title sits there.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Low, warm, flat late sun, tallow yellow, raking across the mounds so their curves read like shoulders and hips under a sheet. Raw meat red is the mouth in the turf, the joint in Mercy's hands, and the lips of the Eldest's crack. A faint steam rises from the turf everywhere and catches the light. Long shadows run between the hills into darkness. Mercy's face, pressed to the turf, is in shadow; only the meat in her hands and the wet lip of the mouth catch the full warmth of the sun.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The grass on the Dowagers is short, soft and too bright, like velvet on a coffin. Under it the turf is visibly warm, steaming at dawn even in Lack. The speaking-mouth is a wet red pond-edge in the green, lipped with turf where a chin once was, its teeth rows of wheat-teeth, its tongue working slowly around the meat with a sound like a slow mill. Higher on the same hill, deep in the grass, a pair of closed lids are faintly fluttering. The Eldest's crack is dark, moist and rimmed with fine pale roots that stir when it exhales. Mercy's dress is caked brown at the front. Her cheek is pressed to the turf, and the turf is pressing back, a little.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

In the Fatlands the heaviest do not die. The Laden grow until their feet root, their bulk spreads into the soil, the soil rises to meet them, and at the last they are Seated: a person becomes a place, a low warm hill where things grow very well. Some keep a mouth. Some keep eyes that open in rain. The Dowager Hills are ninety-one mounds along the Weighing Road, nine generations of Gut-lines matriarchs, the oldest of them Matron Ysolde Tullow, the first Laden, who rooted in her own kitchen in the year 61.

The families still consult their Dowagers on marriage, inheritance and precedence. The fee is the best cut of the last wake, laid in the speaking-place by the Hill-Speaker on duty. The Dowager eats, then

answers, sometimes in minutes and sometimes after a day, in a voice felt through the feet. They know true parentage, hidden debts, which fields will Reap. They are rarely wrong. They are also no longer the women they were, and their counsel narrows each year: *Stay. Lie down. Come closer.* The Eldest answers every question now with one word: *Down.*

Mercy Sowerby is a young widow, thin-lipped and careful, employed by the Gut-lines to interpret. She lies face-down to hear. She has noticed that two hills have moved close enough to touch, that their mouths are talking to each other in a language older than Table-speech, and that the hill-census shows three hundred and eleven hills creeping toward Sated. In the shot she has laid the joint and is waiting, ear to the ground. The mound has just spoken. It has used her name.

At ground level the hills breathe in sequence, a long slow wave of rising and falling turf moving down the road, as though passing something along. Anyone who sleeps a night here wakes with roots begun.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The seam between the two touching hills has a line of fresh molehill-like heaps along it: the mouths have dug toward each other.
- ◇ The family's question-card reads only *Which of us?* and someone has already circled a name.
- ◇ Wem Haddle, the Fenn house's head Carrier, stands at the edge of the path looking at a newer hill, holding his hat: his mistress, and he does not know how long it takes a hill to forget its Carrier.
- ◇ Near the Eldest's crack, the turf has grown up over a pair of shoes left by a visitor who slept there.
- ◇ Bees from a hive on a mound's flank are carrying dark honey: grandmother honey, which tastes of a long life ending.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 landscape at low golden sun of a road winding between dozens of smooth rounded green burial-like mounds that are the living bodies of ancient women turned into hills, short velvety too-bright grass steaming, the curves suggesting shoulders and hips under a sheet. In one mound a wet red mouth with rows of wheat-like teeth opens in the turf, and a thin young widow in soil-stained brown lies face-down beside it, laying a raw joint of meat on its tongue, her ear to the grass. A family in mourning silk waits behind her. Tallow yellow light, raw meat red, long black shadows, oil and ink-wash texture, quiet, pastoral, deeply wrong.

Negative: bright colours, cartoon faces, cute hills, fantasy creatures, glossy render, modern clothing, fences of wire, readable text, gore on children, sexualised bodies, nudity, explicit gore, cheerful picnic

▼ THE CHUTE



Beef booms, pork thuds, flour hisses. And some of them knock back.

BARRELSIDE CHILDREN'S LORE

Plate: THE CHUTE · *Origin stamped over twice* · the Fatlands · raw meat red and tallow yellow

THE SHOT

Night at the Chute, from halfway down the long stone ramp, with a 35mm lens at the height of a barrel, looking diagonally up the slope so the ramp climbs from the lower right to the upper left. The 3:1 frame is full of motion. Left third: the top of the ramp, the salting-sheds and rendering-houses of Barreelside stacked against a smoky sky, chimneys pouring, and barrels being tipped onto the stone by red-armed Hooks in leather aprons. Centre third: the ramp itself, a river of oak barrels rolling down it, and at the stamping-post beside it Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot, portly, bald and freckled, his stamp on a cord, bringing it down on a barrel's lid with a tremor in his left hand, a small knife in that hand making a notch. Right third: the foot of the ramp, the Rim Road Company's wagons waiting in a line, a Company notary at a bench tallying each barrel on a platter, and the road running away north into darkness. Foreground: a barrel that has rolled off the ramp and lies on its side close to us, its stamped lid toward the viewer, a puddle of brine spreading under it. Midground: Ivo and the rolling barrels. Background: sheds, smoke, the waiting road. The lower centre band is the dark stone at the ramp's foot and the brine puddle, calm and shadowed. The title sits there.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Rendering-fires and tallow lamps, thick tallow yellow and hot orange smudged by steam. Raw meat red is the Hooks' forearms, the

blood in the gutters beside the ramp, the brine seeping from the barrel staves, and the wax of the Company seal. The road beyond the wagons falls into black. Steam and smoke fill the upper third with yellow murk. The faces of the Hooks are lit from below by the gutter-glow, and Ivo alone stands in a pale pool of lamplight, which makes him look ill.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Oak barrels, iron-hooped, dark with brine at the seams, each lid burned with an origin stamp and that stamp struck over twice more until it is a blot. The ramp stone is worn into two shallow grooves by six centuries of rolling. Gutters on each side run with blood and hot fat and brine, steaming. The Hooks are red-armed, salt-chapped, with forearms like hams and cracked knuckles. Ivo's apron is spotless; his face is shiny with sweat and he is pale. The fallen barrel's staves have sprung slightly, and from the gap a pale thing shows, wet and folded, that could be pork. Salt crusts on everything. Over everything hangs a fine grease-mist that beads on hair, lashes and lamp-glass alike.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Chute is the Rim Road export depot at the Fatlands' northern edge, where the Great Gravy meets the Road: a mile of rendering-houses, salting-sheds, cooperages and stockyards built around a long stone ramp down which barrels roll, day and night, into the Company's wagons. Everything the Fatlands sell the rest of the Table leaves here, in oak: meat, flour, dripping, the Laden god by the pound. Every land that buys knows, somewhere it does not visit, what it is buying. The meat goes out with its origin stamped over twice.

The town around it is Barreelside, Renderers' Union country absolutely. Its people are red-armed, foul-mouthed, proud and well paid by Fatland standards, and nothing that happens here surprises them. A new Hook is initiated by being sealed in an empty barrel for

a night in the salting-shed and let out at dawn by the whole yard, who sing. The smell reaches eleven miles on the Belch. The children can tell a barrel's contents by the sound it makes rolling.

Ivo Stockpot feeds the army and stamps the export barrels: a fussy, honest man with a tremor in his left hand. He has started marking a small notch on the ones he would not eat from himself. There are a great many notches. In the shot he has just notched another, and a yard-warden at the top of the ramp has seen him do it. Ivo has not seen the yard-warden. He wants someone outside the Fatlands to know what is in the barrels. He fears that if they knew, they would keep buying.

At ground level the Chute is deafening: hammers on hoops, bawling stock, the endless boom and thud of barrels on stone. It is hot, slick and salt-stung. You breathe through your mouth and taste it.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The fallen barrel in the foreground has a notch in its lid, and from inside comes a faint answering knock.
- ◇ Under the triple overstamp, the first origin-mark is just legible as the curve of a Dusk Acres corner-stone number.
- ◇ A Vigil buyer at the notary's bench is eating from an open barrel with his fingers, his eyes too bright.
- ◇ Two Barreside children sit on the ramp wall with their ears to the stone, listening.
- ◇ Ivo's tally-book, open on the post, has a column of notches running off the bottom of the page.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 night scene of a long worn stone ramp descending diagonally through a smoky industrial town of rendering-houses and salting-sheds, a river of iron-hooped oak barrels rolling down it, their lids stamped and over-stamped into blots. At a post beside the ramp a portly bald freckled quartermaster in a clean apron brings down a heavy stamp while secretly notching a lid with a small knife. Red-armed workers in leather aprons at the top, a line of waiting wagons and a notary tallying at the bottom, gutters running with blood, brine and fat, steam everywhere. Tallow yellow firelight, raw meat red, black shadows, oil and ink grit, industrial dread.

Negative: bright colours, modern factory, conveyor belts, metal machinery, trucks, cartoon, glossy render, readable text, logos, gore on children, sexualised figures, explicit butchery close-up, cheerful

▼ LOW MARK



*You walk west to work, everybody does, the whole Mile
flows west in the morning like water down a gutter,
and you try not to think about that.*

A CANNERY GIRL OF MILE THIRTEEN

Plate: LOWMARK · *Nineteen miles of pier after a leaving sea* · Brinehollow · drowned teal and salt-white

THE SHOT

Dawn on Mile Twelve, at the start of the Lashings, from a shack doorway hung over the edge of the pier, with a 24mm lens at sitting height, looking west along the Mile as it runs away to the horizon on its tarred pilings sixty feet high. The 3:1 frame is one long perspective line. Left third: the doorway of a slum shack slung on chains, and in it Tolly Brack, eleven, freckled under the salt-grime, an old man face-down across his knee, pounding his back as cold water gouts into a bucket. Centre third: the Mile itself, a wooden road lined with leaning houses, chandlers, chapels and bail-houses, everything tilting slightly west, and the morning crowd already walking west along it to work, hundreds of small figures, all going one way. Right third: the edge of the pier, and below it, sixty feet down in grey twilight, the Underpier, a drowned forest of pilings over black mud, with small lamps among them; on the far horizon, nineteen miles out, the faint pale raw wood of the newest pier and a thread of grey sea. Foreground: Tolly's bucket, the anchoring ring by the door, a rope coiled through it. Midground: the Mile and its westward crowd. Background: the horizon, the leaving sea. The lower centre band is the dark gap between the pier's edge and the Underpier below, a calm drop into shadow. The title sits over that drop.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Grey dawn from behind us in the east, thin and salt-hazed, laying a cold drowned teal over everything and silvering the wet planks. Salt-white is the rime on the ropes, the lace-crust of dried rain on oiled-paper windows, the froth in the buckets, the gulls. Below the pier the Underpier is in deep teal-black twilight, its lamps tiny and yellowish. The far sea is a single pale line. Wet planks catch the dawn in long silver strips, and the bail-water pouring from the sills glints teal-white as it runs west along the gutters.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Tarred pilings crusted white with salt and furred with dead weed. Planks warped, nail-heads bleeding rust down the grain. Shacks of oilskin, canvas and wreck-timber, roped and chained three deep over the edge. The old man across Tolly's knee is grey and thin, his nightshirt soaked, his mouth open over the bucket, clear faintly green water and a thread of weed coming up in a gout; a sand-flea on the rim. Tolly's hands are small, strong and cracked white along every crease. Every ankle in the street carries a rope-burn from the night's anchoring knot. Everyone's eyes are red-rimmed from salt. Bail-water pours off windowsills into the gutters, and the gutters run west. Fish-gut and tar smoke hang in the air, implied by brown smears on the canvas.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Lowmark is the capital of Brinehollow, a city that chased its sea. Since 512 the ocean has been leaving the western coast, furlongs then miles a year, and the great port has followed it nineteen miles out across the dry seabed on a road of piers. The old town on the shore, the Headland, holds the Admiralty and Fathomhouse. From it the Mile runs west: Mile One rich, Mile Seven Netwatch barracks, Twelve to Sixteen the Lashings, slum shacks slung on chains, then the Raw Mile, pale new wood, then Harbor End, where a few licensed boats still reach water.

Every Brinehollower has a tide. Twice a day, at dawn and dusk, their lungs fill with salt water from nowhere, and they bail it out, bent over a bucket, coughing in long racking gouts. The old, the sick and the drunk must be bailed by others, held head-down and struck between the shoulders. At night everyone sleeps tied to a ring, because the sea calls, and the Called walk west and do not come back, or come back Tenanted.

Tolly Brack is eleven and goes door to door up the Mile at dawn bailing those too weak to cough for themselves, a crumb a time, singing his mother's bailing song under his breath. He knows from the colour of the water who will be Called next. Blue means soon. His mother went when he was six, after a winter of begging him to cut her loose. In the shot he is looking at this bucket, and it is beginning to turn blue, and he is deciding whether to tell the old man's daughter, who is standing in the shack behind him tying her own knot.

Below them the Underpier lives on what the Mile drops: Pickers, runaways, the Tenanted whose families would not have them back, humming in the dark between Miles Ten and Eleven.

At ground level Lowmark creaks, coughs and sways, and walking west feels like a descent, though the Mile is flat.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The Lashings' common chain links every shack's anchor-ring along the row; one link near the frame's right edge has been sawn half through.
- ◇ Below the pier, an Underpier child stands in the mud beneath a shack whose rope hangs cut, saying a name upward.
- ◇ In the crowd walking west, one figure walks east, against them, heavier than her size, leaving wet footprints.
- ◇ At the far western end, a line of fresh pilings stands in the mud beyond the last pier, driven by no one in the day crews.
- ◇ Tolly's boot has the curved handle of a cannery knife showing at the top.
- ◇ A red high-water line painted on a cellar hatch has been repainted a hand-span higher this Grace.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 view at grey dawn along an endless wooden pier-city running west to the horizon on tarred salt-crustured pilings sixty feet high, leaning houses, slum shacks hung on chains over the edge, hundreds of small figures walking west, a grey twilight forest of pilings and black mud far below. In the left foreground a small freckled boy in a shack doorway holds a frail old man face-down over his knee, pounding his back as cold green seawater gouts into a bucket. Drowned teal light, salt-white rime and froth and gulls, a thin pale line of distant sea. Oil and ink-wash texture, dry-brush grit, everything leaning slightly west, weary endurance.

Negative: bright colours, blue sky, sunny beach, cartoon, glossy render, modern boardwalk, metal railings, cars, readable text, gore

on children, sexualised figures, pirates, cheerful harbour



For four hundred years they heard the sea. For the last eleven, every child has said they heard someone counting.

THE SLABSIDE LISTENING BOOK, MARGINAL NOTE
IN GRANDAM SOLLIS'S HAND

Plate: LONGSLAB · *The beach that has never dried* · Brinehollow · drowned teal and salt-white

THE SHOT

At the turn of the tide on Longslab, from very low on the stones, with a 28mm lens a hand's breadth above the wet shingle, looking along the beach so it runs away flat to a misty vanishing point two miles off. The 3:1 frame is almost all ground and fog. Left third: the edge of Slabside on the low bluff above, grey turf-roofed cottages with their doors facing inland and their west walls blind, a single lantern on a post. Centre third: on the wet stones close to us, Grandam Weir Sollis, keeper of the listening book, sitting on a folding stool with the book open on her lap and a pencil, and beside her a Slabside child of seven lying face-down on the shingle for the one hour of their life, arms at their sides, cheek pressed to the stones, eyes open. Right third: the beach running away into fog, scattered with pilgrims of the Deepening lying face-down at intervals like the drowned, and far off, the black ribs of something too large to be any animal's showing through the shingle where the middens have shifted. Foreground: the wet stones, every one glistening, water welling between them. Midground: the old woman and the child. Background: the pilgrims, the ribs, the fog. The lower centre band is the shingle itself, dark, wet and still. The title sits on the stones.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Overcast, sourceless, the sky the colour of a gutted herring; a flat, cold, drowned teal light lying on the wet stones so each one holds a dull highlight. Salt-white is the rime on the stones higher up the beach, the Grandam's shawl, the pages of the book and the fog. The single lantern on Slabside's bluff is a faint yellow point. No gulls: the sky over the beach is empty. The wet stones around the child's face hold a faint teal sheen, as if lit from beneath, and the open pages of the book are the brightest thing in the frame.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The shingle is dark and polished and always wet, water seeping up between the stones as if the whole beach were a sponge someone is always pressing; around the child's cheek and hands a thin film of water has gathered. The stones nearest the turn of the tide have a faint lift and fall, as the ground breathes. Moss and salt-rime crust the higher shingle. The child's woollen jumper is darkening with damp from beneath. Grandam Sollis's hands are knotted, her knuckles white with salt-crack, her pencil worn to a stub. The far ribs are grey-black, porous, huge, curving out of the stones like the keel-timbers of a wrecked ship, and between them the shingle has sunk. The pilgrims' clothes are soaked through from lying there all night.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Longslab is the beach of the Beaching. In the ninth winter of the Lack, the Sounders found Dromm, the Fathom, god of the deep sea and of what is kept under, lying in the shallows off this long flat beach. The coast hauled it ashore on ten thousand hooks over four days, and the Admiralty still reads the names of the Hook-Brides given on the third night with honour, and has hanged the clerk who worked out that the tide, not the brides, brought it in. Then the coast ate it, and the sea came into the people.

No sea has touched Longslab in a century, and it has never dried. At the tide-turns the ground breathes, a slow sigh across two miles of stones and a smell of the deep, a tide pool sealed for a thousand years. Gulls will not land here. The middens beneath are full of bones too large to be any animal's, and they are shifting.

Slabside, above it, is the oldest village on the coast and the least changed. Its people speak softly and seldom. Pilgrims of the Deepening, who believe the Calling is a homecoming, come to lie face-down on the stones and listen, and Slabside sells them lodging, rope and damp pebbles. And once in their lives, every Slabside child is taken down at the turn of the tide by their grandparents and laid face-down for a full hour, then asked what they heard, and the answer is written in the village book.

Grandam Weir Sollis keeps the book. For four hundred years the children said they heard the sea. For the last eleven, every child has said they heard someone counting. In the shot the hour is nearly up. The child's lips have started moving. Grandam Sollis has her pencil on the page, and she is not writing, because the child has just told her what number it has reached.

At ground level Longslab is cold, wet and utterly quiet, and the stones are warm when they should not be.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The child's lips are shaped on a number; follow the pencil marks in the open book and the numbers rise year on year, and are nearing eight.
- ◇ In the fog, one face-down pilgrim has been turned over, and the stones that weighted them are stacked neatly beside the body.
- ◇ An old hauling-hook, rusted to lace, lies half buried near the child's hand, with a lover's knot still visible in its iron.
- ◇ The water welling around the child's cheek forms a faint ring, and the ring's surface is trembling in time, not with the child's breath.
- ◇ On Slabside's bluff, every cottage door faces inland but one, which has been bricked up on its west wall from the inside.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 low view across an endless flat beach of dark wet shingle under a fog-grey sky, water welling up between the stones, no sea in sight, no birds. In the centre an old woman in a salt-white shawl sits on a stool with an open ledger, and beside her a small child lies face-down on the wet stones with eyes open, listening. Far down the beach, pilgrims lie face-down at intervals like drowned bodies, and enormous dark porous ribs curve up out of the shingle. Grey turf-roofed cottages with blind walls on a low bluff to the left. Drowned teal and salt-white, oil and ink-wash texture, vast negative space, silence.

Negative: bright colours, sunny beach, blue sea, seagulls, cartoon, glossy render, modern clothing, readable text, gore on

children, harm to the child, sexualised figures, sea monsters, tentacles, cheerful seaside

▼ THE UNCOVERED



*Sweet's new. Sour's a year. Nothing's old. When you
get nothing, mind your feet.*

UNCOVERED SALVAGER'S LORE

Plate: THE UNCOVERED · *A new mile of seabed every year* ·
Brinehollow · drowned teal and salt-white

THE SHOT

Late afternoon, twelve miles out on the exposed seabed, from the crest of a mud-bank with a 35mm lens at standing height, looking west down a long shallow slope into a drowned valley. The 3:1 frame is a strange country. Left third: a salvage party of four on a rope-line between marker-stakes, led by Hask Tarn, the pilot, lean and weathered, swinging a sounding-lead on its cord, one hand raised to stop the others. Centre third: the valley floor, and in it the Upright Ships, a dozen wrecks of every age standing on their keels on the mud as though still sailing, crews leathered at their posts, and beyond them the arched ribs of a Whale Cathedral, the flesh run off them like candle-wax into a shining lake of fat. Right third: the Leather Forest, kelp sixty feet high gone stiff and brown as old saddles, dripping; and running west out of it toward the far fog, a straight road of fitted black stone, older than anything, its kerbs carved with seated figures. Foreground: cracked white salt crust, wreck-debris, a sounding-lead line running into a crack. Midground: the party, the ships, the ribs. Background: the forest, the road, the fog bank rolling in. The lower centre band is the shadowed mud of the valley floor below the crest, calm and dark. The title sits on the mud.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Low western light through haze, coming toward us, so the wrecks and ribs are silhouetted and every wet surface carries a cold sheen.

Drowned teal is the mud, the shadows, the fog and the dead blue coral on a far reef. Salt-white is the crust in the foreground, the leathered sailors' crusted faces, the bleached ribs and the fog's edge. A faint cold glow from the Blue Reefs at the far left edge. The fat-lake around the whale's ribs reflects the sky as a dull pearly sheet, and every wet rib and mast is edged with a thin line of salt-white.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Salt crust cracked into plates like dry skin. Black mud with a wet sheen, pocked with crab-holes. Wrecks crusted with dead barnacles, their timbers spongy, their rigging hung with dried weed and, here and there, a skeleton still in the shrouds. The leathered crews are brown, shrunken, their faces drawn tight over the bones, eyes gone to slits, hands fused to wheels and ropes, heads turned west. The whale's flesh has slumped off its ribs in grey, pink and green curtains and pooled in lakes of fat that never set, crabs moving through them. The Leather Forest sweats slime that drips constantly. Hask Tarn's face is cracked white along every line; his sounding-lead is greasy and worn bright. Everything glistens, and nothing is quite dry.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Uncovered is the seabed the sea left behind: a new mile of it every year since 512, salvage country, lawless and strange. Near the old shore it is cracked white salt littered with six centuries of wreckage. Further out it turns to mud flats, leather-weed jungle and drowned valleys, the largest graveyard on the Table, still being dug. Things live here that came up as the water fell and did not die properly: cart-sized crabs, soft and slow; ribbed things that drag themselves on fins at night; fish that breathe air badly, snoring. And older things, uncovered for the first time since before the Gorging: carved stones, paved roads running west, and at least one table.

The people out here are salvage crews with their own secret tracks, stakes and rope-lines, stripping wrecks for Rim Road

platters, brass and timber; layers of the dead, who lay the ordinary dead face-down on the flats under stones; and pilots, who know the ground. Nobody enforces anything but knives. The mud changes with every flood of the indoor tide that seeps up from below, and a track that held last month goes into a sinkhole. Salvagers do not take anything from a ship whose crew is still aboard.

Hask Tarn used to pilot ships over this ground and navigates by remembered depth: *six fathom here, sand bottom; mind, it shelves*. He is never lost. In the shot he has stopped the party on the crest because the lead swinging from his hand has gone still and is pulling, very slightly, west, toward the Old Road, and because one of the leathered helmsmen in the valley, who was facing west yesterday, is facing east. He knows the way to the Stone Table. He steered over it in 581, and the lead came up warm. He is not going to tell them.

At ground level the Uncovered stinks of low tide that never turns, and the snoring of the gasping fish carries for miles at dusk.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ One leathered sailor on the nearest wreck has his head turned east, toward the party.
- ◇ On the Old Road, a carved bowl in the paving holds fresh water, and floating in it is a cut wrist-knot of linen.
- ◇ A long smooth furrow runs across the valley floor westward, as if something huge had been dragged; its edges are still wet.
- ◇ Inside a dying soft-shelled crab at the edge of the fat-lake, through the membrane, a human shape is curled as if asleep.
- ◇ At the road's vanishing point, barely visible in the fog, a table stands laid with a white cloth and one chair pulled out.
- ◇ The kerb carvings show figures seated at tables in rows; count them along one stretch and there are seven, then a gap.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 landscape of a vast exposed dried seabed at low hazy western light: cracked white salt crust in the foreground, a drowned valley of black mud where a dozen shipwrecks stand upright on their keels with leathered dead sailors at their posts, the arched ribs of a beached whale with rotting flesh slumped off them like candle wax into pools of fat, a forest of giant stiff brown kelp dripping slime, and a straight ancient road of black fitted stone running west into fog. A lean weathered pilot swings a sounding-lead, halting a roped salvage party. Drowned teal and salt-white, oil and ink texture, desolate, enormous.

Negative: bright colours, blue ocean, tropical, pirates, cartoon, glossy render, modern ships, steel hulls, readable text, gore on children, sexualised figures, sea monster attack, tentacles, cheerful adventure

▼ THE HANGING ABBEY



Every night it asks. Every night I say no. That's the whole of the rule. The rest is just weather.

A BOUND MONK OF THE HIGH FACE

Plate: THE HANGING ABBEY · *A cliff hung with a thousand living monks* · Brinehollow · drowned teal and salt-white

THE SHOT

Dawn, at the foot of the cliff in the boulder field of Basketfoot, with a 21mm lens at standing height tilted steeply up, so the black basalt face rises four hundred feet to fill the frame and leans over us. The 3:1 frame is a wall. Left third: the Basketfoot winch-house, a great wooden wheel, and at its bar Winchmaster Cobb Fennick, heavy-shouldered, hauling, a food basket rising on its chain up the cliff. Centre third: the face itself, studded with ledges and scooped cells, and on every one a monk in a canvas habit chained by an iron collar to a ring in the rock, hundreds of them, small and pale, and near the top, on a ledge a day's climb up, a single figure older and thinner than the rest: Father Ebb. At this moment every monk is bent forward, bailing, and water runs down the rock in sheets. Right third: the dry white boulder field running away to where the sea once was, and among the boulders low mounds of stones, each with an iron collar half buried in it, and a villager with a long cart. Foreground: wet boulders, a basket-letter fallen in a puddle. Midground: the winch, the lowest ledges. Background: the high face, the grey sky. The lower centre band is the dark wet base of the cliff where the runoff pools among the boulders, calm and black. The title sits there.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Grey dawn from the sea-side, low and cold, raking along the cliff so every ledge throws a shadow and every chained figure is edge-lit.

Drowned teal is the wet basalt, the pools, the shadows of the cells. Salt-white is the habits, the salt-crust on the rock, the sheets of runoff catching the light, the bleached bones lowered in baskets, and the white boulders. A tiny orange stain shows at every throat: rust. Higher up, the cells are in deep shadow, and only the pale faces and the wet rock between them catch the dawn.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Black basalt, columnar and slick, crusted white with salt where the rain dries, stained orange in long streaks below every ring. Chains greasy and rusted. On the nearer monks the collars are visible in detail: the neck has grown round the iron, the skin ulcerated, scabbed and finally healed over the rim like bark over a nail, so the collar is part of the throat and stains it orange from inside. Ledge-sores on hips and shoulders kept open by salt rain. On a higher ledge, a dead monk is still chained in place as a teaching, picked half clean by gulls, and the living monk beside him is talking to him. The baskets are wicker, dark with wet. Cobb's palms are hide. The runoff is foaming slightly, salt-white.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Hanging Abbey is the cliff of the Anchorites, forty miles north of Lowmark: four hundred feet of black basalt above a field of dry white boulders that was once the sea. On the coast the sea calls the people west at night, and the Called walk into the water and do not come back, or come back with something living in them. The Anchorites believe the Calling is a temptation, and that refusing it every night for a whole life is the only holiness left. So a thousand living monks have chained themselves permanently to the rock by iron collars, each on a ledge or in a scooped cell open to the salt rain, where the sea can never take them.

Food goes up in baskets. Waste comes down. At dawn and dusk the whole cliff coughs at once as the thousand bail, and water runs down the rock in sheets. At night they pray aloud, or scream, and

from below no one can tell which. Monks whose chains fail fall four hundred feet.

Basketfoot lives at the bottom: a few dozen stone huts, a pilgrims' hostel and the winch-house. The village hauls the baskets, carries basket-letters up, which a monk must read before he eats, and gathers what falls, burying it face-down among the boulders with its collar still on.

Cobb Fennick has hauled every basket for twenty-six years and reads every letter before it goes up. Once a year he writes one himself, to Father Ebb, unsigned. This is that morning. Father Ebb, seventy-eight, chained fifty-one years, a skeleton in canvas, has felt the Calling every night of them. His chain has been rusted through for twelve years. He knows. What holds him is a promise sworn on a girl's rope in 589.

At ground level Basketfoot smells of boiled oats, rust and runoff, and the creak of a thousand chains above sounds like a ship at anchor.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Father Ebb's chain, at the high ledge, hangs in two pieces; only his hand on the ring holds it closed.
- ◇ The fallen basket-letter in the foreground is addressed *Edric*, Father Ebb's name before the cliff.
- ◇ One stone mound in the boulder field has been dug at, from beneath.
- ◇ A Postulant on a trial-chain on the lowest rocks is climbing down; above him, one monk is climbing up from the ring he was given.
- ◇ A Wreckwife's charity basket in the winch-house holds bread, gin and a coil of new rope.
- ◇ Every chained figure on the face is bent west except Father Ebb, who faces the land.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 view steeply up a towering black basalt sea-cliff at grey dawn, its face studded with hundreds of ledges and cells where gaunt monks in salt-white canvas habits are chained by iron collars grown into their necks, all bent forward coughing up seawater that runs down the rock in sheets. A great wooden winch and a heavy villager hauling a wicker basket up on a chain at the left; a field of dry white boulders and stone grave-mounds with half-buried iron collars at the right. Rust streaks below every ring, a dead monk left chained on a high ledge. Drowned teal and salt-white, oil and ink-wash grit, devotional, endless, cold.

Negative: bright colours, sunshine, blue sea, cartoon, glossy render, modern climbing gear, ropes of nylon, readable text, gore on children, sexualised figures, fantasy monastery towers, cheerful, heroic poses

▼ THE TRENCH



At the edge you can hear it going. Like a throat. Like the whole sea being swallowed, and something very patient doing the swallowing.

FOREMAN BASTIAN GUTTER OF THE RAW MILE

Plate: THE TRENCH · *Where the water is going* · Brinehollow · drowned teal and salt-white

THE SHOT

Night, thirty miles beyond Lowmark's last pier, at the brink where the Uncovered ends, with a 24mm lens at standing height pointing west over the edge, so the land stops along a ragged line a third of the way up the frame and everything above it is black water falling away. The 3:1 frame is a precipice. Left third: a line of tall fresh pilings marching out from behind us across the mud in a perfectly straight row, driven deep, still wet with tar, and standing beside the last one, a lantern in one hand and her carpenter's pencil in the other, Harbormistress Kessa Drowle, tar to the elbows, staring at the place where the line runs out of ground. Centre third: the edge itself, cracked mud and salt shelving away, and beyond it the Trench: black water that has not dropped, its surface curving down and away like the lip of a drain, the current running downward. Far down in the black, a light, very deep, faint, there and gone. Right third: the brink curving away north into darkness, a broken Salt Assay gauge-post leaning at the lip, and three figures from the Raw Mile crews, Tenanted, standing at the edge in their nightshirts with blistered hands, faces turned down, perfectly calm. Foreground: wet mud, a pile-driver's maul, rope. Midground: Kessa, the last piling, the lip. Background: the black water and the deep light. The lower centre band is the mud just before the brink, dark and flat. The title sits there, at the edge.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Almost no light. Kessa's lantern gives a small warm-white circle on her hands and the piling. Everything else is drowned teal-black. Salt-white is the crust on the brink, the rime frosting the pilings' tops in the warm updraft, the Tenanted's nightshirts and their pale faces, and the faint sourceless light far down in the water, which should be cold and greenish-white, there and not there. The rising mist catches the lantern in a dim halo, and the black water reflects nothing at all, as if it were not a surface but a hole.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The fresh pilings are pale pine under dripping black tar, their tops split by the driver, and they are driven deep into mud that is too soft to hold anything. The brink is cracked salt shelf over black silt, crumbling at the lip in slow lumps that go over without a sound. The water beyond is glossy, heavy, with a faint downward sheen like the inside of a funnel. A warm updraft rises from it, breath-smelling, misting the lantern glass. The Tenanted crewmen's skin is grey and taut, hands blistered raw from the maul, eyes black and wide, a thread of clear cold water running from their ears. Kessa's knuckles are white on the lantern, her face cracked by salt, her mouth moving on a measurement.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Trench is where the sea is going. Thirty miles west of Lowmark's last pier the Uncovered ends at a cliff edge, and beyond it lies black water that has not dropped at all, an abyss of unknown depth with a current running downward. From the edge you can hear it draining, a low endless sound like a throat swallowing. Salvagers who go to the brink report a warm updraft that smells of breath, and a light, very deep, that comes and goes. The Salt Assay has proved with buckets and arithmetic that the sea is not evaporating, and has been forbidden to say where it is going instead. Few go to the edge. Fewer return. Dagna Hull is building a sealed

iron vessel, the *Follow*, to chase the water down, and has nine hundred volunteers.

Kessa Drowle builds Lowmark's next mile of pier each year. She has calculated the year the timber runs out and the year the sea drops off the shelf entirely, and they are the same year, 650. Beyond the twentieth mile the seabed falls to the Trench and pilings will have nothing to stand on. She has begun ordering pilings longer than any sea could need and does not know why. Her foreman kept from her that at dawn, three times this Carving, new pilings have been found standing west of the pier's end in a straight line, still wet. The Tenanted among the crews get up in the night, quiet as cats, and come back with blistered hands.

Tonight she followed the line herself, thirty miles, by lantern. It ends here. In the shot she has just seen that the last piling is not the last: there is another beyond the lip, standing in the water, driven into nothing, and below it another, going down like a stair.

At ground level the Trench is warm when the whole coast is cold, and the swallowing never stops.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Beyond the lip, a further row of piling-tops descends into the black water in a straight line, like a stair going down.
- ◇ The Salt Assay gauge-post's gauge is snapped off; carved into the wood below it is a long column of tallies and the word *matches*.
- ◇ In the deep light, if looked at long enough, there is a shape like a hand, grey and longer than a boat, palm up.
- ◇ Kessa's pencil has written, on the piling beside her, a depth figure that is not a number but a name.
- ◇ One of the Tenanted crewmen still wears a cut wrist-rope, the knot neatly tied, the cut clean.
- ◇ Far down, eight faint points of light, one closer than the rest.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly 3:1 night scene at the edge of an exposed seabed where cracked salt-crust mud ends abruptly at a precipice, beyond it a vast abyss of glossy black water curving downward like the lip of a drain, a faint cold light glimmering far below. A straight line of freshly tarred pine pilings marches across the mud to the brink and continues down into the water like a descending stair. A salt-cracked woman in a tar-stained coat holds a lantern beside the last piling; three grey, calm, black-eyed men in nightshirts with blistered hands stand at the edge looking down. Drowned teal-black and salt-white, warm mist, oil and ink texture, immense negative space.

Negative: bright colours, moonlit blue glow, cartoon, glossy render, modern pier, steel, electric lights, readable text, gore on children, sexualised figures, tentacled monster, portal effects, cheerful, sci-fi



CHAPTER 4

PLATES OF THE
VIGIL,
CRADLEWRACK
AND OATHEN

These fifteen plates cover the three lands where the god is still at work in the body: the Vigil, which cannot close its eyes; Cradlewrack, which cannot stop opening; and Oathen, which cannot unsay anything. Each land gets five headers. The first shows the country or its capital at full width, and the other four go down, district by district, toward the place where the rule is hardest to bear.

All three lands share one problem for the painter, which is restraint. The Vigil's horror is comfort, so its plates must look warm and dangerous at once: lamp amber smeared into a brown smoke ceiling, and the soft grey of a quiet afternoon. Cradlewrack's horror is birth, and its plates keep the camera on the adults, the way the Attendance does. We see the midwife's back, the apprentice holding the door, a seam, a stake gone from the rim, and we never see an

infant's body. Oathen's horror is the word, and its plates are silent: felt, gold, ochre stone and dried blood, and mouths that have learned what a sentence costs.

Every plate has a named person in it, because these lands are made of people still trying to be kind inside an impossible rule. Every plate leaves the lower centre band dark and calm for the title. And every plate holds back one small wrongness about a table, a chair, a door or a guest, for the sharp-eyed. Paint it and do not explain it.

Accent colours: **the Vigil**, lamp amber and smoke; **Cradlewrack**, wet iron red and clay; **Oathen**, canyon ochre and dried-blood brown. One accent per plate, and everything else is near-monochrome.

▼ THE VIGIL



Nobody born in the Vigil has ever seen a star. I have never wanted to see one.

A MIRROR-CLIMBER OF THE LAMPLIGHTERS' GUILD,
SECOND RANK

Plate: THE VIGIL · *The city that has not slept in three centuries* · the Vigil · lamp amber and smoke

THE SHOT

We are on the tin roof of a house on Cinder Row, high on the Slope, at the Seventh Bell. The lens is a wide 24mm held at a kneeling eye-height, so the roof's ridge runs in from the lower left like a road. The **left third** is Wenna Startle, mirror-climber of the Lamplighters' Guild, Second Rank. She kneels on the loose overlapping tin with her rag-bag and polish-pot, rubbing the greasy skin of smoke off a mirror as tall as she is. Her own face looks back from the cleaned half: hollow-eyed, mouth slack, a pin held crosswise in her teeth. The **centre third** is the city, ten thousand public lamps and a hundred thousand more in windows, falling away down the Slope and rising again in terraces of mirrors toward the Height. On the far summit, small and exact, stands the grey hollow tower of the Nodding Stair. Between the two, as a dark oval, lies the Pillow, ringed with fence-lamps on poles like a bruise circled in pins. The **right third** is the Lid's edge: the plateau stops in a sheer grey cliff, and below it is soft black heather country with the thin pale thread of the Pilgrim Road. On it lies a faint line of shapes in the grass: the Sleepers' Mile. Over everything hangs the smoke ceiling, a low brown lid lit from beneath. Foreground: wet tin and a bell-rope. Midground: the city. Background: the cliff. The lower centre band is a dark stretch of roofs below the Row, where the mirrors are unpolished, and it stays quiet for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

There is no darkness anywhere, and that is the wrongness. Every light source is amber: Bonfires, street-lamps, windows and mirrors, all throwing light back up into the smoke. The smoke ceiling glows the dull orange of a scab, and the brightest lamp in the whole picture is the reflection in Wenna's mirror. No shadow falls anywhere in the city, because light comes from every direction. Shadows begin only past the cliff edge, where the Rim country sinks into true blue-black: the only night in the frame, and it belongs to the Sleepers. The palette is smoke-brown, soot-black and tin-grey, with **lamp amber** as the single accent, pooled in thousands of points and gathered most strongly on Wenna's face.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The tin is pitted, buckled and sweating condensation, rivets bleeding rust. The mirror's unpolished half carries a skin of soot thick enough to take a fingerprint, and Wenna's rag has smeared it into tobacco-coloured streaks. Her knuckles are split from lye and cold. The back of her hand shows a constellation of old pin-marks, small red-brown punctures in rows, some healed white and some fresh and beaded. Her eyes are the Vigil's eyes. The whites have yellowed and threaded with red, the lower lids sag like wet paper, and a crust of salt sits at the inner corners where tears have dried without anyone noticing. On the inside of her left wrist, in lamp-black, her name is written. Her breath shows faintly. The smoke is laid in with a dry brush, layered and greasy like old cooking fat in a kitchen. Everything in the frame looks unrested. Even the tin looks tired.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

It is a working bell like any other. Wenna's brother Florian has the house shift, and she has the mirrors: forty-one big and two hundred small on this stretch of Cinder Row. If the smoke is not taken off them every hour, the light in the lane goes amber and soft, and amber and soft puts people down. So she polishes until she sees her own face, and then she polishes that off too. Behind her the six-bell

Shouting has just ended, every shutter on the Row thrown open to shout at nothing for a count of thirty. Below her the Vigil goes about its one long day, which began in 341 and has not ended. Four hundred thousand people stand, pinch, rouse and nudge one another under the lamps, and sixty thousand lie down the hill in the Dormitory and breathe in time. This plate tells the player what the land is: a whole city kept awake by statute, by drug, by pain and by each other, never dark, never resting, drowning a little deeper each year while standing up. Nobody born here has seen a star. Wenna's grandmother told her they were holes in a lid, with the room shining through behind them. In a moment Wenna will finish this mirror and move to the next. Three houses down, something tall in a grey coat is walking across a roof. She did not see it, because she is not one of the thirty-one who did, so it did not happen.

electric lights, cars, glass skyscrapers, text artefacts, watermark, smiling faces, cosy warmth, beds visible, lens flare

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ On a roof three houses to the right stands a tall thin figure in a long grey coat, rendered faintly, as if half-erased. It is a Seeming the city has entered as news: seen by thirty-one, and not by Wenna.
- ◇ In the smoke ceiling directly above the Pillow there is a single tiny pinprick of pale light, like a star or a hole in a lid. No one in the Vigil would know what to call it.
- ◇ In the mirror's polished half, behind Wenna's reflection, there is an extra lamp that is not in the real city behind her. It sits low, at the height of a bed.
- ◇ A chalk tally on the bell-post reads *41 · 200 · Florian*, the mirror-count and the next shift.
- ◇ Along the Sleepers' Mile the shapes in the heather lie in a row with heads all turned the same way, toward the Lid.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide panorama, 3:1, of a vast never-dark city on a grey stone plateau, seen from a rusted tin rooftop. A gaunt young woman in a soot-stained smock kneels at left polishing a tall mirror. Her exhausted red-rimmed eyes are reflected in the cleaned half, a pin held in her teeth, old pin-scars on her hands. Below her spreads a sea of thousands of amber lamps and iron bonfire-furnaces, terraces of roof-mirrors, and a grey spiral tower on the far summit. A fenced dark hollow at the centre is ringed by lamps on poles. At right the plateau ends in a sheer cliff above black heather and a faint row of sleeping bodies along a road. Overhead, a low smoke ceiling glows scab-orange. Desaturated smoke-brown and tin-grey, the only accent lamp amber. Oil and ink, dry-brush smoke, heavy black at the cliff, a calm dark lower centre.

Negative: stars, moon, clear sky, bright saturated colours, blue daylight, cartoon, anime, clean digital gloss, modern streetlights,

▼ THE DORMITORY



Received this bell from the Slope carts: eleven. Washed, sheeted, numbered, laid. Breathing in time by the half-bell. Smiling: all.

THE RECEIVING GATE DAY-BOOK, GREY NINTH OF CARVING 588

Plate: THE DORMITORY · *Sixty thousand beds, breathing in time* · the Vigil · lamp amber and smoke

THE SHOT

We stand in the central hall of the Dormitory, the largest roofed space on the Table, with a long 85mm lens at the height of a standing orderly's eye. The aisle runs straight away from us and the rows of beds compress into a single endless pale field. The ceiling is low, almost oppressive, held up on squat grey pillars. In the **left third**, close to the lens, sits Bed One, which has a brass rail where every other bed has iron, and in it lies Aveline Morne: a plump fair baker's daughter, nineteen for three hundred years, flour still in the creases of her knuckles, lips parted. In the **centre third**, a little way down the aisle and lit from the side, walks Matron Cecily Dorm. She is broad and soft, in a starched grey gown and felt slippers, and one hand holds the heavy ring of bed-keys at her belt so it will not jingle. The other hand hangs at her side holding something pale and folded that might be linen and might be a pillow. Her lips are moving. She is counting. The **right third** is the rows going on: narrow iron beds, white sheets, black numbers on the foot-rails climbing into five figures, lamp after lamp on the pillars receding into a brown haze of distance until the beds become texture. The lower centre band is the dim aisle floor of scrubbed boards between two beds, dark and empty, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

There are lamps on every pillar, oil-lamps with smoked glass chimneys, and they all flicker together, dimming slightly on each long inhalation of the halls as the air is drawn past them. The light is warm, low and even, the colour of milk with a drop of tea in it, and it is the most frightening light in the series because it is *restful*. The white sheets catch it and go faintly gold. **Lamp amber** is the accent: the flames, the brass rail of Bed One, and a reflected glint on the Matron's keys. Everything else is linen-white, felt-grey and the brown smoke haze under the ceiling. Paint no hard shadows. Everything is soft-edged, as if seen through tired eyes.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The Counted look perfect. That is the wrongness. Skin smooth and faintly flushed, not sweating, not ageing, no dust settling on it. Aveline's cheeks are pink. Her hair spreads across the pillow in a fan that has not moved in three centuries, and the pillowcase beneath it has a faint hollow worn into it. Under her parted lips the tongue is just visible, and the lips themselves are shaping a word, caught mid-form: the beginning of a name. The sheets are starched, changed every Plate though they never need it, folded at the corners in hard military creases. The air is visibly thick, a faint warm haze that moves in long slow drifts toward the doors and back, and the Matron's grey gown sways with it. Her hands are soft and chapped, her nails bitten to the quick. Implied smell: clean linen, and the sweetish skin-smell of bodies that do not sweat.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Dormitory was begun in 342 as a single converted granary and has been extended wing by wing for three hundred years. It holds sixty thousand beds, and every one but fewer than two thousand is full. By law every sleeper in the Vigil is collected within a bell, washed, numbered and laid here, where they breathe and do not wake. They breathe in time: sixty thousand chests rising and falling together, four breaths to the minute, so that standing in this hall is

like standing inside the lung of an enormous animal. Matron Cecily Dorm is the only living person who knows the number at which the eye in the dream will open. She walks the rows every day counting from one under her breath. She loves the Counted, and knows their faces the way a mother knows her children's. Sometimes she hates them, and tells no one. She has been seen standing over a bed with a pillow for a long time. What she carries in her hand in this plate is left uncertain on purpose. Just before this moment, Bed One spoke. For three hundred years Aveline Morne made no sound, and last month her lips began to shape words. Most of them are names, one a day, and each person named has gone to the room the following day. The Matron has started writing them down. In a moment she will reach the brass rail, take out her pencil and lean in to listen. This week Aveline said a sentence instead of a name. It was about a door, and someone who has not been fed.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The Matron's lips, if magnified, are forming a number past fifty-eight thousand. She has not lost count.
- ◇ One of the beds in the right third holds a sleeper who looks exactly like a woman standing at its foot in visiting clothes. This is *going to look for your bed*: one of the Already-Counted has found herself.
- ◇ A slip of grey card is tucked under Bed One's rail, with the Matron's handwriting on it. It is a list of names, and the last line is longer than the others.
- ◇ Down the far aisle, one bed among thousands stands empty with its sheet turned back, and at its foot sits a single extra chair, pulled out a little, as though someone were expected.
- ◇ The lamp-flames all lean the same way, toward the doors. They are caught on the inhalation.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide interior, 3:1, of an endless low-ceilinged hall of narrow iron beds in perfect rows, white-sheeted, black numbers painted on the foot-rails, receding into brown haze. Close at left is a plump fair young woman asleep in a brass-railed bed, flushed and perfect, flour in her knuckle-creases, lips parted mid-word. At centre a broad matron in a starched grey gown and felt slippers walks the aisle, holding her ring of keys still, lips counting, something pale and folded in her other hand. Smoked oil-lamps on squat pillars all flicker in unison, the air a warm visible haze. The light is soft, milky and restful, which is the horror. Desaturated linen-white and felt-grey, the only accent lamp amber on flames and brass. Oil-paint brushwork, soft edges, deep shadow at the far end, a calm dark lower centre band.

Negative: gore, corpses, decay, open eyes, hospital equipment, modern beds, IV drips, electric light, bright colours, cartoon, clean

digital render, text artefacts, watermark, sexualised figures, children in beds, cosy domestic warmth, sunlight

▼ THE NODDING STAIR



She looked at me for a count of eleven. One more than the Regard. I have been waiting thirty years for her to mention it.

A WATCHER OF THE THIRD SHIFT

Plate: THE NODDING STAIR · *A council that may never sit* · the Vigil · lamp amber and smoke

THE SHOT

We are inside the hollow grey tower at the summit of the Height, looking across the shaft from the inner rail with a 35mm lens at the height of the Lid's Eye landing, halfway up. The staircase, broad as a road, spirals around the inside of the tower wall, so that it crosses the frame in great diagonal bands rising left to right, again and again, above and below us, until it vanishes into lamplit haze at top and bottom. In the **centre third**, on the landing, stands Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud, the only figure in the frame who is standing still. She is fifty-eight and lidless, in a high-collared grey gown, small and very straight. Her enormous pale grey eyes are red-rimmed and webbed with veins, and they look directly into the lens. At each shoulder an eye-wetter in felt holds a sable brush, and one brush is a finger's breadth from her eye, mid-stroke, glistening with rosewater. In the **left third**, the council climbs past her: Watchers of the Eye-lines, lidless, robed in grey, bodies bent forward on the uneven steps, faces wet-eyed and grimacing, some leaning on each other. One has a hand raised for *aye*. In the **right third**, the stair rises out of view, and on the wall beside the landing an old scratched inscription can just be made out. Far below is a small iron-barred door. Foreground: a worn step edge slanting outward, and a dropped pin. The lower centre band is the dark curve of the stair's underside below the landing, which the title rests against.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Lamps in iron brackets are bolted to the inner wall at every turn, smoked and guttering, throwing a ladder of amber pools up the spiral. Between the pools the stone is grey-blue and cold. The strongest light falls on Stroud from a lamp directly above her, a hard top-light that makes her eyes huge and wet and leaves the eye-wetters half in shadow. **Lamp amber** is the accent, in the bracket-lamps and in the rosewater glint on the brush. Everything else is tower-grey, robe-grey and soot. A faint warm haze rises from the barred door far below, the only patch of real darkness in the frame.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Stroud's eyes are the image. They have no lids at all: the orbit rims are smooth, slightly shiny scar where lids should be, and the eyeball sits too prominent, glossed with rosewater, the whites a map of burst capillaries. Tear-salt has crusted in a fine white line down each cheek and been brushed away so often that the skin there is raw. The sable brush is wet, its hairs parted. Her hands are folded and perfectly still, with a single silver hatpin through the cuff. The climbing Watchers are worse: lidless too, eyes clouded at the edges, one with the cornea cracked like glazed pottery, the blind white of a Giver. Their robes are dark with sweat at the spine. The stair's treads are worn into hollows by two hundred years of feet, each one a different height, so the lines of the steps never quite agree. On the wall the scratched letters have been gouged by a fingernail or a pin and blackened by the lamp.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Watch of Watches convened here in 441 and has not adjourned. Some three hundred Eye-line nobles climb the Nodding Stair in three shifts, day and night, and debate on the move. Motions are carried by those still breathing hard enough to say *aye*. Benedikt Lour built the steps so that no one could sit, lean or stand comfortably on them, and the top step returns by a hidden ramp to the bottom, so the council climbs forever and never arrives. Only

the Warden-Prime stands still. Ilvane Stroud has not shut her eyes once since birth, because she has nothing to shut them with, and she forgets nothing she has seen: every execution she has signed, every lie told to her on this stair, and the exact weight of each. Every quarter hour the whole council passes before her, and she counts them, and has never stopped counting. This is the moment the player arrives on the landing. Stroud will remember them perfectly, forever. Behind her an old lord is falling behind, grey-faced, and someone will have to pin him. Far below, behind the barred door at the foot of the stair, is the only dark room on the Lid. In it lies the Coverlet, the casket where the two hundred and fourteen lids of the Giving were laid in 503 and became a single folded sheet of soft grey skin with a closed seam down its middle, breathing four times to the minute. Every new Warden-Prime goes down once, alone, to look. Stroud went down in 612 and came up saying one thing twice: *It has got bigger*. She knows the number. The Matron does not know she knows.

electric light, text artefacts, watermark, closed eyes on the Warden, blood spray, heroic poses

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The scratched inscription on the landing wall reads, faintly, *I gave my lids for the city and the city gave me nothing to close*. It is Ottoline Quell's, from 503.
- ◇ The barred door at the base of the stair has a draught-stain around its edges, a soft grey bloom on the stone that rises and fades, as if something behind the door were breathing.
- ◇ High at the top of the tower, a single lit window holds a small dark-haired woman with ordinary hazel eyes, closed. It is Lady Oriel Stroud, alone, blinking for the joy of it.
- ◇ One Watcher in the left third has stopped climbing and stands with his eyes on the Warden. He is the one held in her Regard for a count of eleven.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide interior, 3:1, of a vast hollow grey stone tower with a broad uneven staircase spiralling endlessly up and down its walls. Grey-robed nobles climb it in a bent, exhausted procession, their eyes lidless, wet and clouded. At centre, on a landing, stands a small straight woman in a high grey collar who has no eyelids. Her huge pale bloodshot eyes stare straight out, glossed with rosewater, and two felt-clad attendants at her shoulders hold wet sable brushes to her eyes. Iron bracket-lamps form a spiral ladder of amber light, with cold grey stone between. Far below is a small barred iron door with a soft grey stain breathing around it. Desaturated slate and soot, the only accent lamp amber. Oil-paint, gritty texture, intimate eye horror, a calm dark lower centre band.

Negative: throne, seated figures, crowns, bright colours, gold excess, cartoon, anime, clean digital gloss, modern architecture,

▼ THE SLOPE



Thimble Lane, two children down, a grandmother and an aunt. Lanternside, nine. Gutter Lane, the whole of number four. That's this afternoon. Pass it on.

THE SLOPE'S CART-COUNT, SHOUTED FROM ROOF
TO ROOF ON A GREY DAY

Plate: THE SLOPE · *Where whole families go down in an afternoon*
· the Vigil · lamp amber and smoke

THE SHOT

A grey afternoon in Carving on Thimble Lane, deep in the Slope. The camera is a 28mm at the height of a crouching woman, looking up the lane, which is so steep it is nearly a stair. Tin-and-plank houses are stacked so that one family's floor is the next one's roof. In the **left third**, through an open doorway, we see into a single room at the lane's edge. A household has gone down. A grandfather lies sideways on the floor by the hackle, a woman sits slumped against the twisting-post, and a younger man has fallen forward over the table, cheek on his folded arms, all of them breathing, all of them smiling. In the doorway stands Mag Startle, ring-mother of Cinder Row: forty-six, broad, a widow with a voice heard three lanes off. She has a pin-glove on her right hand and her mouth is open in a shout. She has just slapped the man at the table and he has not come back. In the **centre third** the lane climbs, and halfway up it a Dormitory cart with rattling wooden wheels is being pushed down by two Wakers in long coats with needles at their belts. In the **right third** the Slope tumbles down toward the bottom of the frame, and on the roofs nudger-children stand with their hands cupped to their mouths, shouting the count from roof to roof. Above everything, the sky is a flat milk-grey lid. The lower centre band is the dark mouth of a drain-gutter running down the lane's centre, unlit and calm, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The danger here is the light itself: even, grey, windless and shadowless, the colour of milk in a bowl. It flattens everything, and it is the colour of sleep. Against it, the Slope's lamps are few and poor, burning bad oil with a smoky orange flame. One lamp is lit inside the doorway behind Mag, and its weak **lamp amber** pools on the faces of the smiling sleepers, and that is the accent: thin and failing. Smoke from a dung-fed Bonfire lies across the upper lane in a brown smear. The palette is otherwise milk-grey, tin-grey and rope-brown.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The tin is dented, rust-blooded and dripping. Rope hangs everywhere, hemp and tarred, from lines between the houses, frayed into hairs. The sleepers' faces are the horror: slack, softened, the lines of a lifetime of waking smoothed away, mouths curved into small contented smiles. The grandfather's cheek is flattened against the floorboards and his eyes, peeled open by Mag a moment ago, are rolled back and wet. On the back of the younger man's hand are fresh pinpricks in a line, and one welling bead of red. Mag's own face is the opposite: grey, sweat-shined, the eyes standing out, the lips bitten raw. The pin-glove is cracked leather with nine bent steel points. On the inside of every wrist in the room, lamp-black names. On the table, a cup of rouse gone cold, with chalk-grit settled in the bottom, the cut stuff. Implied smell: wet tin, cheap oil, chalk and ash, and this year a faint smell of the sea.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Slope is forty thousand households in a hundred lanes too steep for the Wakers' carts, a city of rope, wick, laundry and rag under its own dung-fed Bonfires, where the rouse is cut with chalk and ash and the nudgers are mostly children. Slope families nudge in a ring, everyone watched and watching, the youngest set to watch the oldest, and nobody may be unwatched in their own home. The ring holds on most days. It does not hold on a grey afternoon. When the

wind drops and the cloud closes and the light goes all one colour, whole families go down one after another, and the last one awake moves between the bodies slapping and screaming until they go quiet too. The Weather-Board at the Ludmere Bonfire has been chalked *GREY AFTERNOON* since the ninth bell. This is that afternoon. Mag Startle keeps the ring for the whole of Cinder Row, not just her own house, and she knows by the sound of the shouting which household is weakest. This one went quiet and she came running. She has got the grandmother back, and the grandmother is upstairs, being slapped by a child. The other three are gone, smiling, breathing in time with sixty thousand others down the hill. Next the cart will reach the door and the Wakers will try the needle at all points, and then they will lift them. Mag will stand in the lane and count them onto the cart, because that is what the Slope does: it comes out to watch, and to count. Then she will go home and look again at two of her grandchildren, who she has begun to think are very careful copies.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ One of the children shouting on the roofs in the right third has the same face, stance and cap as another child two roofs over. These are Mag's grandchildren, or her Copies of them.
- ◇ The Waker on the cart's left side has a figure *41* chalked on his coat-sleeve: the afternoon's count so far.
- ◇ The man at the table wears a padded hand-ward box strapped to his forearm. It is locked, and the key hangs around the grandmother's neck upstairs.
- ◇ In the lane above, a woman stands motionless at an upstairs window pinching her own wrist in a slow rhythm. She is *at the window*, and she will lose this whole long watch.
- ◇ Painted over the door is the Slope's skipping-rhyme, half scrubbed out: *six for the door that lets the number in*.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide street scene, 3:1, of a steep slum lane of tin-and-plank houses stacked on each other, ropes strung everywhere, under a flat windless milk-grey sky. At left, through a doorway, a family lies asleep where they fell: an old man on the floor, a woman against a post, a man slumped over a table, all slack and smiling, eyes rolled back. A broad exhausted woman in a cracked leather pin-glove stands in the doorway shouting. Up the lane, two long-coated men push a rattling wooden cart downhill. On the roofs, small figures cup their hands to shout. A single weak lamp inside gives a failing amber glow on the sleepers' faces. Desaturated milk-grey, tin and rope-brown, the only accent thin lamp amber. Oil and ink, scratchy dry-brush texture, a calm dark gutter in the lower centre.

Negative: blood pools, corpses, dead children, injured children, gore on children, violence, bright colours, blue sky, sunlight,

cartoon, clean digital gloss, modern clothing, cars, electric light, text artefacts, watermark, cheerful mood

▼ THE GLASS HOUSE



*I'm sorry. I'm sorry. Please don't look at my mouth.
I'm sorry.*

LUKAS MARRE, THROUGH THE SPEAKING-TUBE, TO
EVERY VISITOR, EVERY TIME

Plate: THE GLASS HOUSE · *Quarantine for those whose yawns are catching* · the Vigil · lamp amber and smoke

THE SHOT

We are on the Glass Spur, the bare finger of rock at the windward edge of the Lid, inside the long greenhouse. The camera is a 50mm at a seated eye-height, looking along the corridor that runs the length of the building between two rows of cells walled in thick green glass and iron frames. In the **right third**, close to the lens, is a cell. Behind its pane sits Lukas Marre, the Yawning Man: thirty-one, thin, bookish, in a patched grey coat, his lower face held in a stiff leather muzzle that clamps his jaw half shut. His eyes are lowered from the glass in apology and a book lies open on his knee. A brass speaking-tube runs from his cell through the glass and ends at a funnel mouth on the corridor side. In the **centre third**, on the corridor side, an old woman visitor sits on a stool with her mouth to the funnel, her eyes turned firmly away from his face as the rules require. Beside her stands Keeper Otilie Grain: fifty, gruff, wax in her ears, a weighted cosh at her belt and her other hand raised, ready to slap the visitor if she begins to yawn. In the **left third**, the corridor recedes past cell after green-lit cell, each with a hunched masked figure inside, to a far door where the wind beats on the glass. Foreground is the brass funnel and the worn stool-rung. Midground is the visitor and Otilie. Background is the receding cells. The lower centre band is the dark worn flagstone floor of the corridor, unlit between lamps, held calm for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Each cell is lit from outside by its own lamp, hung on the corridor side, so the light passes through green glass and the prisoners sit in a drowned, bottle-coloured glow. The corridor is lit from these cell-lamps and from the Glass Crew's lamps, burned in sacred quantities, harsh and too many. **Lamp amber** is the accent, in the corridor lamps and in the warm edge they throw on the visitor's cheek. The cell interiors are green-grey, a colour that sits against the amber and must be kept desaturated and murky, like old bottle glass. Outside, beyond the glass roof, is a cold grey gale and the brown smoke lid.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The glass is old, thick and wavy, full of seeds and bubbles, with stains of condensation running down in long beads. Through it Lukas is slightly distorted, like something in a jar. The muzzle is saddle-leather, dark and stiff, buckled behind his head with three straps. It has rubbed the skin at the corners of his mouth into raw red sores that have crusted and split many times, and a faint glistening of spit stains the leather below the lips. His jaw muscles are visibly clenched against it. Above the muzzle his face is gentle and hollow, the eyes wet and red. His fingers are inked from writing. Otilie Grain's face is weathered, wire-lidded, the wax in her ears yellow. Her eyes are dry, very dry, and wide. The brass tube is green with verdigris at its joints and polished bright at the funnel where mouths have pressed to it. The visitor's hand grips the stool, knuckles white.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

In the Vigil a yawn is contagious, and in a few people it is catching beyond all reason. Lukas Marre is the worst of them. One gape of his jaw and a room goes down, a street sways, and once, at nineteen, before he knew, a whole market square went down. In 533 his grandmother put four hundred people into the Dormitory in the Pinchmarket, and that is why the Glass House was built. He has

lived twelve years in this cell, masked, alone, in the coldest corner of the city. He is painfully polite and apologises through the pane to everyone. Every Plate he writes to the Matron asking after the people from the square. The visitor is a mother from the Slope whose son was in that square. She comes every season to speak to Lukas through the tube. She has not forgiven him and she cannot stop coming. She has paid Otilie a crumb to stand beside her and slap her if she yawns. Otilie has kept the yawners for twenty years and rotates her guards every bell, but not herself, because she believes she is immune. She has never once yawned at work. She has never once been seen to blink at all, and she does not know this about herself. Outside, the people of the Spur build their houses with their backs to the Glass House and walk past it backwards. In this moment Lukas has felt the yawn rising in him, and has shut his eyes and clenched against the leather, and on the far side of the glass the visitor's head has begun, very slightly, to sway.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ In the cell behind the visitor, a masked figure is pressed to the glass with its muzzle worn through at the chin.
- ◇ The cap of one speaking-tube along the corridor hangs open on its chain.
- ◇ Otilie Grain's eyes, under magnification, are rimmed with the same red as the Warden-Prime's. She has stopped blinking.
- ◇ Through the far door a small Spur child walks backward along the path outside, eyes on the ground.
- ◇ A pot and a wooden spoon hang on a nail by the corridor door, the district's yawn-alarm.
- ◇ On Lukas's open book, a letter has been started: *Dear Matron, the people from the square...*

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide interior, 3:1, of a long greenhouse corridor walled with thick wavy green glass cells in iron frames. In a cell at right sits a thin gentle young man, his jaw clamped half-shut in a stiff saddle-leather muzzle, raw sores at the mouth-corners, eyes lowered in apology, a book on his knee. A verdigrised brass speaking-tube runs through the glass to a funnel where an old woman sits with her mouth to it, eyes turned away, her head beginning to sway. Beside her a gruff wax-eared female keeper with a cosh stands with her hand raised to slap. Masked figures hunch in green-lit cells receding left. Amber lamps hang in the corridor, the cells murky green-grey. Desaturated, the only accent lamp amber, oil and ink texture, a calm dark lower centre.

Negative: sci-fi lab, clean glass, modern prison, electric light, bright green, neon, cartoon, anime, clean digital gloss, text artefacts, watermark, blood spray, monsters, fangs, gas masks, steampunk excess

▼ KEST



◆
Knock, and wait. If it knocks back, you were right to knock. If it doesn't, you were right to wait.

A KEST MOTHER'S RULE, TAUGHT AT THE LINTEL

Plate: KEST · *A city of round red houses and no door that locks* · Cradlewrack · wet iron red and clay

THE SHOT

Dusk on the steps of the Tally-house, on the crown of Tally Hill, at the hour of the Dusk Reading. The camera is a 35mm set low on the steps, looking past the crier and out over the city. In the **left third** stands Corin Ledge, the Exchange crier: forty, hoarse, in a wet-wool coat, a lamp held high in one hand and the oiled-paper copy of the day's Tally in the other. His mouth is open on a number. Below him on the steps the crowd has just turned its faces away for a count of three, because the line he read ended in a ruled line, *struck through*. At the front, a few mothers not yet read stand facing him. In the **centre third** the city falls away in curves: round red buildings rammed from clay, windowless on the weather side, clustered like eggs set out to warm, with no corner anywhere and no straight street. Rising in the middle distance is the Round, crowned by the Old Lying-In, squat and red, its doorways all standing open and glowing faintly. In the **right third** the steep south hill of the Coppers sends up a white column of steam, and beyond it, on the north slope, the Stillyard's concentric red walls ring the hill like the growth-rings of a cut tree. Caul-fog lies in the valley to the height of the second storey, so the seven hills stand up out of it like islands. Foreground: the lamp and the crier's hand. Midground: the turned-away crowd. Background: the hills. The lower centre band is the dark step-edges below the crowd's feet, in shadow and calm, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The last daylight is a low wet bruise over the western ravines, more brown than gold. The crier's lamp is the strongest light in the frame and falls in a warm circle on the steps and the backs of heads. The Coppers' fires glow under their steam column. The Old Lying-In's open doorways show a dull ember light from within. **Wet iron red** is the accent: in the clay walls of every building, in the madder-dyed shawls, in the stains on the aprons of the midwives at the front, and in the pink rime along the gutters where the waters ran. Everything else is fog-grey, clay-brown and wool-black.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Kest is built of the land, and the land is flesh-like. Rammed clay walls are smooth and slightly glossy, the colour of liver, with fine cracks that have been smoothed over again and again like scar. Doors hang on leather hinges and are held, if at all, with wedges, and every one in the frame stands a hand's breadth ajar. Rooms meant to stay shut are bricked, fresh mortar pale in their seams. The crier's coat steams. In the crowd: a man's neck with old stitches puckered and freshly reddened where a seam reopened at the last pang; a woman's forearms laced with neat white stitch-scars, a number of them new; a laundress's hands, red and shining from lye. The gutters in the lane below the steps run with a faint pink water and leave a pale salt rime. Implied smell: wet clay, lye, boiled aprons, and the warm salt of the springs, which outlanders say tastes like the inside of a cheek.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Kest is the capital of the highlands, sixty thousand people by a count the Tally cannot agree with, built on seven rounded hills around the birthing-house where the god Vey was killed in the Meal. Since that night nothing in Cradlewrack stays shut. Doors drift open, locks undo, wounds reopen on pang nights. Since the Year of Doors no door in Kest is permitted to lock, and corners are forbidden because things collect in them. Every evening, on every hill, the day's births are chalked on a Tally-board and read aloud, and on Tally Hill the

whole city's births are read. Each line has five parts: the number, the household, the bearer, *what*, and *stays*. At *stays* the crowd murmurs *and let it stay*. At a ruled line it turns its face away for a count of three, the time an Opinion is meant to take. Corin Ledge has just read such a line. He has read thousands. He keeps a private book of the naming-rights he has sold, and visits those children on their naming-days with a sugar-stick. The next line on his paper is entered *without bearer*: someone new in the city whom nobody carried. Last year eleven hundred more people were born in the highlands than were carried by anyone. When the Reading ends the crowd will say *nine days* and go home, and knock on every door before opening it, and brick their children in for the night. Down on the Round, the eight doors of the Old Lying-In stand open as they have for six centuries, and over them the frieze shows eight figures in eight arches, one arch empty.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The Old Lying-In's frieze is just legible: seven worn figures with arms spread in their arches, and the eighth chiselled out to a dark hole.
- ◇ One woman at the back of the crowd has not turned away. She stands among those already read and struck through, facing the crier. Nobody speaks to her.
- ◇ A tiny white-limed numeral *4,418* is chalked on the step by Corin's foot, the last line of the evening's page: a key, born of a well-house, that unlocks nothing yet tried.
- ◇ In the Coppers' steam column a naked figure is half-visible, newly born-grown from a vat, a *boiling*.
- ◇ Every house on the near hill has notches cut into its lintel. The last few are much closer together than the first.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide cityscape, 3:1, at wet brown dusk. In the foreground a hoarse crier in a steaming wool coat holds up a lamp and reads from oiled paper on clay steps, while a crowd below turns their faces away in unison. Beyond spreads a city of round windowless red-clay buildings on seven hills, no corners, no straight streets, like heaps of eggs. Doors hang ajar on leather hinges and some rooms are freshly bricked shut. A squat ancient red birthing-house crowns the central hill, all its doors open and faintly glowing. A white steam column rises from laundry vats, and concentric red cemetery walls ring a northern hill. Fog fills the valleys. Desaturated fog-grey and clay-brown, the only accent wet iron red. Oil and ink, gritty texture, a calm dark lower centre band.

Negative: infants, babies, birth scenes, gore on children, bright colours, sunny sky, cartoon, clean digital gloss, modern buildings, square corners, straight streets, electric light, text artefacts, watermark, festive mood

▼ THE DILATION



Twenty years at the rim. I've seen it take a stake, a cart, two pilgrims and a bishop of the Purgation. Never seen it give back anything I'd want.

MADDER RUDGE

Plate: THE DILATION · *A mile across and widening* · Cradlewrack · wet iron red and clay

THE SHOT

Dawn at Rimwatch, on the lip of the great crowning in the central highlands. The camera is an extreme wide 16mm held low, almost on the clay, at the very edge, so the Dilation's inward slope falls away from the bottom of the frame and its far rim curves round the horizon a mile off like the lip of a bowl. In the **left third**, close to the lens, kneels Madder Rudge, Head of the Watch: sixty-nine, stumpy, red to the elbows from fifty years of clay, face like a dried apple, a pipe smoked upside down in her teeth against the steam. She has one ear pressed flat to the soft clay and her eyes are open and listening. Beside her lies a bundle of painted stakes and a coil of tarred rope. In the **centre third** the clay lips slope inward, ribbed and soft, to a sheer drop into a darkness that has no bottom, and warm air rises out of it in a slow visible breath of steam. A line of painted stakes marks the rim, each with a name daubed on it; the nearest stakes lean inward and two are already half-swallowed. Cut into the inner slope on the right is the Apron Stair: ninety-one steps hewn into the clay, which now go down only a few strides before falling into the dark, their head stakes tied with strips of white linen. In the **right third**, set back from the rim, sprawls Rimwatch: tents, turf huts and peat-smoke, a posset-cart, pilgrims wrapped in blankets. Foreground: Madder's ear on the clay. Midground: the slope and stakes. Background: the far rim and the tents. The lower

centre band is the shadowed inner slope just below the lip, dark and smooth, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Low dawn light from the right rakes across the rim and catches the tops of the stakes and the steam. The bowl itself is in shadow, deepening to absolute black at the centre, and the steam rising out of it is lit pink-grey from above. **Wet iron red** is the accent: in the clay, which glistens like the inside of a lip, in the paint on the stakes, in the stains on Madder's arms and on the white linen strips where the waters have soaked them. The tents and pilgrims are clay-brown and smoke-grey. The sky is a low heavy damp grey, almost the colour of the fog.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The clay of the lip is the image: soft, red, finely wrinkled and faintly glossy, giving underfoot like flesh, with deep radial creases running inward toward the dark like the folds of a dilated mouth. Where the slope steepens it is wet, beaded with clear fluid, and a pale salt rime has dried in the creases. Madder's cheek presses into it and leaves a print. Her coat is clay-stiff hide, cracked at the elbows, and her bare forearms are stained red to the elbow, the stain worked into every wrinkle. Her knuckles are swollen. The stakes are rough-split ash, the paint dribbled, names daubed by unpractised hands. The white linen strips at the Apron Stair are sodden and pinked at the hem, and among them hang other things, small and wet and wrapped, tied to the stakes by pilgrims. Implied smell: warm, humid iron and birth-water, peat-smoke, unwashed wool.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Dilation opened in 547 as a pothole in a sheep track, and it has never stopped. It is the greatest of the crownings, the round soft openings the earth makes in the highlands, and it is a mile across and widening. At every pang the bowl flexes, widens by a stride and eases back by less, and every pang somebody who was standing at the edge

is not there any more. The Attendance believes the god is regrowing not in a person but in the country, that the quakes are contractions, and that when the interval between them closes to nothing something will be born out of the ground. It was once a full season. It is now nine days. Madder Rudge has been at the rim since 621. Every dawn the watch sets out painted stakes to mark its advance, and anyone may pay a crumb to paint their name on one; when the stake is gone by noon, it is lucky. Madder kneels at each new stake and listens. She can tell what moves beneath to ninety feet. This morning she is listening to the great slow beat under the clay, and under it, quick and small, a second beat that she will tell the next pilgrim is a heart. Behind her, Rimwatch wakes: pilgrims, Barren preachers telling the crowd to start nothing, Assemblers' agents, Attendance observers, and mothers whose children walked into the hole. On Hollan's Day of 619 a procession of mothers went down the Apron Stair and did not come back. Since Lack 640 things have come up the stair in the waters, and they are tied to the stakes too.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ One stake near the lip has *MADDER* painted on it in old, faded letters. She has never let it be taken.
- ◇ Among the linen strips on the Apron Stair hangs a folded white apron, starched and clean, a name stitched inside its hem in the old way.
- ◇ Hollan Pyke's posset-cart in the right third has nine faint wheel-ruts behind it, one for every time she has moved her pitch back.
- ◇ In the dark at the centre of the bowl, at the limit of visibility, is a faint pale curve like the crown of something enormous.
- ◇ A pilgrim's finger and every tent-flap in Rimwatch are pointing the same way: north, toward the Sill.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide landscape, 3:1, at grey dawn, of an enormous round crater a mile across in soft red clay hills. Its lips are glossy, wrinkled and flesh-like, creasing inward to a bottomless black centre from which warm steam breathes. At left a stout old woman stained red to the elbows, upside-down pipe in her teeth, kneels with her ear pressed to the wet clay, listening. A line of painted wooden stakes leans toward the edge. Steps cut into the inner slope end in darkness, hung with sodden white linen strips. At right is a camp of tents, turf huts and peat-smoke with blanket-wrapped pilgrims. Low raking light, pink-grey steam. Desaturated clay-brown and smoke-grey, the only accent wet iron red. Oil-paint and ink texture, gritty, a calm dark slope in the lower centre.

Negative: volcano, lava, fire, bright orange, explicit anatomy, infants, gore on children, cartoon, clean digital gloss, modern equipment, fences, vehicles, text artefacts, watermark, blue sky, heroic pose

▼ THE SILL



◇
It's a long room, it says, and warm, and the table's laid. One chair's out. I said who's that for. It said, no hurry.

OLD HINGE, TO VISITORS AT THE SILL

Plate: THE SILL · *A door standing in its frame on a hill* · Cradlewrack · wet iron red and clay

THE SHOT

A bare hilltop in the north of Cradlewrack, at the last light. The camera is a 50mm at standing height, square on to the hill, with the horizon low. Wind is rare here and the grass stands still. In the **centre third**, alone on the crown of the hill, stands a door in its frame with no wall around it: oak grey with age, iron-bound, older than the Gorging, set in a heavy lintel and posts sunk into the red earth. It is ajar, open about a hand's width toward the viewer. Through the gap, where there should be only more hillside and evening sky, there is something else: a strip of warm interior dark, and the faint gleam of light on a surface far back. In the **left third**, downhill and a hundred paces off, stands a low turf hut with a peat-smoke thread and a bench beside its door. In the **right third**, close to the door, stoops Old Hinge, its keeper: perhaps eighty, bent and bald, with knuckles like walnuts. He holds a small oil-can to the upper hinge, and his face is turned resolutely away from the gap, over his own shoulder toward the hut. A measuring-stick of notched ash leans against the doorpost. Behind the door, from the back, the hill is plainly empty. Foreground: grass, a scatter of wedges, and a path worn by visitors that stops a careful distance from the threshold. Midground: the door and Hinge. Background: the folded red hills going grey into fog. The lower centre band is the dark

shadowed grass of the hill's slope in front of the door, calm and empty, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The sun is down. The sky is a low, wet, even grey, fading toward slate. The hill is lit only by the dying glow off the clouds. The only warm light in the frame comes from inside the gap: a faint steady glow, like a kitchen seen down a long passage, which falls on the threshold stone and on the edge of the door. **Wet iron red** is the accent, in the red earth of the hilltop, in the rust bleeding from the iron bands, and, very faintly, in the warmth of the gap. Everything else is grey-green grass, grey oak and fog.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The oak is silvered, deeply grooved by centuries of weather, the grain standing up like the ridges of an old fingertip. The iron bands are pitted and swollen with rust, bleeding long orange-red tears down the wood. The hinges are black and glossy with fresh oil, the only cared-for thing in the frame. Notches are cut into the post at regular heights, each one dated with a scratched year, climbing. The threshold stone is worn into a shallow dip in the middle, as if something had stood on it often. The earth around the posts is red, soft and faintly glistening, with a fine salt rime. Old Hinge's hands are spotted and swollen at every joint, the nails thick and yellow; oil darkens his cuffs. His bald head is freckled. His eyes are screwed shut. Implied: warm air coming out of the gap, carrying a smell of bread and woodsmoke into the cold.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Sill is a single door standing in its frame on a bare hill, with nothing around it. It has stood there since before the Gorging. On the night the god Vey died, every door in the old birthing-house at Kest swung open, and this one opened too, a finger's width, and it has opened a little further every year since. Walk around it and there is only hillside behind. Look through the gap from the front, the old

rule says, and you will see something else. Old Hinge has kept it for longer than anyone in Kest can remember. He lives in the turf hut a hundred paces downhill with his back to it. He oils the hinges and measures the gap and notches the post, and he has never looked through. He says he does not need to, because most nights something on the other side describes the view to him: a long room, warm, a table laid, a great many chairs, and one of them pulled out. He tells visitors about it in a pleasant dry voice. When he asked who the chair was for, it said *no hurry*. Everything in Cradlewrack leans toward the Sill: the crownings point at it, the Assemblers' figure has turned its head toward it, and the thing Sabeth Thorne keeps in a loft at Tarnbrow asks to be taken to see it. This is the end of Hinge's evening round. He has oiled the hinge and he is about to measure, and the stick will show the gap wider than last month by more than it should be. What he fears is the night the voice stops describing and asks him to come and see.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Through the gap, at the limit of resolution, are the edge of a long table with a white cloth, and the back of one chair pulled out. Never paint more than that.
- ◇ The last notch on the post is dated *641*. The distance between it and the notch for *640* is twice that of any earlier year.
- ◇ A trail of small damp prints, like a child's, crosses the grass from the left of the frame and stops at the visitors' line. They do not go further.
- ◇ On the bench by the hut lie two cups. One is Hinge's.
- ◇ The grass around the threshold all bends inward, toward the gap, though there is no wind.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide landscape, 3:1, of a bare red-earthed hilltop at grey dusk where a single ancient grey oak door, iron-bound and rust-streaked, stands alone in its frame with no wall around it. It is ajar a hand's width, and through the gap glows a faint warm interior light, as of a distant room, though behind the door is only empty hill. At right a bent bald old man with swollen knuckles oils the upper hinge, face turned firmly away from the gap, eyes shut. A notched measuring-stick leans on the post. At left is a small turf hut with a smoke thread. Folded red hills fade into fog beyond. Desaturated grey-green and slate, the only accent wet iron red in earth, rust and the gap's glow. Oil and ink, dry-brush texture, huge negative space, a calm dark lower centre.

Negative: figure in doorway, faces in the gap, monsters, portal effects, glowing magic, bright colours, sunset orange, cartoon, clean digital gloss, modern objects, text artefacts, watermark, fantasy castle, lens flare

▼ THE ASSEMBLERS' BARN



◇
It will not be alone any more, and neither will you.

THE FOUNDING PROMISE OF THE ASSEMBLERS, SAID
AT THE BARN'S NEAR DOOR

Plate: THE ASSEMBLERS' BARN · *Visitors are not shown the far end* · Cradlewrack · wet iron red and clay

THE SHOT

The far end of the long stone threshing-barn in a fold of hills east of Kest, at night, during a Joining. The camera is a 28mm at the height of a kneeling brother, set just inside the ring of humming Assemblers so their shoulders frame the left and right edges. In the **centre third**, on a bed of warm straw on a low stone platform, lies Herself: a figure eleven feet long, made of four hundred Parts from four hundred families, joined by pink puckered seams into a shape almost but not quite a body. She lies on her side with her knees drawn up. Her head, made of more than one, has turned on its neck away from the lamps, toward the right edge of the frame and the north. Kneeling at her left wrist, where the hand should be and is not, is Dov Marrin, Assembler-Prime: fifty-five, mild, balding, spectacles pushed up on his forehead, very clean nails, a curved needle and a skein of fine sheep-gut in his fingers. In the **left third** stands Joss Tanner, a Carrier: thirty, freckled, painfully thin, a short cape thrown back to show the born right hand sewn to the inside of his left forearm, which is reaching, on its own, toward the figure. In the **right third** the ring of brothers and sisters in brown aprons stands humming, mouths closed, and behind them the barn's far door, iron-barred, faces north. Overhead hang a hundred lamps from the rafters. Foreground: straw, a basin of warm water and a row of curved needles laid out on linen. The lower centre band is the dark face of the stone platform below the straw, in shadow, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

A hundred tallow lamps hang from the tie-beams on chains, so the light is warm, close and many-sourced, coming down onto the figure from above like the light of a lambing-shed. Steam rises from the basins. The straw glows dull gold, but it must be kept desaturated, near to brown. **Wet iron red** is the accent: in the fresh seams, in the stained water of the basins, in the clay floor, in the madder of the brothers' aprons. The figure's skin is many skins, cream, brown, grey-pink, sallow, and all of them muted. The far door and the rafters are black.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Herself is the image, and she must be painted with tenderness. Her skin is a patchwork of a hundred tones joined by seams that have healed pink, raised and puckered, the stitch-holes still visible in rows like the holes in a quilted coverlet. Nine arms lie along her flank, some a woman's, some a man's, one with a wedding band grown into the finger. Her back is a spine of too many joints under thin wet skin the colour of a peeled grape. Ears turn on her neck toward the humming. One eye on her shoulder is open and wet. She is breathing slowly, and her ribcage shifts the straw. Where her left hand should be, the wrist ends in a smooth pink dome, faintly translucent. Joss's borne hand is warm and plump, its seam to his forearm angry and fresh, his own arm wasted thin around it. Dov's sleeves are rolled. Implied smell: tallow, catgut, warm milk, and the inside of a sheepfold in spring.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Assemblers believe that the Parts born in Cradlewrack, the living hands, ears, spines and eyes that arrive instead of children, are not monstrous births at all but one body, born piecemeal through ten thousand mothers across a century. It is Vey, they say, being born again the only way the highlands would permit, in pieces small enough to be let stay. Their work is to gather the pieces and give the god back its shape. At the near door mothers are given posset and a

seat by the fire, and the Parts sleep in labelled straw boxes, fed by hand. Visitors are not shown the far end. Here Dov Marrin has fitted four hundred Parts into one figure, which he calls Herself, and speaks of each Part by the name of its bearer. A Joining takes a night: fine gut, curved needles, a great deal of warm water, and the ring humming its five-note tune. In the morning the seam has healed and the figure breathes a little deeper. Joss Tanner has borne the hand on his arm since Plenty, sewn there to learn the way. He dreams of its bearer, a Rudge widow he has never met. Tonight the Fitter has heard that the hand is ready, and Dov will cut it from Joss and join it. It is a right hand. The figure still lacks a left hand and a voice. Dov has already given it a heart: his own wife's, born to her as a Part in her sixtieth year. She hums in a cot in the middle hall. Dov's fear is the thing in this frame: the head has turned toward the Sill without him.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ A board by the far door chalks the Gatherers' Rates. The line for *A hand, left* has been overwritten three times, each time higher.
- ◇ The open Mothers' Book on a trestle shows entries in a gentle hand: *Hester's hand, Aldo's ear, old Nan Furrow's one*.
- ◇ Among the ring of hummers, one sister's lips are parted. She is the only one singing words.
- ◇ Every door in sight, including the barred far door, stands a finger's width open.
- ◇ In the straw by the figure's mouth, which has no tongue, lies a small cup with a cover. Something in it has spoken once.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide interior, 3:1, of the far end of a long stone barn lit by a hundred hanging tallow lamps. On a bed of warm straw lies an eleven-foot figure stitched from hundreds of mismatched human parts in many skin tones, joined by healed pink puckered seams. It has nine arms along one flank, ears turning on its neck, an eye open on its shoulder, and a missing left hand, and it breathes as its head turns away toward a dark barred door. A mild balding man with spectacles kneels with a curved needle and gut. A thin freckled young man bares a living hand sewn to his forearm, reaching on its own. A ring of aprons hums with mouths closed. Desaturated straw-brown and soot, the only accent wet iron red. Tender oil-paint body horror, a calm dark lower centre.

Negative: infants, child body parts, gore on children, frankenstein lab, electricity, lightning, bright colours, cartoon, clean digital gloss, modern surgery, steel tables, text artefacts, watermark, sexualised anatomy, splatter

▼ THE LYING-IN



Choose so that you can remember, the Book says. It doesn't say you'll be let forget.

A RETIRED OPINION, THE ANSWERED WARD OF THE LYING-IN

Plate: THE LYING-IN · *Where the births nobody speaks of are taken* · Cradlewrack · wet iron red and clay

THE SHOT

Night in the upper ward of the Lying-In, the Attendance's fortress-hospital on a bare hill north of Kest. The camera is a 40mm at sitting height, looking down the long curved ward, which follows the inside of the ring wall. In the **left third**, close to the lens, Sabeth Thorne stands at a copper basin on a stand, with her back to the room. She is forty, long-boned, cropped black hair, sleeves rolled to the shoulder, scrubbing her hands with pumice and a stiff brush in water that has gone faintly pink. The skin of her knuckles is cracked and bleeding. Her knife-case lies closed on the stand beside her. In the **centre third**, in the bed by the east window, lies a woman at the Brink, propped on pillows: a crowning has opened at her sternum, a round soft-lipped opening, and from its lips a single wet pale curve has pressed up, with a seam down it that has parted to show an eye. The eye is looking at Sabeth's back. The woman's own face is turned to the wall. In the **right third**, at the ward's single wooden door, Wenna Thrale, the apprentice, stands with her back flat against it and both palms pressed to the wood. Her face is very young and very still. Beyond, down the curve of the ward, older women sit in chairs by the windows with their forearms in basins of water, the answered Opinions. Through the far windows the forty-foot red ring-wall shows in moonlight, with a ladder and a wicker hoist. Foreground: the basin, the brush and the pink water. The lower centre band is the dark scrubbed floorboards between the beds, unlit, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

A single rush-lamp hangs over the Brink bed and makes a small warm island in the dark. The ward beyond is lit only by thin moonlight through the east windows, cold and blue-grey, falling across the answered women and their basins. Sabeth is lit from the side, half her face in shadow. **Wet iron red** is the accent: in the water of her basin, in the cracked skin of her knuckles, in the faint rose of the crowning's lips, in the red of the ring-wall outside. Everything else is linen-white, lavender-grey and the deep brown-black of the old beams.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Sabeth's hands are the centre of the texture: the skin of the knuckles split and weeping, a thick callus on the inside of the ring finger where the hook of the knife rests, the nails scrubbed down to pink. The pumice is grey and gritty, the brush bristles splayed, the copper of the basin scoured bright on the inside and green on the outside. The Brink woman's nightgown has been cut open at the breastbone. The crowning's lips are soft, rose-brown and moist, its edges perfectly round, with a fine thread of a failed stitch dissolving at one side. The pale curve within is smooth and wet, like the crown of a skull, and the parted seam shows a grey-blue eye glistening. The answered Opinions' forearms are pale and puckered from water, the fingertips wrinkled white. The wooden door behind Wenna has a faint bulge in its planks, as if it were being pressed from the other side. Implied smell: lavender, lye and iron.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Lying-In is a ring of red walls forty feet high with no gate, entered by ladder and basket hoist. Here the Attendance brings the births nobody speaks about: the ones the Second Opinion spared and should not have, the ones it could not reach, the mothers who will not stop bearing, and the Brink-touched, in whom the flesh has opened into a crowning through which something presses toward the light at every pang. Nothing has ever come all the way out. Its

upper wards are clean and quiet and smell of lavender. Its lower wards are bricked, cell by cell, and the bricklayers are paid triple and change every year. The Lying-In keeps its own book, and nobody outside the Attendance has read it. Sabeth Thorne was for eighteen years the Opinion the other Opinions sent for. Last winter, in Tarnbrow, she counted eleven breaths, and the thing lived, and she has not reported it. Tonight she has been called to the bed by the east window, where the night Opinion has entered the patient as *the same as last month* and knows she is not. Sabeth has done nothing yet. She has opened the case and closed it again, and now she is scrubbing her hands, which is what every Opinion does, until the skin breaks. The woman in the bed has turned her face to the wall, which the Book says is to be permitted. Wenna holds the door, as apprentices are taught, because the door opened on its own when they came in and will not stay shut. In a moment the voice in the crowning will ask for water, and Sabeth will have to turn round.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The Lying-In's own book lies open on a lectern. The last entry reads *the same as last month*, and below it someone has written *it is not*.
- ◇ Down the ward, forty-four chairs line the windows, a few of them empty with basins still steaming.
- ◇ On the floor by the Brink bed lies a small bone door the size of a hand, hinged and closed.
- ◇ One of the answered Opinions is looking not at her basin but at Sabeth's back, and is counting on her wet fingers.
- ◇ Through the window, low on the ring-wall, a fresh course of bricks shows paler than the rest.
- ◇ The rush-lamp's smoke drifts toward the crowning, not toward the window.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide interior, 3:1, of a long curved hospital ward at night inside a red-walled fortress. At left a tall cropped-haired midwife stands with her back to the room, scrubbing cracked bleeding hands with pumice in a copper basin of pink water, a closed knife-case beside her. At centre, under one rush-lamp, a woman lies propped in bed with her face turned to the wall, and a round soft-lipped opening at her breastbone, from which a smooth pale curve with a parted seam shows a wet eye. At right a young apprentice in a white apron presses her back against a bulging wooden door. Older women sit by moonlit windows with their forearms in basins. Desaturated linen and lavender-grey, the only accent wet iron red. Intimate oil-paint body horror, a calm dark lower centre band.

Negative: infants, babies, newborns, birth depicted, explicit nudity, sexualised bodies, gore on children, surgery shown, knife in

use, bright colours, cartoon, clean digital gloss, modern hospital, electric light, text artefacts, watermark

▼ TACIT



The canyon does not forget a word. Neither does the thing beneath it. Speak as though you will be quoted, because you will.

INSCRIPTION OVER THE LESSER GATE OF TACIT

Plate: TACIT · *Half a million people and you can hear a sandal drop* · Oathen · canyon ochre and dried-blood brown

THE SHOT

Noon in Tacit, the one hour when light falls straight down the canyon like water poured into a well. The camera hangs at the middle of the Tenth Bridge, looking east along the gash with a 24mm lens, so the two cliff walls rise on either side of the frame and converge into haze. In the **centre third**, at the deepest point of the bridge's sag, stands Marrit Holloway, Bridge-Warden of the Tenth Bridge: broad, stooped in the careful way of the old bridge-families, a rigger's hook at her belt, her cheeks puffed and lips pressed tight. She is holding her breath, as everyone does at the middle. At her feet, the felt along the footboards is worn through in long pale patches. In the **left third** rises the Sunward Wall in full sun: tier upon tier of galleries cut into ochre rock, screens of pierced red stone, and on the fourth tier the façade of nine pillars carved as closed hands, the Hall of Conditions. In the **right third** the Shadeward Wall stands in red half-dusk, its galleries four feet wide and crowded with people passing sideways, eyes down. A pack of bitted children runs one gallery signing to each other, and a wicker lift hangs mid-haul on its felted rope. Bridges cross and recross the gulf at nine levels below and above. Far down, the Hushwater is a thin green stitch, and on the canyon floor the shanties of the Breakdowns crowd. In the far haze the canyon bends and the four-mile cliff of the Ledger begins, hung with scaffolds. Foreground: the felted handrope under

Marrit's fist. The lower centre band is the deep shadowed gulf below the bridge, dark and calm, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The noon light is hard, white and vertical, a single shaft that turns the top of the Sunward Wall almost bone-coloured and falls short of the canyon floor. The Shadeward side stays in a deep red-brown dusk, lit only by its own reflected glow. **Canyon ochre** is the accent, burning in the sunlit rock and in dust in the air, with **dried-blood brown** in the shadows and in the felt. The Hushwater is a thread of desaturated green-grey, the only cool note. No lamps; it is day. Paint no sky, or only a thin white slot of it high above.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Everything in Tacit is built to be quiet, and the texture shows it. Felt is everywhere: grey and ochre bolts hanging as door-curtains, padding the footboards of the bridge, wrapping the handropes, worn to a shine by hands. Hinges glisten with goat-fat. The rock is ochre sandstone, layered and fine-grained, and the gallery parapets are polished by elbows. Marrit's hands are tar-black and rope-calloused. Her spine bends at the waist in a curve too fixed to be posture: her family once swore by their spines. The children's faces are cut across by bits: leather straps through the mouth, buckled behind the head, the corners of their lips calloused smooth by years of wear. Across the gulf, a man on a gallery has a split lip healed white and a crooked finger, the small marks of childish boasts. Dust hangs in the shaft of light like flour. Implied smell: hot stone, goat, sour cheese, cedar oil.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Tacit is cut into both walls of the deepest canyon in Oathen, a thousand feet deep and in places only four hundred feet across, and half a million people live in it, and you can hear a sandal drop. In Oathen a promise is a physical fact. Keep it and nothing happens. Break it and the body breaks to match, at once, with a sound, in a

shape that fits the word. So the canyon does not chat. It speaks rarely, slowly and in conditionals, *if able, as I now intend*, and for prices and gossip it uses handtalk, which was believed until last year to cost nothing. Children are bitted until they are old enough to know what a sentence weighs. Sandals are soled with felt, cart wheels wrapped in rag, and dogs debarked as pups. The canyon throws every word back, and an echo is the speaker speaking again. Marrit Holloway's family has kept the Tenth Bridge for nine generations. On taking it they swore to keep it, Weight 4, and a Rope-Folk family whose bridge fails breaks with it, all of them. She crosses the middle twice a day holding her breath, because children are taught that the middle of a bridge is where words fall out of you. This noon she has stopped, against the habit of a lifetime, to look down at the felt under her boots. It has worn through in the shape of feet. Not shoes. Bare feet, very large, all walking east toward the Ledger, at night. She has not told anyone, because she does not know how to say it without asserting something. In a moment she will have to breathe.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The worn patches in the felt are clearly footprints: huge, bare, long-toed, all pointing east.
- ◇ A man on a Shadeward gallery has a shoulder pressed to his neighbour's back at the parapet. Nobody screams in a gallery fall.
- ◇ High on the Sunward Wall, under a striped awning, the glint of a brass spyglass is trained on the Heights: Silas Amend's.
- ◇ One of the bitted children has paused mid-sign. Her fingers are bent at an angle fingers should not bend.
- ◇ On a high bridge-stump at the canyon floor, the severed rope-ends from the Riots of 506 hang like tendons.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide canyon city, 3:1, at noon. A thousand-foot red-ochre gorge has its two sheer walls carved into tiers of galleries, pierced stone screens and doorways, and one wall carries a façade of pillars shaped as closed fists. Hundreds of felt-wrapped rope bridges cross the gulf at many levels. At centre, at the sag of one bridge, a stooped broad female rigger with a hook holds her breath, cheeks puffed, staring down at bare giant footprints worn into the felt. Crowded shadow-side galleries hold silent people and running children with leather bits buckled through their mouths, signing. A thin green river runs far below. A hard white vertical shaft of light falls from above. Desaturated, the only accents canyon ochre and dried-blood brown. Oil and ink, dusty texture, deep calm dark gulf in the lower centre.

Negative: open mouths shouting, crowds celebrating, bright colours, blue sky, lush greenery, cartoon, clean digital gloss, modern

bridges, steel, cars, electric light, text artefacts, watermark, tourist ruins, gore on children

▼ THE BREAKDOWNS



*I was a liar for nine years with a whole face. Now I
have the face I earned. Nobody has to wonder.*

A FORSWORN OF HONEST MEASURE, MOUTH OPEN
TO THE EARS

Plate: THE BREAKDOWNS · *Slum of the Forsworn* · Oathen ·
canyon ochre and dried-blood brown

THE SHOT

Sunrise on the canyon floor below Tacit, at the river's edge, during a Showing. The camera is a 35mm at waist height on the shingle, looking across the shallows toward the cliff foot, with both canyon walls rising out of the top of the frame. In the **centre third** stands Brakk, Voice of the Forsworn: huge, grey-bearded, laughing, his oiled cloth thrown back off his chest. His ribs have opened outward like the covers of a book and stayed that way, and under the stretched skin his heart and lungs are visible, slick, working, breath steaming from his chest in the cool dawn. One great arm is round the shoulders of a newcomer. In the **left third** stands the newcomer, a young Felt Market haggler, freshly broken, his cloth just taken from his hands, which have bent back at the knuckles of every finger, and he is staring at them. Facing him in a half-ring along the bank, the lane shows him theirs, one by one: a woman whose mouth has split back to the ears, a man on knees that bend the heron's way, a woman whose hands came off for short weight. In the **right third** the Breakdowns climb the cliff foot: lean-tos, houses built from the wreckage of the cut bridges, flat-boats turned keel-up, smoke from goat-dung fires, and a chalked board on a corner. Above, severed bridge-stumps hang from the walls. Foreground: the green shallows, and a jug of fig-spirit on the shingle. The lower centre band is the dark wet shingle at the water's edge, calm, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The sun reaches the Breakdowns for two hours a day, and this is the first of them: a low warm wedge of light falling down the canyon, catching the tops of heads and the steam from Brakk's chest and leaving the cliff foot in deep brown shadow. **Canyon ochre** lights the walls and the dust in the air. **Dried-blood brown** is in the oiled cloth, the old stains, the river mud and the shadows. The Hushwater is a muted green-grey. A few dung fires add small orange points that must be kept desaturated.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The Forsworn bodies are sentences written in flesh and healed as written. Brakk's chest is the heart of the image: the ribs swung outward on their cartilage and fixed, the skin stretched between them like a tent and gone translucent, scarred along every edge, and beneath it the heart moving, glossy and dark, the lungs pale and spongy, rising. Steam curls from it. His beard is thick and grey and his teeth are bared in a laugh. The newcomer's fingers are bent backward at every joint, swollen and purple, the nail-beds weeping. The split mouth of the woman beside him has healed into a permanent grin of scar, gums and back teeth visible. The man's backward knees are knobbed and calloused, his shins bowed. The oiled cloths are dark, stiff, grease-shined. The river mud is red-brown and cracked at the edges. Implied smell: fig-spirit, goat-dung smoke, wound-dressing and wet slate.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Breakdowns are the slum of the Forsworn, perhaps a hundred thousand people in a mile and a half of canyon floor, and they are the loudest place in Oathen, because the people in them have nothing left to lose. A part lost to a grievous Breaking cannot break again. A woman whose hands came off can swear on the scales until her death; a man whose chest stands open can tell any woman he loves her and walk away whole. The Breakdowns call it standing on broken ground. Here people shout, laugh, lie for sport, haggle aloud

and sing, and mock the Walls overhead. Their lanes are named for the oaths their founders broke: Fair Weight Row, Back-Before-Dark, the Never Alley, I'll-Stand-By-You, Till-Death Court. This dawn a newcomer has come down. He broke in the Felt Market yesterday over a haggle in handtalk, which was supposed not to count, and since 640 it does. He came down on a lift with his hands wrapped. Now the lane brings him to the river at sunrise for the Showing. His cloth is taken, the whole lane looks at what broke, and then the lane shows him theirs. Brakk is always there. He broke a marriage vow, and he is the most plainspoken man in Oathen: he says *I love you* to strangers and *I will kill you* to Clausewrights, and laughs at both. In a moment someone will feed the newcomer, and he will be one of them. Brakk's fear, which he does not show at the river, is that the Bench is right, and that the broken deserve it.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The chalked board on the corner reads *LIES TOLD — 3 L. UNDER OATH IN A COURT — 10 L. LOVE, SWORN — 2 L, AND YOU BUY THE DRINK.*
- ◇ A brass speaking-trumpet hangs from Brakk's belt. He uses it to shout up at the Walls.
- ◇ In the half-ring, three newcomers have fingers broken at the same joint: handtalkers, all broken this year.
- ◇ Up on a Shadeward gallery, a whole Oathener leans out to watch, a crumb held between two fingers: the Extra Crumb, *I saw, and will not tell.*
- ◇ A lane-sign nailed to a keel-up boat reads *Till-Death Court*, and beneath it sit eleven strapped figures, the survivors of Wending.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide scene, 3:1, at sunrise on a canyon floor beside a thin green river, beneath towering red-ochre walls with severed rope-bridge stumps. At centre a huge laughing grey-bearded man has his ribs opened outward like a book and healed that way, his heart and lungs visible and glistening under stretched translucent skin, breath steaming from his chest. One arm is round a young man staring at his own fingers, bent backward at every joint. A half-ring of the broken shows their wounds: a woman whose mouth is split back to the ears, a man on backward-bending knees. Behind them is a slum of lean-tos, wrecked bridge timbers and upturned boats. A warm low wedge of light, deep brown shadow. Desaturated, the only accents canyon ochre and dried-blood brown. Intimate oil-paint body horror, a calm dark lower centre.

Negative: fresh blood spray, splatter, open wounds bleeding heavily, gore on children, sexualised bodies, bright colours, blue sky, cartoon, clean digital gloss, modern clothing, plastic, electric light, text artefacts, watermark, zombies

▼ SWORN GORGE



Nobody is near Sworn Gorge. The Wardens should be told.

MARGIN NOTE AGAINST THE NINETEENTH ECHO,
ECHO-WARDENS' TABLE OF THE GORGES

Plate: SWORN GORGE · *An oath shouted in 419 that has never stopped* · Oathen · canyon ochre and dried-blood brown

THE SHOT

Night at the mouth of Sworn Gorge, a sealed ravine east of Tacit, under a thin moon. The camera is a long 100mm set back among the ruins of Sowe, looking up the narrow approach to the wall, so the gorge's mouth is compressed into a tall dark slot. In the **centre third** stands the wall: dressed stone forty feet high, filling the ravine from side to side, its courses packed behind with wool that bulges grey-white from every crack and joint like stuffing from a split mattress. Pressed against its foot, his whole body flattened to the stone, is Halvar Stane, Echo-Warden: gaunt, bow-legged, deaf in the right ear by initiation, his good left ear crushed against the wall, his eyes wide, his lips moving. He has dropped his lantern and it lies on its side at his feet. In the **left third** are the twenty stone houses of Sowe, the dead hamlet, roofs intact, every door shut. Above the ravine's mouth, on both sides, carved stone hands stand out from the rock, palm outward, the old sign for a silent gorge. In the **right third**, in the doorway of the Wardens' post, stands Gorge-Warden Tacet Morrow, a shortbow in one hand, wax and lead in both ears, watching Halvar. Her other hand is raised, not yet signalling. Foreground: a scatter of dropped ear-plugs, lead and wax, on the stones. Midground: Halvar and the wall. Background: the black slot of the ravine above the wall and a sliver of sky. The lower centre band is the dark rubble of the path at the wall's foot, unlit, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Thin cold moonlight falls into the ravine from above and silvers the top of the wall and the stone hands. The fallen lantern, on its side, throws a low smoky glow across the wall's foot and up Halvar's face from below, and that small warm pool is the only warmth in the frame. **Canyon ochre** is in the lantern-lit stone; **dried-blood brown** is in the deep shadows, in Sowe's doorways, and in old stains down the wall where water has wept from the wool. Everything else is moon-grey and black.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The wall is old dressed sandstone, its faces scoured smooth by two centuries of wind, its joints stuffed with grey wool gone matted and felted with dust and age. In places the wool has rotted dark and wet, and long brown stains run down the stone below it. Halvar's face is weathered to leather, deeply lined, the skin of his cheek pressed white against the stone. His right ear is a puckered knot of old surgical scar where the initiation closed it. His lips are dry and cracked and shaped mid-word. His fingers are splayed on the stone, nails broken. Sowe's houses have doors of grey weathered wood, warped, swollen tight in their frames, with the bars on the inside: you can see the ends of the bars through the gaps. The stone hands at the gorge mouth are worn soft. The dropped plugs are small grey cones, bitten. Implied: no smell at all, because the wool has drunk it.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

In the drought summer of 419, something was shouted in this ravine, and the ravine has never stopped saying it. A page is cut from the Bench's minutes for that year and a stretch of the Ledger has been chiselled smooth. What is known is that the people of Sowe, at the gorge's mouth, were all found broken the following spring, every one of them, in the same way, and that the Echo-Wardens' charter forbids describing the shape. In Oathen an echo is the speaker speaking again, and anyone who hears this one is bound by it. Nobody knows any longer what it says. The gorge was walled and

the wall packed with wool, and for two hundred years a man pressing his ear to it could hear a murmur in the rock like a crowd a mile off, rising and falling. This Carving, for the first time in two hundred years, it stopped. Halvar Stane has tracked the echo for thirty years. He has come close enough to make out two words and will not repeat them, because to repeat is to renew. He was relieved as Warden of the Wall in 639 because Tacet Morrow found him at it with his ear to the stone and his lips moving. He dreams of the wall nightly and has begun sleepwalking toward it. Tonight he walked here from Tacit in his sleep, and woke with his ear to the stone, and heard nothing, and that nothing is worse. Three herders in the eastern canyons have broken the way Sowe broke. Halvar believes the echo has found a way out. In the next breath Tacet will signal, and he will have to decide whether to stop his own mouth.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Halvar's lips are shaping the second of two words, and only the first syllable shows.
- ◇ On the wall, at the height of a man's ear, the stone is worn into a smooth shallow hollow by thirty years of Halvar's ear.
- ◇ One door in Sowe, in the left third, has a thin line of dark under it. It is the only door whose bar has been slid back from the inside.
- ◇ On the face of the wall, high up, a section of wool has been pulled out from the far side. The hole is the size of a mouth.
- ◇ The carved stone hands above the ravine have their palms out, but the uppermost one has turned in its socket to face the gorge.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide night scene, 3:1, in a narrow red-rock ravine sealed by a forty-foot wall of dressed stone, with matted grey wool bulging from every crack and joint and long brown water-stains below. A gaunt bow-legged old man lies pressed flat against its foot with one ear crushed to the stone, eyes wide, lips moving, a fallen lantern glowing at his feet. At left stands a dead hamlet of twenty stone houses with every warped door shut and barred from inside. At right, a woman with wax in her ears watches from a guard-post doorway with a bow. Carved stone hands jut palm-outward from the cliffs. Thin cold moonlight, one warm lantern pool. Desaturated moon-grey and black, the only accents canyon ochre and dried-blood brown. Oil and ink, huge negative space, a calm dark lower centre.

Negative: visible sound waves, ghosts, glowing runes, monsters, corpses, bright colours, cartoon, clean digital gloss, modern locks, electric light, text artefacts, watermark, daylight, starry sky, fantasy magic effects

▼ THE LEDGER



Writing is not supposed to count.

OTTOLINE VANT, SCRIBE OF THE LEDGER, TO THE
BENCH, CARVING 640

Plate: THE LEDGER · *Four miles of carved vows* · Oathen · canyon ochre and dried-blood brown

THE SHOT

Late afternoon on the face of the Ledger, the four-mile cliff at the east end of Tacit into which every vow of public record has been carved. The camera hangs in space beside a scaffold, an 85mm lens at the carver's height, eight hundred feet up, looking along the cliff so that its face recedes in a long ochre wall of lettering to the vanishing point. In the **left third**, on a plank scaffold slung from ropes, kneels Ottoline Vant: thirty, sunburned, lean from the scaffolds, hair bound in a cloth, a vinegar-rag tied over her mouth and nose. Her eyes are closed. Her fingertips rest on a line of letters cut into the stone in front of her, reading them by touch; one finger is pressed into a single word. Her mallet and chisel lie untouched on the plank beside her knee. In the **centre third**, the cliff of carving runs away: millions of letters, treaties, marriages, sentences and Rim Road contracts, line after line in a dense close hand, the near ones crisp and pale with fresh dust, the far ones worn nearly smooth. Scaffolds hang down the face at intervals, each with a tiny figure working in silence. In the **right third**, on the next scaffold over, crouches Master Carver Ebbe Lantry, grey and dust-caked, his hand closed on a folded list, looking at Ottoline. Below, the cliff falls away to the Carvers' Rows, a haze of pink chippings, and the dark slot of a vent in the rock that breathes from the record-rooms behind. Foreground: the ropes of Ottoline's scaffold, fraying. The lower centre band is the shadowed lower face of the cliff, its oldest letters worn to texture, calm and dark, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The sun is low in the west, behind the camera, and lights the cliff face at a raking angle that throws every carved letter into relief, each cut a thin line of shadow. The near face blazes **canyon ochre**. The dust in the air glows. The lower cliff and the canyon floor sink into **dried-blood brown** shadow. Ottoline's face is lit warm on one side. The far scaffolds are silhouettes. Keep the sky out of frame, or a thin bleached strip at the top.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The stone is fine-grained ochre sandstone, and the letters are cut sharp-edged and V-sectioned, crisp at the near end, with stone-dust still lying in their troughs. Further along the cliff they soften, weathered and rounded, until at the far west they are only ripples, like the skin of a healed burn. Ottoline's hands are the detail: fingertips calloused and split, rubbed raw on the stone, a thin smear of blood left in the troughs of the letters she has been reading. Her sunburned skin peels at the nose. Her eyelids are red and swollen from dust and the vinegar she rinses them with. The scaffold planks are grey, rope-bound, worn smooth. Ebbe Lantry's face is caked pale with dust, and there is grit in the creases of his lips. In the dust at his knee lies something he has coughed up, small and shaped. The chippings below lift on the wind in a fine pink haze. Implied smell: stone-dust, lamp-smoke, vinegar.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Ledger is the memory of Oathen. Since the year 12, every vow of public record has been carved into this cliff by carvers who work on scaffolds in silence, in all weathers, at a lack a letter. Behind the face lies a warren of record-rooms and copying halls; below them, the Ninth Room, where executions are conducted; and below that, the Gilded Cells. The Bench has always held that writing does not count. Last year Ottoline Vant miscut one vow by a single word, writing *never* where the sworn record read *not*, and the man it named broke that night. She has not carved a letter since. She started

checking the old carvings for errors and found eleven, and all eleven of the people named broke the night the carving was done. The Bench put it down to coincidence each time, and posted a notice at the foot of the scaffolds, carved, saying that carving does not count, and every carver looks at it each morning and wonders whether it is binding. Many carvers now work with their eyes closed, touching the letters of the draft with their fingertips to be sure that what the hand knows is what the Bench wrote. Ottoline has climbed back up today not to carve but to read, and she is touching her own miscut. Ebbe Lantry, who taught her, took her list and went looking for a twelfth. He found it. It is one of his own, from 609, and the man it names is a Benchman who has never broken. Someone corrected that stone at night. Ebbe has come out on the next scaffold to tell her.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Under Ottoline's fingertip the word *NEVER* is cut slightly deeper and fresher than the letters around it.
- ◇ Down the cliff a smoothed rectangle interrupts the lines, very carefully chiselled flat: the stretch erased for the year 419.
- ◇ On a ledge by Ottoline's knee lies a small dish of uneaten figs.
- ◇ On one distant scaffold, a carver works by night-lamp on a stone that is not on any Bench draft.
- ◇ The fresh dust in the troughs of one long line of letters is disturbed by marks like large bare fingertips, reaching from above where no scaffold hangs.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly wide view, 3:1, along an immense ochre sandstone cliff face covered from end to end in millions of carved letters, crisp and dusty near, worn smooth far away, with rope-slung plank scaffolds hanging down it. At left a lean sunburned young woman kneels on a scaffold eight hundred feet up, eyes closed, a cloth tied over her nose and mouth, bloodied fingertips pressed into one carved word, her chisel set aside. At right, on another scaffold, an old dust-caked master carver clutches a folded list and watches her. Below, the canyon floor is lost in pink stone-dust haze. Low raking sunlight throws every letter into relief. Desaturated, the only accents canyon ochre and dried-blood brown. Oil and ink, gritty dry-brush stone texture, a calm dark lower centre band.

Negative: legible real-world text, readable words, alphabet artefacts, modern lettering, typography, watermark, bright colours, blue sky, cartoon, clean digital gloss, power tools, modern harnesses, electric light, heroic pose

▼ THE GILDED CELLS



I have been listening. I have not stopped.

SCRATCHED INTO THE LEAD OF THE THIRD GILDED CELL, CROSSED OUT, AND SCRATCHED AGAIN

Plate: THE GILDED CELLS · *Where the Sayers are kept* · Oathen · canyon ochre and dried-blood brown

THE SHOT

Deep under the Ledger, inside the third of the nine Gilded Cells. The camera is a 50mm at the seated height of the prisoner, close, intimate, the cell's low lead-lined vault curving over the top of the frame. In the **centre third**, seated upright on a felted bench, is Lady Imre Dath, the Sayer: a Tongue-line woman of twenty-eight in a plain grey shift, her mouth held in a bit of soft pure gold cast to its exact shape and strapped behind her head. Her face has grown long and smooth. Her eyes have sealed over with skin. Across her cheeks and temples small pink ears have bloomed like moss, turned upward toward the Ledger above. In her lap is a wax tablet, and in her hand is a stylus, and she has been writing. In the **left third**, on a stool at her side, sits Garl Tome, the Bitmaker: fifty, broad, bearded, a kerchief over his own mouth from habit. He holds a small gold tongue-plate up to the lamp, calipers in his other hand, resizing it because her tongue has grown again. A leather roll of fine tools lies open across his knees. In the **right third**, beyond the cell's open gold-faced iron door, stands a guard in the corridor, bitted in iron, his ears surgically closed, facing away. Down the corridor are two more doors, one of them very old and sealed. Foreground: the edge of the wax tablet, its lines visible. The lower centre band is the dark felt-covered floor and the shadow under the bench, calm, for the title.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

A single shielded oil lamp hangs on a hook by Garl's shoulder, and its light is the only light: close, warm and low. It falls on the gold of the bit, which is the brightest object in the series, though it must still be painted dull and buttery, never brilliant. **Canyon ochre** lives in the gold and the lamp-glow on skin. **Dried-blood brown** is in the felt, the shadows and the old stains at the corners of her mouth. The lead walls are a dull blue-grey that drinks light. The corridor beyond is near-black.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Imre's face is the heart of the plate. The skin over her eyes is smooth and seamless, faintly shiny, with only the slightest curve of the eyeball beneath. The ears across her cheeks and temples are small and perfect, pink and translucent at the rims, folded like young fungus, some wet inside, all turned to listen. The gold bit fills her mouth, its surface marked with fine tooth-scores, and at its edges the lips have grown soft and slightly swollen around it. A thin line of dried blood-brown crusts the corner. Her hands are pale and long-fingered, and wax is caught under the nails. Garl's hands are thick, scarred from the forge, delicate with the calipers. The tongue-plate in his fingers is worn bright on its upper face. The lead walls are beaten and dented, lined with old felt gone dark at the seams, and words are scratched into the lead, crossed out and scratched again. Implied smell: lead, broth, cedar oil, and something sweeter, like the inside of a mouth.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

A Tongue-line in the last stage of the god's Regrowth does not describe the world. What they say, is. The canyons call them the Sayers, and they are the closest thing to Tolm walking again: not the god's ear but its mouth. The first, a Hushwell girl, said *I wish it would stop* during a storm in 598, and everything in the valley of Low Shale stopped, and it is still there, intact, with nothing moving. The few Sayers alive are kept here, bitted in gold, the one metal

Tolm's mouth will not bite through, in a vault of nine lead-lined chambers whose guards are bitted and deafened. A bit cut with copper was bitten through in 611, and the Sayer it held said one word into the dark, and no one knows what. Imre Dath was clever and talkative, which her mother punished. At twenty-five she said *My brother is a liar* at dinner, and her brother's mouth opened back to his ears and has never closed. She has been here three years, and she hears everything said in the Ledger above. Once a year the Bench unmuzzles her to say one sentence its Clausewrights have drafted for months. Last year's was *The canyon wells shall not run dry this Lack*, and they did not. She does not hate the Bench. She pities it. Garl Tome comes every few months to resize the plate, and he is the only visitor who stays. He fitted his own daughter with a bit at birth and has never heard her voice. Tonight he has noticed the tablet, and the stylus, and that she has begun to write her own.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ On the wax tablet, Imre's unseen handwriting runs in neat lines. The last line breaks off mid-word, and the line above ends *one more at the table than*.
- ◇ The words in the lead behind her, *I have been listening*, are scratched at the height of a seated woman's mouth.
- ◇ Down the corridor, the first cell's door is crusted and unopened, and a gold glint shows at its grille. The First Sayer has not been unbitted in forty-three years.
- ◇ A copper bit hangs on the corridor wall, bitten clean through, kept as a warning.
- ◇ The guard in the corridor has no ears, and he is smiling.
- ◇ Garl Tome's tool roll holds a second, very small gold bit, unfinished, the size of a twelve-year-old's mouth.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly intimate wide interior, 3:1, of a low vaulted cell lined with dented lead and dark felt, lit by one shielded oil lamp. At centre a pale young woman in a grey shift sits upright, her mouth filled by a fitted soft gold bit strapped behind her head. Her eyes are sealed over with smooth skin, and small pink ears bloom across her cheeks and temples like moss, turned upward. She holds a stylus over a wax tablet in her lap. Beside her a broad bearded smith with a kerchief over his mouth holds up a small gold tongue-plate and calipers to the lamp. Beyond an open gold-faced iron door, an earless bitted guard stands in a dark corridor. Desaturated lead-grey and felt-brown, the only accents canyon ochre gold and dried-blood brown. Intimate oil-paint body horror, soft rim light, a calm dark lower centre.

Negative: shiny gold glare, jewellery glamour, sexualised figure, bondage aesthetic, bright colours, cartoon, anime, clean digital

gloss, modern prison, electric light, text artefacts, legible writing, watermark, gore on children, screaming



CHAPTER 5

PLATES OF THE
FAST AND THE RIM
ROAD

These seven plates cover the middle of the Table and the ring of road that goes around it. Every other land's plates were painted in the colours of rot, salt, smoke or meat. The Fast's plates are painted in **warm candle gold**, the only kind light anywhere in the series. That warmth is where the horror is. Every artist on this set must keep one rule in mind: in the Fast, nothing hurts you. The god Orrum, the Host, has never once been unkind. The fields are combed, the hedges laid, the cloths spotless, the lamps lit. The people are starving in the cold beside a feast because they will not say yes to it, and the ones who did say yes are still sitting at table, happy, centuries later. Paint the welcome so well that the viewer wants to step into it, and then put a thin, cold, upright figure in the frame, refusing.

The Rim Road plates take the Fast's gold to its edge, where it lies against the ordinary grey of the world like the light from a door left open. Keep the gold on the inner side, the side that faces the middle, and keep the outer road bone-grey and wet.

Two cautions. First, the Host is never painted whole. Show its kindnesses: a napkin, a pulled-out chair, a warm print on stone. Second, and stricter: there were eight chairs at the first table and only seven peoples, and nobody counts the chairs. Each plate holds one small thing that is a seat too many, a side too clean, a shadow for nobody. Never draw who it is for.

▼ HALLOWBOARD



Seven sides worn, one side clean. Don't ask me whose.

REFT LAMMAS, ROLL-KEEPER OF BARROWGATE

Plate: HALLOWBOARD · *The eight-sided table at the centre of the world* · The Fast · warm candle gold

THE SHOT

A long lens from low on the slope of the chalk hill, just above the Barrows, looking up and across at the summit so that the stone table sits on the horizon like an altar on a step. Kneeling height, the first grey-gold minute after dawn on the morning after Tablenight. In the left third, the foreground is the Barrows: long, low, grassed mounds with coarse pale grass that hangs off them like uncombed hair, and a line of the Abstinent walking down between them away from the hill in single file, roped belt to belt, their backs to the stone. They are small dark strokes, leaning forward with exhaustion. In the centre third, Hollowboard: a forty-foot slab of grey granite with eight sides, waist-high, polished to a dull gleam, set on the round bare crown of the hill. The worn chalk trench circles seven of its sides like a pale moat. The eighth side faces the camera at a slight angle, and the chalk in front of it is smooth, white and unmarked, the only clean ground in the picture. In the right third, a single figure stands close to the stone with one hand raised above its surface, not touching: **Reft Lammas**, Roll-Keeper of Barrowgate, checking for the handprints. Behind him an empty ash carrying-chair waits on the slope, its poles resting on the chalk. The background is the heartland seen from above, a gold haze of combed fields and ruled orchards, with thin straight threads of chimney smoke rising from empty farmhouses all the way to the horizon. The lower centre band, where the title sits, is the dark shadowed flank of the hill below the stone, a calm field of blue-grey chalk in shade.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The sun comes from low and slightly too far west, which is wrong for dawn, and the Fast's light is always wrong like that. It washes the top of the hill and the upper face of the stone in **warm candle gold**, rich and soft as butter at the edge of a flame. The gold also lies on the seven warm handprints on the slab, which glow faintly, like the inside of an oven, and on the thin far chimney threads. Everything else is cold: the roped walkers are blue-grey and black, the Barrows are near-monochrome ash and bone, and Reft's coat is the colour of wet slate. The clean eighth side gets no gold at all. It is lit flat white, the light from nowhere, as though a lamp were held there that nobody can see.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The chalk trench is the record of the Refusal: pressed into its hard pale floor, layered and overlapping, are the faint shapes of bare feet and knees, thousands deep, like fossil prints on a riverbed. After last night's rain a few small things have washed up out of it, and along the trench lip lie teeth, brown and grey, worn flat at the crowns, some still with a dark root. The granite is smooth enough to hold a reflection, with no moss, no lichen, no birdlime, and the handprints on it are not stains but warmth, a faint steam lifting off each one into the cold air, as from a loaf just set down. Reft's hand is the hand of an Unfed: long, knuckled, the skin thin and yellowish over the tendons, the nails ridged. His lips are parted and his tongue is held flat to keep the smell out, the Fast's always-there smell of new bread and brown butter. On the Barrows the pale grass is matted where something large lay down among the mounds overnight, and the shape it left is a person curled on one side, arms around something.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Hallowboard is the centre of the world. Six hundred and forty-one years ago the Unfed stood here around their god's table for nine days and nights and said *no, thank you*, forty thousand of them, while six

other peoples ate their gods in the same black season. The ones who died standing are under the Barrows. The ones who lived walked east and built a town with no hearths. The god, refused, stood up, ducked its head under every lintel on the Stoopway, and has been walking the empty heartland ever since, laying tables, mending them when they are broken, and waiting.

Every Tablenight the Abstinent climb the hill and stand around the stone with their backs to it through the longest night of the year. The empty ash chair on the slope is Elder Forbear Wend's; his bearers have already carried him down, because he could not stay to see the stone in daylight. They walk home roped together, silent, the way people leave a sickroom.

Reft Lammas stays. He is the Roll-Keeper of Barrowgate and it is his duty, every year, to count the handprints. He has counted seven every year of his life. A large hand, palm down, beside each worn side, like a host resting a hand beside a guest's plate to say *there, that's yours*. He is counting now, lips moving. He has reached seven. He is looking at the eighth side, where there is never a print, and where the chalk has never been trodden, and where the one carved panel on the stone has had its figure smoothed away by a thumb, many times, a long time ago. He does not know why nobody stands there. Nobody does. When he is asked, he will say what they all say, puzzled, that it is someone else's place. In a moment he will write *seven* in the roll, close the book, and go down the hill faster than he came up.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The smoothed carving on the eighth side, if looked at closely, still shows the faint outline of a chair back, and no one sitting in it.
- ◇ Among the teeth on the trench lip is one milk tooth, very small, set apart from the others on a folded white napkin; the Host has tidied it.
- ◇ Reft's roll book, open under his arm, has a column for each of the seven sides and an eighth column that has been ruled and left blank on every page.
- ◇ One rope among the walkers has an extra loop tied in it at the end of the file, a belt-knot with no belt in it.
- ◇ The ash chair's seat holds a faint warm hollow, though Wend was lifted out of it an hour ago.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly oil and ink, wide 3:1 cinematic composition, a vast eight-sided grey granite table on a bare round chalk hilltop at dawn, worn pale trench circling seven sides, eighth side untouched white chalk lit flatly from nowhere; low warm candle-gold light from the west gilding the stone and seven faint steaming handprints on it; a gaunt cold-skinned Unfed man in a slate-grey coat raising a hand over the slab, counting; an empty ash carrying-chair on the slope; foreground of long grassy burial mounds with pale hair-like grass, a roped line of thin dark figures walking away; scattered old teeth on

the chalk; distant golden farmland with straight thin chimney smoke; heavy black shadow in the lower centre, gritty dry-brush texture, near-monochrome with one warm gold accent.

Negative: bright colours, saturated sky, cartoon, anime, clean digital gloss, modern objects, text artefacts, lettering on the stone, visible god, figure on the eighth side, crowds facing the table, fantasy castles, lens flare, cheerful mood

▼ WANTING



◇
*Carry your own. Count your chairs. Close the gate,
and then go through it again.*

WHAT A WANTING MOTHER SAYS AT THE DOOR
EACH MORNING

Plate: WANTING · *The town with no hearths* · The Fast · warm candle gold

THE SHOT

Street level, a 35mm lens at a child's height, in the blue dark before dawn in Lack, looking down a straight cobbled street in Pinners' Yard toward Pantry Close. The street is a corridor of long, low, grey stone houses roofed in slate and frosted white, and there is not one chimney on any roof, so the skyline is a row of flat, cold, unbroken ridges. In the left third, in the foreground, a heavy iron-strapped door hangs open outward, and on its threshold stands **Meagre Toft**, Measure-Bearer, fifteen, with a ration-cloth bundled under one arm and her palm pressed flat against the door from outside, in the middle of the ritual of closing it, opening it, going back in and coming out again. Behind her, through the gap, her mother stands against a bare inside wall in every garment she owns. In the centre third, the street runs away from us to the squat round Pantry tower, five storeys of dressed stone, windowless below the fourth floor, one lamp burning at its iron door, and in front of it the Ration Line already formed, four abreast, a dark mass of hunched wool and white breath. In the right third, doors all down the street are open at the same moment, and in each a thin figure performs its own family's way of closing, touching, returning. At the top of the right edge, sitting on a stone at the head of a rising street, is blind Old Pinch Corve, listening to everyone breathe. Far in the background, past the last roofs to the west, the sky is not dark: it is a low band of

gold, the edge of the Fast. The lower centre band is the frost-black, empty cobbles of the street.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The town is in pre-dawn blue-black, lit by the frost itself and one lamp. The cold is the main colour: bone, slate, iron, breath. The only warm thing inside the town is the small pale amber of the Pantry lamp, and it is not gold, it is weaker, a thin yellow. The real **warm candle gold** lies outside, on the western horizon over the roofs, a soft rich band where it is always an early Carving afternoon. It reaches into the town only as a faint gilt edge on the west-facing sides of the frosted ridges, like light on a knife.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

Frost grows on the inside of Meagre's shutter in fern shapes, and there is a clear print of her palm in it, because frost inside means the god was not near in the night. Her hand on the door is red-knuckled and chapped, the skin over her wrist bones shiny and tight, the nails bitten. Her face is young and already shows the skull: hollow at the temple, the hinges of the jaw visible under the skin, lips cracked white in the cold. The Line's breath hangs over the Close in a low fog, and the faint sweet pear-drop tang of hunger breath is in it. The walls of the houses are rough grey stone, and where each house once had a hearth there is a square of newer brick in the wall, mortared shut, scrubbed and cold. The cobbles are worn into a ring around the Pantry by centuries of slow feet, and no path crosses the Close. The doors have deep scuffs at the handle height of every member of every family, worn by the closing rituals of six hundred years.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Wanting is the only real town of the Unfed, nine thousand people on a cold limestone ridge on the eastern edge of the Fast, half a day from the Rim Road. It was built in 188 A.G. to one idea: that nothing in it should look like an invitation. There are no inns, no bakeries, no kitchens, no benches. Doors open outward so that no

one inside can be said to have let anyone in. Cooking is done in the Cold Yards at the edge of town, on bare earth under the open sky, and the fires are put out the moment the food is warm. There is nowhere to sit in the whole town except the floor of your own house.

Meagre Toft is the girl from the ledger of ordinary days. She woke in the dark because the cold woke her, checked the frost, touched the bricked hearth, said the Five Rules into the blanket. Her mother said *carry your own*, and Meagre said *I carry my own*. Now she is closing the door from the outside, and in a moment she will open it, go back in, close it from inside, and come out again, because that is how her family does it, and all the families have a way, and all of them are about the door. She will walk the long way around the Close, never across it, and stand in the Line, and carry thirty-one cloth bundles out to Thinwick and Sallow Hatch and the Brindle farms. Last week there were thirty-three.

The feeling at ground level is quiet and slow. People walk carefully to save their strength. Nobody says good morning. A Rim visitor would call it the most miserable town on the Table. The Unfed would agree, and take it as praise.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ One roof in the row, far down the street, has a single thin thread of smoke rising from it, from a house that has no chimney.
- ◇ On Meagre's windowsill, under the frost, is a small dark shape: a crust left out by a child, and beside it, a ripe plum that nobody in Wanting could have.
- ◇ Old Pinch Corve's head is turned, not toward the street, but west, toward the gold, as if he hears someone breathing there.
- ◇ The scuff marks on the Toft door count four family members at four heights; there are three people in the house.
- ◇ The Ration Line is four abreast, and in one rank there are three people and a gap kept exactly the width of a fourth.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly oil and ink, wide 3:1 cinematic frame, pre-dawn winter street of long low grey stone houses with frosted slate roofs and no chimneys at all, heavy iron-strapped doors opening outward; a gaunt fifteen-year-old girl in layered wool with a ration bundle, palm flat on a door, breath steaming; behind her a thin woman against a bare wall; doors open down the street with thin figures touching their frames; a squat windowless round stone granary tower at the street's end with one weak lamp and a hunched queue four abreast in fog; a blind old man seated on a stone at right; on the western horizon a low band of warm candle-gold light over the roofs; frost ferns, bricked-up hearths, worn cobbles, blue-black and bone palette, heavy dark empty lower centre.

Negative: bright colours, chimneys, warm interiors, food, cartoon, anime, clean digital gloss, modern objects, text artefacts,

shop signs, window boxes, smiling crowds, snow-globe prettiness, lens flare

▼ THE LONG TABLE



We kept you a place. We always keep you a place. It's further along now. You'll find it.

A CHORUS OF THE SEATED, EIGHTH MILE

Plate: THE LONG TABLE · *Nine miles of the Seated, eating nothing in good cheer* · The Fast · warm candle gold

THE SHOT

A wide lens from the far verge of the valley road, at standing height, looking diagonally across the road and down the length of the table so that it runs from the left edge into a vanishing point in the right third and never ends. The valley sides are beech-hung hills, the leaves on the turn and never falling. In the left third, in the foreground on the verge, the road between her and the cloth, stands **Sparing Lowe**, widow of Pinners' Yard, in her visiting coat with wax in her nostrils, hands folded, talking across the road to her son. In the centre third, the table: pale unidentifiable wood, a spotless white cloth unbroken into the distance, lamps lit at intervals in broad daylight, porcelain and silver, and the Seated on both sides in every stage of wasting. Her son sits directly across from her, about forty, his coat hanging off a frame, smiling courteously, calling her *madam*. Two chairs down sits **Brother Hallow Crust**, a draped coat with a head, a silver fork raised to his mouth with nothing on it. The right third is the long perspective of the table shrinking toward the valley's head, the Seated becoming smaller, paler, thinner, until the farthest are only coats holding a posture. Somewhere along it, small, clearly, one chair is pulled out from the table and empty. The background is the head of the valley in gold haze. The lower centre band is the grey flint road surface between Sparing and the table, kept dark and calm, a strip of no-man's-land.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The light is the Fast's unending early-Carving afternoon: low, amber, coming from slightly too far west, laying long soft shadows of chair legs across the road. **Warm candle gold** lives on the table: in the lamp flames, glinting on rims of porcelain and silver, glowing through the steam over dishes, and warming the cloth to the colour of fresh cream. The Seated are lit by it kindly, the way portraits are lit. Sparing, on the verge, stands in the cool shade of a beech, desaturated, blue-grey, out of the warmth. Her side of the road has no gold at all.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The Seated are clean. That is the first wrongness: collars pressed, what hair remains combed, no filth anywhere. Her son's cheeks have fallen to the teeth, the lips drawn back, skin the colour of weak tea stretched so tight over the breastbone that you can see the slow knock of the heart through it. His nails have grown thick and yellow as horn, curling round the handle of his fork like roots round a stone. Brother Hallow Crust's eyes are sunk into blue pits but wet, because a good host does not let a guest's eyes dry. Further down, a woman's grey hair has grown four feet long and down into the chair and through the weave of the cloth like a darn, binding her to the table. A loose tooth sits on a plate beside a fork. The lips of the oldest are split and white inside like bark. Steam rises off golden dishes: crackling, new peas, a pie crimped by a thumb. The air should look faintly thick, a shimmer of roast and of a thin sharp chemical sweetness like windfall apples.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Long Table runs nine miles down a valley road in the old heart of the Fast. It began, the Hostwatch think, as one table at a crossroads in the second century, and it has grown with every guest. About eleven thousand people sit at it, the newly sat flushed and chattering and eating with both hands, the oldest near the valley's head almost weightless, a smile hung between two cheekbones. They

are all happy. They are eating nothing. Their murmur is all praise. *Oh, this is lovely. Have you tried the. Pass the.*

On the first day of each season a few hundred Unfed walk the road from Wax Halt and stand on the verge to visit their Seated, because the road is not the table and the verge is not a chair. Sparing Lowe has visited her son on the sixth mile every season for thirty-one years. He has not known her for twenty. He is telling her, just now, that his mother used to make a dish like this one, and that he must remember to send for her. She is about to thank him, and say she is sure his mother would come if she could, and walk home.

Brother Hallow Crust, forty years at table, a Tablebreaker who sat down on purpose to see if he could get up, has turned his head toward Sparing and is about to tell her about the syllabub, with nutmeg grated over. He remembers every dish he has been served since 601 and cannot remember his wife's name. A Crumb-Runner's cart is passing far off down the road, at a trot, eyes on the ground, ears stopped with wax, because the Seated call everyone by name.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ The empty pulled-out chair in the distance sits a little further down the table than a pencilled mark on the milestone at the verge, where someone noted it last season.
- ◇ Sparing's own chair is laid opposite her: her name card faces the road, in her son's childhood handwriting.
- ◇ Brother Hallow Crust's sleeve is torn at the elbow where it was caught on an axe-haft, long ago, the only Tablebreaker mark left on him.
- ◇ Under the cloth near the far distance, two pairs of hands are clasped, and those two Seated are the only ones not looking toward the road.
- ◇ The table's lamps, followed into the distance, are lit in pairs, but every so often there is a single lamp lit for one more place than there are chairs.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly oil and ink, wide 3:1 cinematic composition, an endless banquet table running down a golden beech-lined valley road into the far distance, spotless white cloth, lamps lit in daylight, porcelain and silver, steaming golden food; both sides lined with impossibly emaciated, smiling, clean diners in pressed old-fashioned coats, cheeks hollowed to the teeth, horn-like curling yellow nails around forks, long grey hair grown into the cloth; the nearest a courteous wasted man, beside him an older skeletal man raising an empty fork; on the near verge in cold shadow, a thin old widow in a dark coat, hands folded, looking across the road; one empty chair pulled out far away; warm candle-gold light on the table only, desaturated cool shade elsewhere, dry-brush grit, dark calm road in the lower centre.

Negative: bright colours, cartoon, anime, gore, blood, filth, rot on the diners, zombies, horror-movie grimaces, clean digital gloss, modern objects, text artefacts, readable cards, children at the table, crowded foreground, lens flare

▼ THE EMPTY CHAIR



Every morning the plate is clean. Every night I lay it again. I don't call that worship. I call it manners.

SOBER OSMOND, VERGER OF THE EMPTY CHAIR

Plate: THE EMPTY CHAIR · *The last temple of the Host* · The Fast
· warm candle gold

THE SHOT

Interior, a wide lens on a low tripod height, at the foot of the great hall, looking up its whole length to the head of the table. The temple is a long low hall of honey-coloured stone with a slate roof carried on dark beams, built for a parish to eat together in. Down the centre runs a single great table the length of the hall, bare boards, dust-free, with hundreds of chairs along both sides all pushed in square. The left third is the long row of pushed-in chairs on one side, the stone wall above them carved with old bands of wheat and loaves, and deep tall windows letting in late gold light in long slanting shafts. The centre third is the far head of the table, where one place is laid on a white cloth folded over only that end: plate, cup, knife, fork, a loaf, a candle, and the chair at the head pulled out a hand's width. Standing beside it, bent to straighten the knife, is **Sober Osmond**, the Verger, old and thin, in a plain dark gown with a linen apron. The right third is the other row of chairs and, against the wall, an alcove where the Host's figure once stood in carved stone, now worn into an indistinct seated shape by touch, with a shelf of cracked old Host-bells. The background, behind the head of the table, is a great arched window full of the gold heartland: combed fields and smoke threads. The lower centre band is the near end of the long bare table, empty boards and dark floor, quiet.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The light is evening and enters from the west windows in long slanting shafts, **warm candle gold** in its purest form: honeyed on the stone, catching motes, laying bars across the dark table. The single candle at the head has just been lit and its flame is the brightest gold point in the frame. The laid place glows softly, as if lit from within. The rest of the hall, the far ends of the shafts, the pushed-in chairs, Osmond's gown, fall into deep honey-brown and then black. Osmond's face is warm on one side and grey on the other.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The honey stone is soft and worn smooth at shoulder height along every wall, where generations of a parish leaned at meals before the Refusal. The table boards are bare, with deep old knife-scores and a long worn trough down the middle from centuries of plates set down and lifted. The one plate is cream porcelain with a gold rim, and it is spotless, polished, as clean as it is every morning. The loaf is real Pantry oatcake on the plate's edge, grey and coarse and small, Osmond's own measure: he lays his own bread for the god and goes without. His hands are bone and liver-spotted skin, the joints swollen, the fingertips split from cold. His cheeks have fallen in; his neck is a cord of tendons. The alcove figure has been rubbed by palms until its face is gone and its lap is a smooth hollow dark with skin oils. Mouse droppings and dust are everywhere except on the table, which no dust will lie on.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

In the first century the Unfed pulled down every temple of Orrum in the Fast. This one, on a wooded rise six miles west of Wanting, was left, and nobody now remembers why. It was built to feed a whole parish at one table every feast day, and it is the last place on the Table where the Host was ever worshipped as a host is worshipped, with food.

It is kept by one man, Sober Osmond. Every night, against all law, he lays one place at the head of the table and lights one candle, and every morning he finds the plate clean. He does not know whether the god eats it. He does not think it matters. The Abstinents have condemned him eleven times. They have never sent anyone to stop him. Pilgrims and the curious walk out from Wanting to look, a quarter-day there, and stand at the door, and do not come in, and Osmond is always kind to them, which makes them leave faster.

The moment captured is the laying. Osmond has set down the plate and cup, lit the candle, and is straightening the knife so that it lies parallel to the table's edge, which is how the god likes it, he says, though he cannot say how he knows. He will go and sit on the floor by the door, on the cold stone, not on any chair. He will sleep there. In the morning he will come back up the hall and find the plate clean and the knife exactly where he set it, and the chair at the head pulled out a finger's width further than he left it. He will push it in. He will begin again.

The feeling of the place is hushed and warm and sad, like a family home after a death with the table still laid. It is the only room in the Fast where the Unfed's god is spoken to directly, and Osmond speaks to it the way you speak to someone old and lonely at the end of a long day.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ On the floor by the door is Osmond's bedroll and his own empty bowl, turned upside down, and someone has laid a folded napkin on top of it.
- ◇ The pushed-in chairs, counted down one side, are one more than down the other, and the extra chair is set back a little from the table, as for someone who was never expected to eat.
- ◇ One of the cracked Host-bells on the alcove shelf has been wrapped in wool, as Hostwatch trackers do now.
- ◇ The worn alcove figure's lap holds a small fresh crumb.
- ◇ In the great west window, among the far smoke threads, one rises from the rise itself, from this temple's own roof, which has no hearth lit.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly oil and ink, wide 3:1 cinematic interior, a long low hall of honey-coloured stone under dark beams, one immense bare wooden table running its full length with hundreds of chairs pushed in square; at the far head one place laid on a small white cloth, gold-rimmed plate, cup, coarse grey oatcake, single lit candle, chair pulled slightly out; a very thin old verger in dark gown and linen apron bending to straighten the knife; long slanting shafts of warm candle-gold evening light through tall west windows, dust motes; a worn faceless seated stone figure in a wall alcove with cracked bronze bells on a shelf; golden farmland through the arched end window; deep brown-black shadows, gritty dry-brush texture, dark empty table boards in the lower centre.

Negative: bright colours, stained glass, cartoon, anime, clean digital gloss, modern objects, text artefacts, crowds, priests in robes, visible god, gore, lavish feast, lens flare, cosy fantasy tavern

▼ THE PANTRY



Four months of grain. Six months of winter. You can pray about that or you can do the arithmetic. I have done the arithmetic.

MOTHER STINT AVERY, KEEPER OF THE PANTRY

Plate: THE PANTRY · *Four months of grain for six months of winter* · The Fast · warm candle gold

THE SHOT

Interior of the weighing-hall on the ground floor of the Pantry tower, a medium-wide lens at chest height across the scales. The hall is a round windowless vault of dressed stone with eight-foot walls, sacks banked to the ceiling. The left third is the iron hatch in the north wall, its shutter open on the blue dark of Pantry Close, and through it a sliver of the Ration Line: hands reaching, chits held out, faces cut by the iron frame. Beside the hatch a young clerk, **Hesitate Brune**, Night Lister, stands at a lectern copying names, his left shoe unlaced. The centre third is **Mother Stint Avery** at the great brass scales, older than Wanting, a cloth bundle balanced in one pan against iron weights in the other, her sleeves rolled to the elbow, forearms white with oat-dust, square and hard and still, saying a name aloud. The right third is the store itself, receding into dark: grain sacks stacked in courses, salt-fish casks, round cheeses on slatted shelves, and along the curving wall the ledgers, hundreds of spines back to 41 A.G. Pinned on a wall peg above the ledgers hangs a long stitched cloth, the letter to the Keeper from Avery Steading, unopened, its lines of stitching visible. Most shelves at the far end are already bare. The lower centre band is the stone floor in front of the scales, swept clean, in shadow, with only a few spilled oats.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

Inside it is warmer than anywhere else in Wanting, and it is not warm. The light is one hooded lamp hung over the scales, a dim yellow, and the frosty blue of the Close through the hatch. **Warm candle gold** appears only in the brass: the scale pans and beam catch the lamp and burn soft gold, the one rich thing in the room. A thin gold sheen also lies on the oats spilled on the floor. All else is dust-brown, sacking-beige, iron-black, and the cold blue of the hatch.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The air is thick with dust motes and the room smells, visibly, of sacking and mouse and faint oats. Sacks sag and split at their seams, mended with coarse thread; there are mouse-holes chewed and plugged with wire wool. Stint Avery's forearms are a stone-mason's, ridged with old tendon, her fingers ink-stained black at the tips, nails clipped to the quick. Her face is square, lined, colourless, the skin dry and flaking at the hairline, eyes with no expression at all. The hands at the hatch are the Fast's hands: blue at the nails, knuckle bones sharp, one with two fingers bound in a rag where they broke. Hesitate Brune is gaunt and young, his cheekbones like shelves, a pencil behind his ear. The ledgers' leather is cracked; the pages that show are columns of names, many struck through with a single straight line. The stitched cloth from the steading is grey wool with many hands' worth of uneven stitching, some lines in thread, some in what looks like hair.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Pantry is the best-guarded building in the Fast and its only true seat of government. A squat round tower of dressed stone in the middle of Wanting, five storeys, no windows below the fourth floor, one iron door that opens outward with three locks held by three different people. The Unfed grow nothing. Every mouthful they eat is bought from the Rim and carried in by Crumb-Runners, and stored here, and weighed out every morning by name, and recorded, back to 41 A.G. Every evening the Keeper reads out the next day's

list at the iron door. A name not on the list does not eat. The list is never explained.

Mother Stint Avery is sixty-two and has never given anyone a grain extra. She knows what nobody else has let themselves know: there are four months of grain for six months of winter. She has already decided which villages: the furthest, the oldest, the ones with fewest children. She has not told the Chair, because he would pray, and praying is a delay, and delay kills more. Her own village, Avery Steading, is on her list. The cloth on the peg is its yearly letter, every household stitching one line to tell the Keeper how they are. She has read it every year and never answered. This year she has not unpinned it.

The moment: she is weighing a bundle for a hamlet name and saying the name aloud, flatly, once. In a moment the clerk will write it. Hesitate Brune is copying the list for tonight's reading, and he has begun, very lightly, in pencil, to copy the names that are struck out, and to keep them in his shoe. Outside the hatch, the Line moves on. The feeling here is of an accountancy of hunger: cool, dry, dutiful, unbearable, and done by the only person in the Fast who will look at the sum.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ A scrap of paper pokes out of Hesitate's unlaced shoe, with one visible pencilled name: Avery.
- ◇ The iron weights on the scale do not match the bundle; the pan has been balanced with one weight too few, and it balances anyway, as if something light and kind was resting a finger on it.
- ◇ On a high bare shelf at the back, alone, stands a single sack that is not a Pantry sack: fine white linen, tied with a bow, never logged.
- ◇ The ledgers in the far dark have one spine in a different colour, newer and pale, labelled in no hand anyone uses, filed between 640 and 641.
- ◇ Among the hands at the hatch is one smooth, warm-coloured, unchapped hand holding out an empty chit, and no face behind it.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly oil and ink, wide 3:1 cinematic interior of a round windowless stone granary vault, grain sacks and casks banked to the ceiling, shelves of old cracked ledgers, many shelves bare; a square, hard, sixty-year-old woman in an oiled canvas apron, sleeves rolled, oat-dust on strong forearms, at great antique brass scales weighing a cloth bundle, expressionless; a gaunt young clerk at a lectern copying names by a hooded lamp; an iron hatch in the wall opening on a cold blue night queue with thin reaching hands; a long grey stitched cloth pinned on a peg; dust motes, sacking, mouse-holes; the brass glowing warm candle gold as the only rich colour; dust-brown and iron-black palette, dark calm floor in lower centre.

Negative: bright colours, abundance, golden grain heaps, cartoon, anime, clean digital gloss, modern objects, text artefacts,

readable writing, fantasy treasure room, crowds inside, lens flare, warm cosy mood

▼ THE RIM ROAD



Every land is certain that the cure is next door.

RIM ROAD SAYING

Plate: THE RIM ROAD · *Two thousand four hundred miles around a hole* · The Rim · warm candle gold, inner edge only

THE SHOT

A long lens from a slight rise on the outer ditch, at the height of a rider, looking along the road at Saltlick Cross at dusk in Lack, so that the highway curves away from right to left and keeps curving, the whole frame bent around the middle. The road is great fitted slabs of grey Oathen stone, cambered and wet. On its outer side is the drainage ditch; on its inner side, the Hem, a knee-high wall that does nothing and that nobody steps over. In the left third, the road bends away inward toward the horizon, with milestones at intervals and a Company caravan of covered wagons, small and lamplit, heading on clockwise. In the centre third is the crossroads: four stone posts each with a lamp, and in the middle of the crossing a black scorched square of salted ground. On it stands **Warden Corin Tallis** of the Rim Road Company, in a heavy oiled cloak, crossbow slung, on the night watch posted every night since 639 when a table was found laid there at dawn with eight places, steaming. He is facing inward, toward the Fast. In the right third, nearest, is a milestone carved with the Company's seven-spoked wheel, and beside it, crouched on the Hem side of the road, a Hostwatch tracker, **Spare Tolland**, holding a Host-bell wrapped in wool against his chest. Beyond the Hem, across the whole background, is the Fast: low golden fields under a sky that is still afternoon. Beyond the outer ditch is grey winter dusk. The lower centre band is the wet dark slabs of the road.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The frame is split by the Hem. The outer half, the world, is cold Lack dusk: wet bone-grey road, lead sky, pale lamp flames at the posts. The inner half, beyond the knee-high wall, is lit with **warm candle gold**, the Fast's unchanging early-Carving afternoon, low and rich, coming from the wrong direction. The gold spills a short way over the Hem onto the inner edge of the road slabs and stops in a clean line, like light under a door. The warden's face, turned inward, is gilded on one side.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The slabs are polished by centuries of iron tyres, grooved in two long ruts, puddled with rain, wheel-grease and dung. The Hem is lichened on its outer face and spotless on its inner face. The salted square at the crossing is crusted white over black char, and in the char are pale shapes: the burned outline of table legs, eight smaller marks for chairs, and the fused lumps of what were plates. Tallis's cloak is greasy wool beaded with rain, his gloves cracked, his face a Rim face, weathered, thick-necked, breath steaming, a week's stubble, eyes bloodshot from staring at a crossroads every night. Tolland is Unfed: gaunt, wax in his nostrils, tongue flat in his mouth, fingers wound white around the muffled bell, his coat pinned with tiny map pins. The milestone's carving is worn soft, but the wheel's seven spokes are clean-cut, freshly recut each year.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

The Rim Road is a ring of highway about two thousand four hundred miles long that runs around the border of the Fast, touching every land in turn. It was built in the Thin Years by caravaneers who wanted to carry Fatlands grain to every market on the Table without setting foot in the empty middle. Nobody crosses the middle. Everybody goes around. A wagon takes about a hundred days to make the full circuit.

The Rim Road Company owns the road, every inn and post on it, and every toll, and its law runs a bowshot either side: *Pay the toll. Keep the peace. Say the grace.* Here, on the Company's strip, a Sallowreach Closer and a Fast Reckoner can share a table. Every land's need of a neighbour it finds obscene moves along this road: meat, contracts, oil, brine, wire, mercenaries, and, under the Cage Toll, which the Company does not like discussed, closed carts of live cargo out of the Fast.

Saltlick Cross is where the old heartland road comes in straight toward Hallowboard and meets the ring. In 639 a table was laid in the middle of it overnight. The Company burned it and salted the ground and has posted a warden here every night since. They rotate weekly, and none of them will say what they see. Tonight it is Corin Tallis's sixth night. Spare Tolland has come out of the Fast along the heartland road at a run, and has crouched behind the milestone, because the bell he carries has begun to ring on the Rim side, at inns and crossings, in the night, and the trackers have started wrapping their bells in wool. The moment: the wrapped bell is ringing, muffled, and Tallis has heard it, and has not turned around. In a minute the caravan's last lamp will vanish around the curve, and the two men will be alone at the crossing in the last of the light.

HIDDEN DETAILS

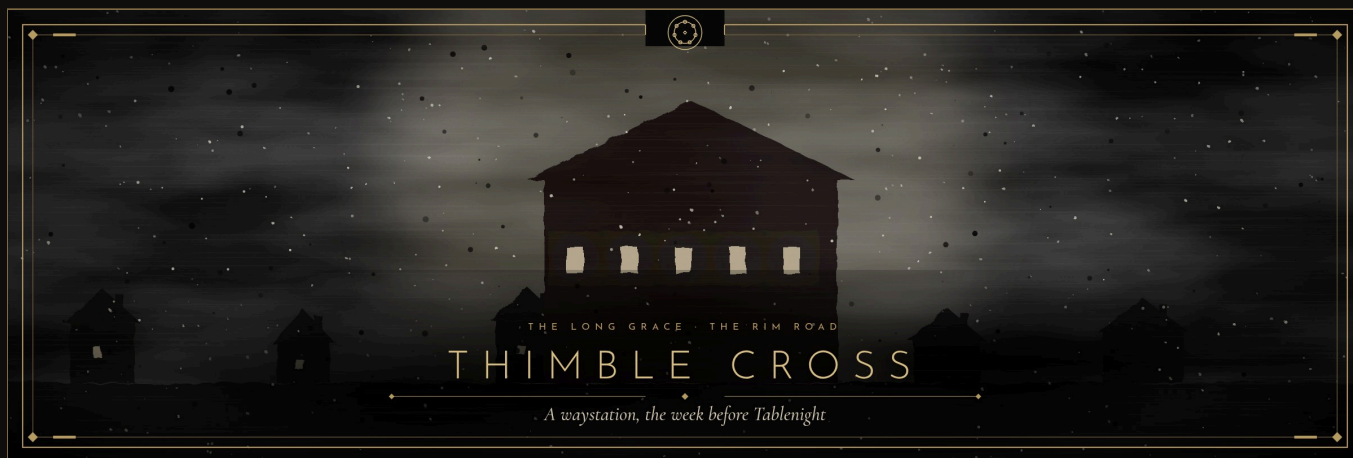
- ◇ The burned outline on the salted square has eight chair marks, but one of them is not scorched; it is a clean pale square, as if that chair had been lifted away before the fire.
- ◇ The milestone gives the distance to Company headquarters in both directions, and the two numbers do not add up to the full circuit; a few miles are missing.
- ◇ The caravan's last wagon has a closed cage-cart, and a thin hand rests on its bars.
- ◇ Just over the Hem, on the gold side, the grass is laid flat in a wide warm path running parallel to the road, as if something has started walking the Rim as well.
- ◇ On Tallis's belt is his ledger tally, notches for nights; beside his own six, someone has carved a seventh, neatly.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly oil and ink, wide 3:1 cinematic composition, a great curving highway of fitted wet grey stone slabs at winter dusk, a knee-high stone wall along its inner edge, outer drainage ditch; a crossroads marked by four lamp posts with a scorched, salt-crusted black square in its centre showing burned outlines of a table and chairs; a heavy-set warden in a greasy oiled cloak with a slung crossbow standing on it facing inward; a gaunt crouched tracker behind a carved milestone with a seven-spoked wheel, clutching a wool-wrapped bronze bell; distant lamplit covered wagons on the curve; beyond the low wall, golden fields in warm candle-gold afternoon light spilling to a clean line; outer world bone-grey and lead; gritty dry-brush, dark wet road in lower centre.

Negative: bright colours, sunny sky, cartoon, anime, clean digital gloss, modern roads, asphalt, cars, signage, text artefacts, readable numbers, visible god, a table standing intact, crowds, lens flare

▼ THIMBLE CROSS



◇
Nobody turned away.

CUT INTO THE PRICE SLATE AT THIMBLE CROSS
WITH A KNIFE

Plate: THIMBLE CROSS · *A waystation, the week before Tablenight*
· The Rim · warm candle gold

THE SHOT

A wide lens from the bend of the Rim Road, just outside the two boundary stones, at the height of a traveller on foot, looking at the inn across the marbled ground on the morning of Day Two in Lack 641. In the left third, the foreground is the road coming up out of the south between low hedges gone white, and the white is not snow: the ground is veined in branching rinds of fat, a hand deep, glossed, and flakes are falling from a dead-grey sky and settling without melting. One boundary stone stands at the edge, carved with the Company's wheel; behind it, the toll house with its bell, and in its lit doorway **Warden Josse Haverick** at the ledger lectern, pen raised. In the centre third, the inn: two storeys of grey fieldstone, slate roof, seventeen chimneys, only one of them smoking. On the front step, the door held wide, stands **Hepzibah Thimble**, the keeper's wife, small-chinned, pale-lashed, a strawberry mark at her throat, holding a spoon and a cloth, and saying welcome, as she must. Through the west window beside her, glimpsed, is the common room and a long dark polished table that was not there yesterday, its white cloth, its nine gold-rimmed plates. In the right third, the yard wall and, beyond it, the Hungry Lane running north into the Fast, its ground bare and warm-dark where it cuts the white, into gold. Far up the lane, at the edge of the light, is a single tall thin figure in a steward's coat, walking toward the inn. The lower centre band is the marbled yard ground before the step, smooth and pale grey in shadow.

LIGHT AND COLOUR

The Rim side is dead winter light: flat, grey, the fat-marbling the colour of tallow and old bone, the sky lead. Inside the inn the common room glows with **warm candle gold** from the long table's lamps and the steam of its bread, the first warmth in two days, pouring through the west window onto Hepzibah's shoulder. The other source of gold is the north, the Fast, where it is late afternoon in early Carving. The white stops at the edge of that light like a tide.

TEXTURE AND FLESH

The marbling is fat: pale, waxy, veined like the cut face of a ham, slick under the boots, climbing the boundary stone and the hedges in long white branches. The flakes on the hedges soften and spread and leave a sheen rather than melting. Hepzibah's right hand holds the spoon awkwardly: two fingers fold backwards to the wrist, healed that way since she barred the door once in her youth, the knuckles knotted and shiny. She has been polishing the spoon for an hour; it is worn through to the shape of her thumb. Her face is the Thimble face, the same as her husband's, the same as her children's, grey-eyed, too alike. Her apron is stiff with old dripping. Haverick's knuckles are raw from the cold, his face lined, a careful man's face. In the yard wall's gateway the corner of the convoy shows: oiled canvas over barrels, pink brine beading at the staves and freezing into soft white whorls. The little graveyard behind its low wall shows nine stones, and the marbling lies across the newest one, still sharp-edged and pale, and the earth there is disturbed.

THE STORY IN THE FRAME

Thimble Cross stands where the Rim Road, coming north out of the Fatlands, bends hard west to skirt a lobe of the Fast. It was founded in 402 by Hadley Thimble, a Crumb-Runner who had been spat on all her life by the people she fed, and who swore a charter in Oathen that the keepers of Thimble Cross shall turn no traveller away, nor refuse any guest, while the blood of Thimble endures. Promises sworn in Oathen follow the body. The Thimbles

cannot refuse anyone without their bones breaking to match. And because a Clausewright opined that a mixed line might be argued to have ended, the family has for five generations kept its blood narrow, at home. The register in the parlour says *Kept* after every name. Guests notice the family's sameness. Guests do not ask.

This is the week before Tablenight, the anniversary of the night six peoples ate their gods and one did not. A Renderers' Union convoy came in out of the warm country with forty-four barrels of salt pork, thirteen of them notched, and the white came with it up the road, and now the station is closed in. Last night a drover was taken in the yard, and the keeper Absalom went out to the little graveyard with a spade. This morning there is a fourth table in the common room, nine places, eight chairs pulled out a hand's width, a card at each place in the handwriting of someone the reader loved, and the bread is still steaming.

Hepzibah is standing on the step because someone is coming up the Hungry Lane, and she cannot shut the door. Haverick has seen him too, and is writing the count, and the count is higher than it was at dusk. The tall figure on the lane is Welcome Ardent, the Host's steward, who usually lays a table a mile ahead of his master. This time the Host laid without him, and the ninth card has no name, in a hand that is not his. He is hurrying.

HIDDEN DETAILS

- ◇ Hadley Thimble's gravestone, at the back of the nine, carries the single carved word *Welcome*; the turf at its foot is broken open from beneath.
- ◇ Of the seventeen chimneys, the smoking one is above the common room, where no fire has been lit.
- ◇ The ninth chair at the far end of the long table, glimpsed through the window, is pushed in square with its back to the lamp, and there is no shadow under it.
- ◇ In the toll-house doorway, the last page of Haverick's ledger is already ruled, with one line written at the bottom and the date left blank.
- ◇ A small figure at an upstairs window is Dorcas Thimble, with a diagram of a skeleton pinned on the wall behind her and certain bones inked.
- ◇ Up the Hungry Lane, Ardent casts his shadow, and beside it, on the warm bare ground, is a second long shadow that no figure is casting.

PAINTER'S PROMPT

Dark painterly oil and ink, wide 3:1 cinematic composition, a lonely two-storey grey fieldstone coaching inn with seventeen chimneys, only one smoking, on a bending winter road; the ground and hedges veined thick with pale waxy fat-marbling like cut ham, soft unmelting flakes falling from a lead sky; a small pale-lashed woman in a stiff apron on the front step holding the door open, two fingers of one hand bent backwards, polishing a worn spoon; warm candle-gold light pouring from a west window revealing a long polished

table with nine gold-rimmed plates; a toll house with a bell and a careful warden at a ledger; a little walled graveyard of nine stones, one disturbed; a bare dark lane running north into golden fields with one tall thin figure approaching; tallow-white and bone palette, dark calm yard in lower centre.

Negative: bright colours, clean white snow, Christmas mood, cosy inn, cartoon, anime, clean digital gloss, modern objects, text artefacts, readable cards or signs, gore, sexualised figures, visible god, crowds, lens flare

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